

aid.

# Donor heart covers 20km in 16 minutes via green corridor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Noida

A journey that would ordinarily be measured in traffic signals and minutes was reduced to a race against time: A donor heart travelled nearly 20 kilometres from Hindon Airport in Ghaziabad to a hospital in Noida in just 16 minutes, as traffic police cleared the way for the ambulance carrying it.

The heart, donated by a woman in Chandigarh, was flown to Hindon Airport by air ambulance before being transported by road to Fortis Hospital in Sector 62, where it was successfully transplanted into a 62-year-old patient, officials said.

Noida DCP (Traffic) Abhay Kumar Mishra said that the green corridor was created between Ghaziabad and Sector 62, with traffic regulated along the route to minimise interruptions on

September 9.

"A green corridor spanning approximately 20 kilometres was set up from Ghaziabad to Noida Sector 62. At 2 pm, the heart was transported from Hindon Airport by ambulance and, travelling by road, reached Fortis Hospital in Sector 62 in 16 minutes," Mishra said.

The episode illustrates the purpose of a green corridor: Temporarily coordinating and regulating traffic so an ambulance carrying an organ or critically ill patient can move through a city with as little delay as possible.

In organ transplantation, the significance is particularly acute because organs have a limited period of viability outside the donor's body.

But the September 9 journey was not an isolated instance in the National Capital Region. Noida, Ghaziabad, Delhi and neigh-



bouring cities have repeatedly coordinated such corridors in recent years, turning what was once an exceptional emergency response into an increasingly familiar part of time-critical medical logistics.

In August last year, Noida

traffic police created a six-kilometre green corridor from the DND Flyway to Child PGI in Sector 30 to facilitate the transfer of two premature twins. The ambulance reached the hospital in about four minutes, officials said.

The twins, a boy and a girl,

were born at 26 weeks at a private hospital in Delhi's Najafgarh and weighed around 700 grams each. They were in intensive care and suffering from severe respiratory and digestive complications, according to Child PGI officials.

On June 2, 2025, Noida, Ghaziabad and Delhi authorities coordinated a 17-kilometre corridor from Yashoda Hospital to Fortis Escorts Hospital, enabling a live donor heart to be transported in 19 minutes.

On January 8, 2025, Noida and Faridabad police coordinated a 46.4-kilometre corridor between Amrita Hospital in Faridabad and Yatharth Hospital in Greater Noida for the transportation of a kidney. The distance was covered in 24 minutes and 40 seconds.

The use of such corridors in the region also predates these recent cases.

On October 1, 2021, traffic police created a 14-kilometre corridor from the Delhi-Noida Chilla border to Jaypee Hospital in Sector 128, allowing an ambulance carrying a harvested organ to cover the stretch in 14 minutes.

A separate corridor was also deployed that day between Sector 14-A and Jaypee Hospital for another organ-transplant-related emergency.

For healthcare professionals, the value of a green corridor extends beyond spectacularly short travel times. It is about removing avoidable delays at a point when the medical clock is already running. Dr PN Arora, chairman and managing director of Yashoda Group of Hospitals, said green corridors could be "invaluable" when every minute matters, particularly during organ transportation and other time-critical emergencies.

He said their effectiveness depended on coordination between hospitals, police and traffic authorities, ambulance teams, airport authorities where required and transplant coordinators.

Pre-planning and regular drills could further help identify delays and improve responses before an actual emergency, Arora said, adding that drivers also needed greater awareness about why traffic was being cleared for such journeys.

The repeated green corridors across Noida and its neighbouring cities point to a broader challenge: In a densely populated and heavily trafficked urban region, medical emergencies do not wait for traffic to clear.

A green corridor does not create additional medical resources or change the condition of a patient. What it can do is remove one variable — the time lost on the road. For a heart waiting to be transplanted, a critically ill newborn or a patient being rushed to specialised cardiac care, that lost time can be crucial.

## DMIL to make global debut at InnoTrans 2026 in Berlin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro International Limited (DMIL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), will make its global debut at InnoTrans 2026 in Berlin, taking its mobility expertise and experience to an international audience.

InnoTrans, the world's largest trade fair for the rail transport industry, is held every two years in Berlin, Germany. Through its participation, DMIL will showcase its capabilities across operations and maintenance, consultancy, project management and advisory services, while engaging with transit authorities, infrastructure companies, technology providers, operators and other mobility stakeholders to explore partnerships across the global urban transport ecosystem.

DMIL Chief Executive Officer Sanjay Jamuar said InnoTrans 2026 provides an important platform to showcase the expertise of DMRC and DMIL on the global stage. "It will help us engage with transit authorities, infrastructure partners and mobility leaders from across the world. Cities are looking for integrated, flexible and future-ready mobility solu-



tions. We see an opportunity to take our engineering expertise and real-world operational experience to international markets. Through DMIL, we aim to build meaningful collaborations. We also seek to learn from global best practices and contribute to efficient and sustainable urban transport systems," Jamuar said.

DMIL focuses on delivering operations and maintenance, consultancy, project management and advisory services for metro, rail and urban transit projects across India and international markets.

Delhi Metro stands among the world's leading metro systems, operating a network of over 416 kilometres with more than 300 stations and handling nearly 6.5 million pas-

senger boardings every day.

Leveraging the experience gained through planning, building and operating Delhi Metro, DMIL will support transit projects across their lifecycle, from feasibility studies and planning to implementation, testing, commissioning, operations, maintenance, asset management and capacity building. DMIL has submitted five international bids in the last three months, marking a significant start to its international business expansion.

The company is exploring opportunities in West Asia and select European markets, while evaluating opportunities in North America over time. Africa also remains on its watch list, with potential opportunities through part-

nerships with local companies and the Union Government.

At InnoTrans 2026, DMIL will be present at Hall 7.2C, Stand 240, where the team will showcase its capabilities and engage with Government agencies, infrastructure partners, funders, developers and other stakeholders.

The company will use the global platform to highlight its experience in delivering metro and urban transport solutions and explore opportunities for collaboration across international markets.

InnoTrans 2026 will provide DMIL with an opportunity to take its experience and capabilities to a global audience and build greater awareness of its expertise in metro and urban transport.

As cities worldwide seek to expand public transport networks and respond to evolving mobility needs, DMIL aims to work with international partners by bringing proven expertise, operational know-how and project delivery capabilities to transit projects across markets. The 2026 edition of InnoTrans will focus on technologies transforming rail transport, including autonomous public transport, cybersecurity, robotics, 3D printing and artificial intelligence.

## ICS calls for stronger cancer referral network

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Indian Cancer Society (ICS) has urged the expansion of cancer-care services to Tier 2, Tier 3 and Tier 4 cities and rural areas, with district hospitals taking a larger role in screening, early diagnosis, initial treatment and referral to specialised centres.

The appeal was made at ICS Delhi's annual seminar, "Bridging Innovation & Affordability in Cancer Care," which brought together public health experts, oncologists, hospital leaders, insurers and industry representatives.

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the chief guest, said healthcare must be accessible, available and affordable. Early detection, he added, is one of the most effective ways to reduce the cost of cancer care.

"A better referral system can ensure that patients enter the healthcare system early. The connection between primary healthcare, diagnostic services and specialised hospitals can make a significant difference," Sandhu said.

The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare estimates that cancer treatment is



available in only about 5 per cent of district hospitals, even though around 70 per cent of cancer patients live in rural areas.

ICS Chairperson Jyotsna Govil said affordability has remained central to the Society's 75-year mission. "Access to care should not become another burden for a patient who is already dealing with cancer," she said.

Experts backed a hub-and-spoke model. Prof. Ravi Mehrotra, former

Director of ICMR-NICPR, said basic diagnostics and initial care should be available closer to patients, with specialised centres handling advanced treatment. Professor Chintamani of Sir Ganga Ram Hospital said Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY is expanding access beyond major cities.

Vinay Subramanian of GSK said travel, food and related costs can account for about 60 per cent of a family's spending, leaving only 40 per cent

for treatment itself.

Early care at the district level could ease that burden. Dr Abhitabh Gupta of Ace Insurance Brokers and Dr PN Arora of Yashoda Hospitals stressed insurance outreach and greater transparency so that diagnosis does not become a financial crisis.

The seminar, part of ICS's 75th anniversary, also highlighted Cancer Sahyog, the Delhi branch's survivor-led support programme for patients and caregivers.

## 42-year-old property dealer killed, brother injured in Kalkaji building dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A 42-year-old property dealer was killed and his younger brother injured after a scuffle over an alleged property-related dispute between residents of a building in south-east Delhi's Kalkaji, police said on Sunday.

The police have detained three individuals, including two women, in connection with the incident that occurred

in the intervening night of September 19-20, they said.

The deceased was identified as Manjeet Singh alias Bunty, a resident of Kalkaji. He was involved in property dealing and lived with his wife, two children, mother, brother and sister, according to the police and his family.

Following an argument over construction work in the premises, an argument ensued between residents of the building's ground floor

and third floor, which escalated into a physical altercation, officials said.

Manjeet and his younger brother Dilbag Singh allegedly sustained injuries during the altercation and were taken to the AIIMS Trauma Centre, where Manjeet was declared dead, the police said. Dilbag was later discharged.

Family members alleged that during the altercation, several people surrounded Manjeet and assaulted him.



Police have registered a case of culpable homicide and detained three people, including two women, the officials said, adding that they are being questioned and further arrests may be made during the investigation.

Police are also examining CCTV footage from the building and surrounding areas to identify other people who may have been involved in the altercation.

According to police

sources, Manjeet had been getting construction work carried out at the building's ground floor. The flat was allegedly associated with his side in the property dispute.

An altercation ensued after residents of the third floor had objected to the construction work, following which several people surrounded Manjeet and assaulted him.

According to Dilbag, upon receiving information about the incident, he reached the

spot along with his sister and found his brother lying unconscious on the road outside the building. Dilbag alleged that when he tried to intervene and stop a woman who was present at the spot, he was also attacked.

He was allegedly pushed to the ground and assaulted by the people involved in the altercation, while his sister intervened and helped him get away from the attackers, according to the family.

### The Pioneer Classified

• LOST & FOUND •

**I, Geeta W/o Rajendra Kumar R/o R-543-544, Camp No-5 , Jwala Puri, Sunder Vihar, West Delhi, 110087, have lost my previous original GPA of my property No. JD-18E/C, 3rd Floor, Khirki Extension, New Delhi-110017 finder contact at: 8368536306.**

#### PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the General Public that my client Smt. Sudesh Sachdeva W/o Late Sh. K. K. Sachdeva, R/o N168, Panchsheel Park, New Delhi had earlier, vide a Public Notice published in the newspaper Indian Express and Jansatta dated 20.10.2021, declared that she had severed all relations with his son namely Deepak Sachdeva and his wife Smt. Himani Sachdeva @ Sangeeta Sachdeva and their sons Anchit Sachdeva and Salil Sachdeva and had also severed all her social relations from them due to their egotistic and quarrelsome attitude and behaviour and from her movable and immovable properties. My client hereby withdraws, cancels and revokes the aforesaid discontinuance/public notice dated 20.10.2021 with regard to her son Deepak Sachdeva with immediate effect. The above public notice shall remain effective on others included in that public notice. My client has restored and resumed all family relations with her son Deepak Sachdeva and shall have no objection to his dealing with the public in his individual capacity. The earlier declaration of discontinuance shall henceforth be treated as cancelled, withdrawn and having no effect whatsoever, to the extent of the declaration made therein. Accordingly, all concerned persons, authorities and members of the General Public are hereby informed that the aforesaid earlier discontinuance notice shall not be acted upon or relied upon for any purpose.

**K. S. Rana, (Advocate)**  
Delhi High Court,  
Chamber No. 672, Western Wing, Te Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054.

## Police probe extortion angle after firing at medical shop in Najafgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police are probing a possible extortion angle and the suspected involvement of a network linked to foreign-based gangster Kapil Sangwan after two masked men allegedly opened fire at a medical shop in south-west Delhi's Najafgarh, officials said on Sunday.

No one was injured in the firing that took place at a medical shop in Naya Bazar around 8.30 pm on Saturday, they said.

Shop owner Sanjay Rohilla, 51, told police that two men aged between 25 and 30 and covering their faces arrived outside his shop on a motorcycle.

One of the men got off the motorcycle and allegedly fired a shot towards the upper portion of the shop, following which both fled, police said, citing the shop owner.

Police teams reached the spot after receiving information about the incident and collected evidence as part of the investigation.

Police are examining footage from cameras installed around the medical shop and nearby roads to establish the route taken by the shooters.

The motorcycle's registration



details, if visible in the CCTV footage, will also be verified, they said. Police are also examining the circumstances behind the firing and the possible motive for targeting the medical shop.

According to preliminary information, police are probing whether the incident was linked to an extortion attempt and whether it was carried out at the behest of a network allegedly linked to gangster Sangwan alias Nandu.

However, police are yet to establish the extortion angle or the involvement of any particular gang in the incident.

Investigators are examining all possible angles and are also verifying whether the shop owner or his family had received any threat or extortion call before

the firing, officials said.

The firing has created panic in the Naya Bazar area.

A case has been registered under relevant sections, and multiple teams are working to identify and apprehend the accused, officials said.

Investigators are also questioning the shop owner and other persons who may have witnessed the incident.

The fact that the suspects covered their faces has made identification through CCTV footage an important part of the probe, police said.

Police are also examining whether the firing was intended as a warning or whether the accused had specifically targeted the medical shop owner.

The extortion connection is being verified through call records, previous complaints, threat inputs, and other evidence, officials said.

Police are also looking into the criminal background of people who may be connected with the incident and checking whether the firing bears any similarity to other recent incidents involving extortion threats in the area. Officials said no arrest has been made so far and efforts are underway to trace the two suspects.

## Bhoomi Pujan held for 26th Vishnu Avatar Ramleela at Shastri Park



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Vishnu Avatar Ramleela Committee in Shastri Park, Delhi, held the *Bhoomi Pujan* ceremony on Sunday for this year's Ramleela festival, marking the 26th edition of the event.

The ceremony took place at 10 am and was performed by committee president Thakur Prempal Singh and Kashi Agarwal, Chief Patron and

former president of the committee.

The event was attended by North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari, MLA Ajay Mahawar, and Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma. Also present were Jai Bhagwan Goyal, AAP leader Gaurav Sharma, Amit Kumar Sharma of NFL, Rekha Rani, Bijendra Pradhan, and BJP leader Thakur Vinod Jayas, along with several municipal councillors and local leaders.

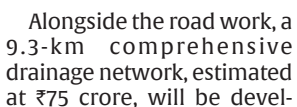
From the Ramleela Committee, those present included Chairman Harish Chaudhary, Chief Patron Naresh Agarwal, General Secretary Diwakar Pandey, Treasurer Upendra Pandey, Vice Presidents Anish Bansal and Tarun Garg, and stage anchors Rajinder Tiwari and Santosh Tandon.

Hundreds of residents from the area also attended the ceremony.

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
**■ New Delhi**

Under the plan, the entire 7.1-km stretch of Burari Road will be improved through three clearly defined sections. The Outer Ring Road to Baba Colony stretch will be developed as a bituminous road, forming part of a 3.2-km

A central verge will also be constructed along the entire 7.1-km stretch as part of the comprehensive plan.



oped to improve storm-water drainage and address water-logging concerns in the area. The drainage works will

cover the Amrit Vihar to Bengali Colony stretch, with drains planned on both sides of the road, and the

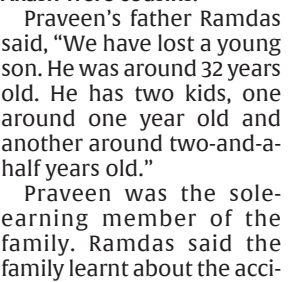
"From the Outer Ring Road through Baba Colony and Nathupura up to Hiranki, the road will be improved according to the requirements of each stretch, while drainage infrastructure will

Until road reconstruction work commences, regular water sprinkling will be undertaken along the affected stretches to control dust and provide relief to commuters and local residents. The integrated road and

With drainage work already tendered and road work set to follow within days, the project marks one of the larger integrated infrastructure interventions planned for Burari, aimed at resolving longstanding issues around road quality and waterlogging that residents in the area have faced along this stretch.

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
**■ New Delhi**

According to police, the workers were carrying out CCTV installation work at the time of the accident. Two of them were on the crane and were engaged in installing cameras, while others were near the autorickshaw and on the road. The impact was severe, and several workers sustained critical injuries. They were rushed to hospital, where four of them were declared dead during treatment, police said.

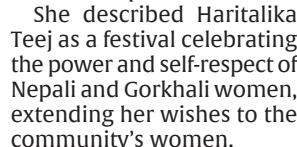


Brajesh said the family had been told that the workers had been engaged in installing CCTV cameras for the police for around six months. Another relative, Satish Kumar, said the family reached the spot after being informed about the accident and found the dumper there. "There was no safety where the work was hap-

The police are also examining the work arrangements at the site, including the deployment of workers and the safety measures in place when the CCTV installation was being carried out. The role of the company, if any, will be ascertained during the investigation, officials said.

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Extending her greetings on Haritalika Teej, the Chief Minister said the festival, associated with the penance



ated the contributions of

She said this was not merely an honour but a record of society's contributions, and offered congratulations and best wishes to the honoured personalities on behalf of the Delhi Government and the people of Delhi.

**RERA Registration Number : DLRERA2026P0006**  
 weblink: [https://rera.delhi.gov.in/registered\\_promoters\\_list](https://rera.delhi.gov.in/registered_promoters_list)



**Ministry of Housing  
and Urban Affairs**  
Government of India



**NBCC**  
*A Navratna CPSE*

# A GOLDEN OPPORTUNITY

— TO AN ADDRESS THAT MEANS BUSINESS —



Sale open through e-auction



Ready to Move-in Office Spaces



## Local Shopping Centre

📍 Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi

A rare opportunity to own commercial space in a landmark business address, offering one modern tower and premium amenities for future-ready enterprises.

### Key Highlights

 Close to Ring Road, Sarojini Nagar, Opposite WTC, New Delhi

 Walking Distance from Sarojini Nagar Metro Station (Pink Line) and AIIMS Metro Station (Yellow Line)

 IGI Airport - 17 km & New Delhi Railway Station - 12 km

 **Strategically Located**

 **Excellent Connectivity**

 **Sustainable & Modern Infrastructure**

 **GRIHA Compliant Building**

**Last Date of Submission of EMD**  
21.09.2026

**Date of e-auction**  
22.09.2026

**Hurry**

LIMITED INVENTORY AVAILABLE

**NO GST**

APPLICABLE ON SALE PRICE

RESERVE PRICE @

**₹39100/-** per sqft.



Scan for Location

**REDEVELOPMENT OF SAROJINI NAGAR BY : NBCC (INDIA) LIMITED**  
 (A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ENTERPRISE)  
 ON BEHALF OF : MINISTRY OF HOUSING AND URBAN AFFAIRS  
 CORPORATE OFFICE : NBCC BHAWAN, LODHI ROAD, NEW DELHI-110003  
 CIN-L74899DL1960GOI003335

Application form available at:  
 Website: [www.nbccindia.in/buyproperties](http://www.nbccindia.in/buyproperties)  
 Follow us on: [Facebook](#) /OfficialNBCC [Twitter](#) @OfficialNBCC



Scan to download Application form

**Call @ : 9899179426, 8168059012, 8527136569, 8527509652**

## IN FOCUS



A child looks at a python during a dog show, in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, Sunday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday claimed that 151 statues of Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar were damaged across 72 districts of Uttar Pradesh during the BJP rule, but only 14 arrests have been made so far.

He alleged that the vandalism was done deliberately because the BJP wanted to change the Constitution but failed to do so.

There was no immediate response from the BJP.

"Statues of Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar have been damaged the most. Under the BJP government, over 151 (Ambedkar statues) have been damaged or vandalised in 72 districts," Yadav told reporters at the party office in Lucknow.

"This was done deliberately because they (the BJP) wanted to change the Constitution but failed to do so. That is why whenever the BJP and those who share its ideology attack, the first thing they target is a hand-held copy of the Constitution," he said. He said the Samajwadi Party could track a total of 151 cases of vandalism of Ambedkar statues.

"In all, we have been able to document 151 cases. If we calculate the average, more than 15 statues were damaged annually under this government. There may be



Samajwadi Party National President Akhilesh Yadav addresses a press conference, at the party office, in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh on Sunday

PTI

undocumented and uncounted cases too," he said. Citing government figures, Yadav said arrests were made only in 14 cases.

In 45 instances, cases were registered against unknown persons. In eight instances, a named FIR was lodged. In 84 cases, no action was taken.

The BJP government neither respects Ambedkar, his statues, nor his people, Yadav said. Later, the Samajwadi Party posted a district-wise

## ABAS' Vishwa Shanti Yatra spans 30 cities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Akhil Bharatiya Adhyatmik Samiti (ABAS) organised the Vishwa Shanti Yatra 2026, bringing together more than 7,000 participants across 12 states and over 30 cities in a nationwide expression of unity, harmony and collective consciousness centred on the theme of peace.

According to organisers, the Yatra was not simply a journey across geographical boundaries but a journey across India's cultural, linguistic, social and spiritual diversity, bringing together different traditions, generations and communities under one shared message, "I Am Peace." At the heart of the movement was the central thought "Antarik Shanti Se Vishwa Shanti," meaning from inner peace to world peace.

## Yogi targets Ansari over remarks on Hindu right-wing communalism

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Noida

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday accused former vice president Mohammad Hamid Ansari of attempting to tarnish India's image, with his statements "disparaging India's Sanatan tradition and insulting its Hindu tradition".

Addressing the Prerna Vimarsh event at the Gautam Buddha University in Greater Noida, Adityanath said India's cultural traditions should not be viewed as a threat, referring to the "unfortunate statement" made by Ansari a day earlier.

The former vice president on Saturday cited former prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru's view that the "real danger to India was not



communism, but Hindu right-wing communalism" while speaking at an event in New Delhi commemorating late constitutional expert and author A G Noorani.

He was speaking at an event organised at the India Islamic Cultural Centre to commemorate Noorani and referred to his 2019 book "The RSS: A Menace to India". Adityanath said, "It does not befit us to refute it; however, his statements

were truly alarming regarding India's traditions and culture. An attempt was made to tarnish India's image. He made statements disparaging India's Sanatan tradition and insulting its Hindu tradition, and made malicious attempts to link it to terrorism."

"India is a secular state in the global context because it is a nation of Sanatan Dharma, with a majority of its people taking pride in their traditions, the lineage of sages, ancestors, deities and cultural heritage," he claimed without elaborating further.

The chief minister also targeted Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over what he dubbed as "jhooth ki goonj" event, alleging that it amounted to an insult to women.

## Electric shock kills two at Ganesh pandal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Mumbai

An eight-year-old girl and a woman were killed, while four others were injured after suffering electric shocks at a temporary drinking water stall near a Ganesh pandal in Mumbai's Lalbaug area early on Sunday, officials said.

The incident occurred apparently after a short circuit near the entrance gate of the Mahaganapati Utsav Mandal in Digvijay Mill Chawl (row tenement) on Dattaram Lad Marg in Kalachowki at 2.20 am, when the area was witnessing massive crowds during the ongoing Ganesh festival, they said.

Electric current was detected at a temporary drinking water and cold drink stall erected near the pandal entrance, the officials said. Following the inci-



Rescue personnel stand near a sealed area after an electrocution incident near a Ganapati pandal, at Lalbaug area, in Mumbai on Sunday

PTI

dent, fire brigade personnel immediately switched off the power supply at the spot, and the area was cordoned off as a precautionary measure.

Six persons who suffered electric shocks were rushed to nearby hospitals, where two of them were declared dead, the officials said.

A girl, identified as Raghini Ghanshyam Yadav (8), was declared brought dead at

Masina Hospital in Byculla. Three others -- Kiran Akbar Naik (19), Tanvi Naresh Hande (19), and Sahil Sandip Tare (19) -- were undergoing treatment at the hospital, and their condition was reported to be stable, a civic official said.

Two other persons were taken to Global Hospital in Parel, where a woman, identified as Sujata (33), was declared brought dead. A

minor girl, Ruhi Singh (12), was in a critical condition and admitted to the Intensive Care Unit (ICU), the official said.

Officials from Brihanmumbai Electric Supply and Transport (BEST) undertaking conducted a site inspection at the chawl, which indicated that a temporary electric meter was installed for illumination of the Ganesh festival celebration and the cold drink stall. Its wiring and MCB (miniature circuit breaker) were disconnected by a local electrician, officials said.

Meanwhile, in a statement issued on Sunday evening, Brihanmumbai Electric Supply and Transport (BEST) undertaking said that following the incident, its officials disconnected the power supply to temporary meter No. M-217392 installed at the Kalachowky Vibhag Sarvajani Utsav Mandal.

## BJP slams Rahul over Indore skit; Congress...

ABVP, the student wing of the BJP, won a majority of the DUSU posts in the recently concluded poll. "While PM Modi, in a thoughtful gesture, ensured a chair for an aged elder, in sharp contrast Rahul Gandhi was seen yesterday revelling when such elders were being shamelessly disrespected. Rahul Gandhi, who supports clowns and such crude circus shows, cannot be taken seriously as a political leader," the BJP spokesperson said.

Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi, in a social media post, said, "Rahul Gandhi and the Congress party have stooped to an absolute nadir of moral bankruptcy. Weaponising a student interaction to mock and insult the late mother of PM Modi reveals a shocking lack of basic human empathy and political culture."

Others who slammed Rahul included Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, who said the Congress leader's language was deteriorating "from bad to worse".

He described the remarks as a "stain on the dignity of Indian politics" and said such language was not representative of India, adding that people were closely observing the words, values and mindset of political leaders.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju posted on X: "Congress Party has become a Party of Comedians & Jokers! They are out forever.... RIP." Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, too, echoed the sentiment. "By laughing at the insult to a mother, Rahul Gandhi has laid bare his political upbringing before the entire nation. This prince of the Congress has fallen victim to mental bankruptcy-and this has once again made it clear to the whole country on his own," she said.

Union minister Piyush Goyal criticised Rahul's act, describing it as "cheap political theatre". In a post on X, he wrote, "The irony writes itself. The need to come on stage every now and then just to drag Prime Minister Modi ji's name into cheap political theatre never fails to amaze me."

Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis said Rahul Gandhi could consider "stand-up comedy" as a career. He said that the Congress leader had already left his political party "unemployed."

"I feel this is the only job left for Rahul Gandhi now. If Rahul Gandhi takes up the profession of a stand-up comedian and does mimicry there, he could secure very good employment. As for his political party, he has already rendered it unemployed," he said.

Other BJP leaders criticised Gandhi over what

they described as the "mocking and insulting" of PM Modi's late mother during the incident.

Opposition parties defended the mimicry, arguing that criticising the PM is part of democratic rights. Congress leader Raashid Alvi said the incident involved "mimicry and nothing else". He alleged that the "real insult" came from remarks PM Modi had made about senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi.

"Rahul Gandhi was only smiling and laughing, but Rahul Gandhi was not laughing alone. The entire crowd was laughing, especially the women who were present there. If a woman is being insulted, will women also laugh?" he said.

TMC MP Mahua Moitra said that it was not "crass humour" but a "long-awaited phenomenon". In a post, she wrote on X, "No, this is not crass humour. This is not immature behaviour. This is a much-needed long-awaited phenomenon. To fearlessly lampoon a PM is a democratic right long denied to Indians."

AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj said BJP leaders had themselves "made insulting remarks about Rahul Gandhi and his family".

## Ministers, MPs, bureaucrats get...

Other who recieved notices include Union Health Secretary Punya Salila, former Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi and his wife, former Delhi deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia, former Delhi minister Kailash Gahlot, Lok Sabha MP Bansuri Swaraj.

The Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi, on Sunday clarified that receiving a notice did not mean that a voter's name would be removed from the electoral roll. "System-generated notices are being issued to the above-mentioned categories to correct their data in ECINET. No name can be deleted without giving an opportunity of being heard and a proper, speaking and appealable order," the CEO said. "Therefore, there is no existential crisis as is being brought out in social and print media," he added. According to the CEO's latest press note, electors appearing in the draft roll have been categorised into those who have mapped or linked themselves, or their progeny entries, with electoral rolls of the last intensive revision and those who could not establish such a link.

Among the top bureaucrats who received discrepancies and no mapping notices are Fisheries Secretary Abhilaash Likh, his wife Sukriti Likh, also a serving secretary at the Department of Ex-

## FROM PAGE - 1

service Men's Welfare, Union Fertiliser Secretary Rajat Kumar Mishra, and Union Land Resources Secretary Narendra Bhooshan. They are among the people who remained "unmapped with the Last SIR". Election Commissioner Dr Sukhbir Singh Sandhu, was served a notice citing a mismatch in the spelling of his name in electoral records. The District Election Office, New Delhi has clarified that Sandhu's name has been verified. "The electoral entry pertaining to Dr SS Sandhu has already been validated and kept in the list for inclusion in the final electoral roll which is scheduled for official publication on November 4," it added. Sandhu's name is registered as an elector in Delhi Cantt.

Advani, 98, his daughter, Pratibha, and daughter-in-law, Geetika, have been issued notices after their names could not be mapped to the 2002 SIR electoral roll, while his son Jayant has cleared the mapping exercise. All four are voters in the New Delhi Assembly constituency. As a result, they will have to again establish their eligibility through documents from the 12 categories specified by the Election Commission of India (ECI). Jaishankar and his wife also featured in the list of voters issued notices during the SIR exercise. Their names were reportedly flagged because they could not be mapped to the previous SIR electoral roll. According to sources in the ECI, the poll body has received the required documents from Jaishankar and his wife following the issuance of notices. The submission of documents is part of the verification process under the ongoing electoral roll revision. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri has been listed under the "unmapped with the Last SIR" category.

Expenditure Secretary Vumlungmang Vualnam, Fertiliser Secretary Rajat Kumar Mishra and Land Resources Secretary Narendra Bhooshan have also received notices under the same category. Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) K Sanjay Murthy, a former IAS officer, has received a notice for "parent name mismatch". Several retired bureaucrats and officials have also received notices for discrepancies. Among them are former NITI Aayog vice-chairman Arvind Panagariya, former JNU vice-chancellor and UGC chairman Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar, former animal husbandry secretary Alka Upadhyay, former consumer affairs secretary Rohit Kumar Singh, his wife and former CISF director-general Nina Singh, former defence secretary Girdhar Aramane, and former environment secretary Leena Nandan.

Their names appear on the list of people for whom notices have been issued at the New Moti Bagh polling booth under the Delhi Cantt Assembly constituency, where most top bureaucrats have their official residences. In all, 593 people have received notices for reasons at the booth. Former Army chief General Upendra Dwivedi and his wife, former Supreme Court judge Ranjana Desai, her husband Prakash Desai, son and advocate Mike Desai, and daughter-in-law Sakshi Desai have also received notices after being classified as unmapped with the previous SIR records.

Former deputy CM Manish Sisodia, a voter in the New Delhi assembly constituency, was issued a notice, but the reason was not specified. His wife, Seema, and son, Meer, are also on the list. His wife has been flagged for a self-name mismatch, while Meer has been flagged for a parent-name mismatch.

Gahlot, former minister in the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government and presently a BJP MLA, was also flagged for no mapping. His wife Moushumi Mishra Gahlot and elder daughter Jahnvi Gahlot were also served notices for the same discrepancy. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal, former Union minister Kapil Sibal, Abhishek Manu Singhvi and Subramanian Swamy were among more than 3.16 million voters served notices for "discrepancies". Of the electors flagged by poll authorities, 1,379,785 were in the "no mapping" category and 1,933,134 were tagged as bearing "logical discrepancies". To be sure, the two categories account for 3,312,919 electors.

## Naxal commander killed in Varanasi

The officials stated that the bullets hit their bulletproof vests and both officers only suffered slight injuries. Police said over 50 cases are registered against Ganjhu; many date back to 1996 and were filed at various police stations in Chatra and other districts of Jharkhand. The accusations against Gandhu covered murder, an attempt to murder, kidnapping, extortion, criminal conspiracy, rioting, the illegal possession and use of arms, assault, damage to public property, and violations of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and the Criminal Law Amendment Act; furthermore, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) was carrying out prosecutions against him, including those relating to terror funding.

The Government of Jharkhand had set a

break-up on social media platform X. Citing media reports, the post said nine Ambedkar statues were attacked in Ballia; six in Azamgarh; five each in Mathura, Muzaffarnagar and Saharanpur; and four each in Ghazipur, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Prayagraj, Lucknow and Varanasi. Two statues were damaged in Gorakhpur, which stood 21st in the list.

The party said that in 85 per cent of cases, no police action was initiated on the "feudalistic anarchic elements". It said 46 Ambedkar statues were damaged during the first tenure of the Yogi Adityanath government, while 105 statues were vandalised during its second.

In a year-wise breakdown, the post said four statues were damaged in 2022, 12 in 2023, 13 in 2024, 29 in 2025 and 47 in 2026. Speaking to reporters at the party office, Yadav took a jibe at Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, saying, "Those who constantly talk about (Samajwadi Party bastion) Saifai should check the records; you will find that Gorakhpur saw the highest number of visits (from a chief minister). No other chief minister has visited his home district as frequently as he did."

Furthermore, there was an attempt to set a world record in Ayodhya, but funds meant for that purpose were embezzled, Yadav said. "Large-scale corruption took place in the construction of

the road connecting Ayodhya and Varanasi."

In reference to the BJP's ideology of Sanatan Dharma, the Samajwadi Party chief said, "The path of truth is Sanatan (eternal), the path of love is Sanatan, the path of brotherhood is Sanatan, and the path of honesty is Sanatan." "Ensuring that offerings made to Lord Shri Ram are not stolen: that is the path of Sanatan. Preventing theft of donations made to Lord Shri Ram: that is the path of Sanatan," he said, "Orchestrating a murder cannot be the path of Sanatan. Fabricating false charges cannot be the path of Sanatan." Yadav further claimed that exam papers were leaked in Uttar Pradesh seemingly to avoid the need to provide government jobs. "If one looks at where paper leaks occurred, Uttar Pradesh saw the highest number of incidents," he said. He said the state cannot prosper without goodwill and brotherhood. "Time and again, they (the BJP) have caused hurt and distressed people. They have actively worked to vitiate the atmosphere in Uttar Pradesh," he alleged.

"This is a government that is failing to deliver justice, a government whose own ministers are forced to stage sit-ins. Just think about having to protest for medical treatment and justice, or even to get a post-mortem done. That is the state of this government," he added.

## GRAPEVINE

### Don't mess it — SIR

Around 33 lakh people in Delhi got SIR show-cause notices from the Election Commission of India. The list includes former Deputy PM LK Advani, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, noted lawyer Kapil Sibal and former minister Subramanian Swamy already declared their intention of approaching Supreme Court. Latest news is majority of Supreme Court and Delhi High Court Judges and their wives also got notice from the ECI in Court for a mass show-cause notice.

## UPI's bell the cat!

Grapevine has it there was a huge arguments in India International Centre's Saturday lunch on UPI charges. Many bureaucrats told their Finance and Commerce Ministry counterparts that these extra charges will create public anger. Many feel these charges were demanded by the US to protect Master and Visa Cards. The question was who would alert political leadership, as a retired bureaucrat quipped, "Who can bell the cat?"

## Out of the blue

New Delhi's political corridors are buzzing over a quiet renovation at YSRCP's Central Delhi office. Sources close to the party say YS Jagan Mohan Reddy's outfit has put its own team to work after the reported break with the NDA – and the first casualty is colour. According to those familiar with the site, saffron curtains that had hung through the alliance phase are being taken down. In their place, planners are said to be lining up a blue interior, a visual reset that gossip circles are already reading as a political statement. Party insiders insist it is only a routine facelift. Rivals, of course, see symbolism: saffron fading as the Delhi equation changes.

# Defence production rising: Seth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Meerut (UP)

India has witnessed a significant increase in defence production and exports over the past decade and is now exporting defence equipment to several countries, Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth said on Sunday. Speaking after witnessing the Suryakiran air show here for the second consecutive day, Seth said the country's defence capabilities were being strengthened in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Swadeshi and Aatmanirbhar Bharat. Seth described the Indian Air Force's Suryakiran Aerobatic Team as the pride of the country and said the air show would inspire youngsters to join the armed forces. "Meerut's children should move towards defence. That is the thought behind this programme. When youngsters see these aircraft, they will think, why can't I



become an Air Force pilot and why can't I join the defence services?" he said. Referring to Meerut's association with the 1857 revolt, Seth said the city was a land of valour and such events would help inculcate a spirit of patriotism and service among the youth. He said the Suryakiran team had performed at around 800 locations across the world over nearly three decades and its aerial displays were inspiring youngsters. Seth said the goal of a developed India lay before

colours of the national flag. The team formed a Tricolour in the sky during the finale, drawing cheers, applause and slogans of "Bharat Mata Ki jai" and "Jai Hind" from the crowd. The two-day air show, held for the first time in Meerut, drew spectators, including students, NCC cadets and NSS volunteers. Three members of the Suryakiran team are from Meerut, including two pilots who took part in the aerial display. The team, established in 1996, is the only nine-aircraft aerobatic team in Asia and has performed at more than 800 air shows in India and abroad, including in China, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Singapore and the UAE. Fresh from its 2026 training season, the team unveiled a new formation in Meerut with nine red-and-white Hawk Mk-132 aircraft, performing manoeuvres including loops, barrel rolls, inverted flying and the 'DNA' formation.

# Noel Tata's double move: Solve ₹25,000 crore SP issue, save model



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Mumbai

Noel Tata is attempting a difficult balancing act: resolving a ₹25,000-crore-plus shareholder liquidity issue without compromising the century-old Tata model. That may be the most significant element of his strategy. At a Tata Sons board meeting, Noel Tata stood firm against listing Tata Sons while insisting that other lawful alternatives be examined. His position follows the unanimous decision taken in March 2024, under Ratan Tata's guidance, to keep Tata Sons unlisted. The principal Tata Trusts reaffirmed that position in 2025. But Noel Tata has not simply said "no." At the same time, he tabled an SP Group proposal that could potentially monetise part of its Tata Sons holding for at least ₹25,000 crore through a proposed two-tranche structure over 18 months, along with a selective capital reduction, subject to the required processes and approvals. He also proposed several possible funding avenues, including internal cash flows, monetisation of listed investments and bringing investors into newer businesses. The message is clear: solve the liquidity problem

without dismantling Tata Sons. That is where the argument for a "gold standard of governance" gains significance. Unlike a conventional promoter-controlled structure, Tata Sons is majority-owned by charitable trusts. Dividends from the group support hospitals, universities, research institutions and other public-purpose initiatives. Ironically, that public-purpose structure can also create additional regulatory and governance complexities. In May, an ex-parte direction from Maharashtra's Charity Commissioner required a meeting of Sir Ratan Tata Trust to be deferred. Tata Trusts said that no prior notice or hearing had been provided. That episode raises a broader governance question: does Tata sometimes face greater structural complexity precisely because generations of its wealth were placed in charitable trusteeship rather than ordinary promoter ownership? Noel Tata's approach appears to be to preserve that model while working within the law and exploring commercial solutions to the shareholder liquidity issue. The underlying principle is straightforward: protect value, protect trust and protect the institution.

# Hockey Odisha elections paused, electoral officer seeks advice

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Bhubaneswar/New Delhi

In what could come as a major setback to the Hockey Association of Odisha (HAO), the Electoral Officer appointed to oversee its elections has put the election process on hold, seeking guidance from Hockey India on serious questions relating to the constitution and governance of several district units. In a report submitted to the Hockey India President and Secretary General, sources said, Electoral Officer Anjani Kumar Mishra, IAS (Retd.), has raised questions over whether several permanent affiliated district units have governing bodies constituted through duly conducted, fair and democratic elections. The report, sources added, records that, in several districts, Collectors, District Magistrates, Additional District Magistrates and other administrative



officials have been shown as President and/or Secretary, in some cases as "Ex-Officio" office bearers. The report also notes that election proceedings and supporting documents have not been furnished in several cases. In a significant observation, the Electoral Officer says that the "documents presently received do not establish" for several district units that

their governing bodies were constituted through duly conducted elections in accordance with the applicable provisions. The report then raises a direct question over the electoral college, asking whether representatives nominated or authorised by such office bearers can be accepted in the final electoral roll without first establishing the legal and governance basis of their appointment. The Electoral Officer has specifically sought Hockey India's guidance on whether representatives authorised by ex-officio Presidents or Secretaries can form part of the final electoral roll, whether the appointment of government administrative officers as ex-officio office bearers is consistent with the HAO bylaws and Hockey India requirements, and whether the election can proceed while these issues remain unresolved.

**नरेन्द्र मोदी**  
प्रधानमंत्री

**रेखा गुप्ता**  
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

सत्यमेव जयते  
**दिल्ली सरकार**

# दिल्ली पीएम सूर्य घर मुफ्त बिजली योजना

# 3 kW तक का सोलर पैनल ₹0

# 3 kW से ऊपर ₹1,56,000 सब्सिडी

**पहले आओ**

**पहले पाओ**

**दिल्ली PM सूर्य घर योजना** के तहत मुफ्त सोलर पैनल लगवाएं, मुफ्त बिजली पाएं और हर महीने **₹300 से ₹2,400** तक की कमाई भी करें

**पंजीकरण शुरू:**  
21 सितंबर, 2026 से

**solar.delhi.gov.in**

पंजीकरण के लिए

QR कोड स्कैन करें

## States Focus



### JAISHANKAR TO LEAD INDIA AT UNGA, SPEAK ON SEPTEMBER 26

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will be leading the Indian delegation at the 81st Session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in New York, the MEA said on Sunday. His address at the high-level session of the UNGA is scheduled for September 26, the Ministry of External Affairs said.

"External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will be leading the Indian delegation for the High Level Week at the 81st Session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), New York, the USA," the MEA said in a statement.

During the visit, the EAM will also attend various plurilateral and bilateral meetings, it said. (PTI)



### INDIA MUST REJECT FRESH US TARIFF, SAYS ANAND SHARMA

India must reject the latest US tariff to defend its sovereign independence and hold off on signing of the "unequal" trade deal until the issues are resolved, Congress leader Anand Sharma said on Sunday.

In a statement, Sharma said the Lindsay Graham Act, a bill signed into legislation by US President Donald Trump, will have serious implications for India's energy security, economy and trade.

The Act that empowers Trump to impose 100 per cent tariffs on oil-buying countries is a matter of "grave concern," Sharma said.

The former commerce and industry minister said India is a major importer of Russian crude oil, accounting for over half of its crude petroleum imports this year, as the US-Israel attack on Iran caused a serious disruption of oil and gas supply globally and sent prices shooting up. "This unjustified action has serious implications for India's energy security, Economy and trade," he said. (PTI)

# Rahul slams Union Govt over hostel crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday hit out at the Modi Government over the issue of hostel facilities for students, asking why they are "forced to live in unsafe PGs", and also sought to know the status of the investigation into the Satya Niketan building collapse incident.

In a social media post, Gandhi shared pictures from the interaction he had on Saturday in Indore with the family of a student from Madhya Pradesh who died in the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi on September 6, in which seven people, including students, were killed.

Among those killed was 21-year-old Arpit Jai, a native of Dewas in Madhya Pradesh. Gandhi invited Jai's family on stage during his youth outreach programme 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' in Indore on Saturday.

In his post in Hindi on X on Sunday, the Congress leader said, "What was that innocent soul's fault? This is the question being asked, with tear-filled eyes, by the family that lost their son, Arpit Jai, in the Satya Niketan tragedy."

Had there been good, safe hostels, they would not have been forced to house their child in such a dangerous place, the leader of the opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

And had safety standards truly been adhered to, perhaps this tragedy, one



Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi addresses the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Indore, MP PTI

that neither the students nor their parents could have ever imagined, would never have occurred, he said.

The system's irresponsibility and corruption have snuffed out lives full of dreams and devastated families filled with hope,

Gandhi alleged.

"Like the rest of the country, Arpit's family is demanding accountability. They want responsibility to be fixed regarding the lives of students, ensuring that no other parent has to endure the pain of losing a child in

## West Bengal Congress cautious on Mamata support in bypolls

SAUGAR SENGUPTA  
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Congress is "neither very enthusiastic nor otherwise" following Mamata Trinamool Congress' support to its Nandigram candidate in the coming Assembly by-elections.

In a cautious response, the tri-colour "welcomed" Banerjee's support but reiterated "this one-off situation triggered by political compulsion does not throw open futuristic possibilities," as she has always been an "unreliable stick to lean on... So the Congress will have to carve out its own base before allowing others to hold its hands."

That was a significant remark from PCC member Soumya Banerjee, though PCC president and a traditionally pro-Mamata face in the Congress, Subhankar Sarkar said, "We welcome her decision which may open a new vista for future cooperation and coordination among the Opposition parties in West Bengal... After all, she has been an important ally in the INDIA alliance."

Banerjee's decision to



support the Congress candidate came after her own candidate Sanchita Pradhan Dey withdrew from the fray following a meeting with Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari. Banerjee alleged her nominee was threatened into withdrawing her candidature before saying that she would support the Congress.

Former State Congress president and senior leader Adhir Chowdhury, however, gave a cautious reply, saying Mamata Banerjee had come under the "Banyan tree" at a time when all other co-players had deserted her.

Chowdhury, who had no love lost for Banerjee and often held her responsible for his losing the

two halves between the two factions — one led by the former Bengal Chief Minister and the other by present Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee, who was now leading the Nationalist Trinamool Congress with an Envelope as a symbol. Mamata Banerjee's TMC is represented by a football as its symbol.

Meanwhile, close on the heels of the arrest of Milan Pradhan, the Congress candidate from Nandigram, an Independent candidate put up by Aam Janata Unnayan Party leader Humayun Kabir was arrested on charges of inciting group clashes. Officials from Berhampore police station arrested Saiful Islam in connection with a case dating back to the previous Assembly election, sources said.

Rejinagar too is going to October 6 by-elections, apart from Nandigram. While Nandigram was vacated by Suwendu Adhikari, who preferred to retain the other seat at Bhawanipore, where he defeated Mamata Banerjee, Rejinagar fell vacant after Kabir left it. He had won the Nawda seat also.

this manner," he said. "I have a direct question for the system: Why aren't new, safe hostels being built? Why are students forced to live in unsafe PGs? What is the status of the investigation into the Satya Niketan incident?" Gandhi said.

Earlier in the day, he also flagged the issue of lack of hostels for female students and sought answers from Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the problem being faced by them.

Gandhi cited the remarks by a female student during his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Indore to corner the Government. "The Government has money to light diyas — why not for our hostels?" This question was asked of me yesterday by a

female student in Indore. She came to the city from a village to study," he said, recalling the interaction.

"There's no hostel, so she has to stay in a PG. Just to stay safe, lakhs are spent. The worry of monthly rent, and the fear of becoming homeless - she has to study amidst all this," Gandhi said in his post in Hindi. Many girls drop out of their studies for this very reason - because there's no place to live, he said.

"And what about the housing allowance? It doesn't increase with inflation, and on top of that, it falls prey to corruption. Narendra Modi ji - Do you have any answer to that little girl's question?" the former Congress chief asked.

## CM Suwendu reaches out to Kurmis, drops agitation cases

SAUGAR SENGUPTA  
■ Kolkata

In a big tactical move that could, in the long run, bring the overwhelming Kurmi Adivasi population of Jangalmahal to his side, West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday announced the withdrawal of all cases against the community members who had earlier taken part in agitations demanding tribal status for themselves.

Accusing the previous Mamata Banerjee Government, Adhikari Government for remaining insensitive towards the 80 lakh odd members of the Kurmi community, he said, "The previous Government only divided you and exploited your sentiments, held out tall promises but did nothing ... But we will keep all the promises that had been mentioned in the Sankalpa Patra (election manifesto)." He was addressing a gigantic crowd at Purulia when he announced allocation of ₹50 crore for development projects, saying the land of Jangalmahal would not be allowed to be financial-



ly exploited without material development for the local people.

Adhikari also said that he would work towards including Kurmal and Rajbangshi languages of North Bengal in the 8th Schedule of the Constitution.

The Kurmis of Jangalmahal area had been demanding Adivasi status as la the Santhals, Mundas and Oraons, claiming themselves to be the "mool bhoot niwasis" (inhabitants of the soil). In the past few years, the Kurmi movement has seen prolonged disruption of rail and road traffic connecting Bengal and Jharkhand and other States.

## NIA arrests two key accused in PNB counterfeit currency case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested two key accused for alleged circulation of counterfeit currency notes through the Punjab National Bank currency chest in Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh, officials said on Sunday.

The accused have been identified as Mukesh Kumar and Rajendra Kumar, both from Saharanpur, they said.

Both accused are close associates of the arrested key accused Adesh Choudhary and are also key accused in the conspiracy relating to the circulation of counterfeit currency notes through the Punjab National Bank (PNB) currency chest, Civil Lines, Saharanpur, the



NIA said in a statement.

On August 29, Sadar Bazar police station, Saharanpur, received credible information regarding the recovery of counterfeit Indian currency notes with a face value of ₹17.29 crore from the currency chest of PNB.

The involvement of three employees of the bank surfaced during the inquiry, and

they were accordingly suspended by the bank.

The case was initially registered by the local police on August 29 and then re-registered by the NIA on September 3.

The central agency arrested FIR-named accused Amit Kumar and Adesh Choudhary on September 7 and 15, respectively.

## Nagaland's draft electoral roll excludes 1.59 lakh people

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Kohima

Nagaland's draft electoral roll was published on Sunday with nearly 1.59 lakh of the 13.57 lakh voters excluded from the pre-SIR list. The Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO's) office said the draft roll has 11.99 lakh names, with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise finding 29,944 electors from the previous list deceased, 1.23 lakh absent or permanently shifted, and 5,059 enrolled at multiple places.

The enumeration phase of the SIR of electoral rolls was held in the State from August 16 to September 14.

The CEO office said the absent/shifted/other category includes electors who



became voters in other States or Union Territories, could not be found, did not submit their forms by September 14, or were unwilling to register.

The claims and objections to the deletion of names from the electoral list can be submitted till October 20, it said.

The final electoral roll is scheduled for publication on November 22, while the notice phase and disposal of claims and objections will continue until November 18.

## Akal Takht expels former SGPC member Amarjit Singh Chawla from Khalsa Panth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Amritsar

The Akal Takht on Sunday expelled former Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee member Amarjit Singh Chawla and additional head granthi Giani Malkit Singh from the 'Khalsa Panth'.

The announcement came after a meeting of five Sikh head priests held at the secretariat of the Akal Takht, the highest temporal seat of Sikhs, on Sunday.

The development came days after SGPC member Chawla was booked on charges of rape, wrongful confinement and criminal intimidation in Anandpur Sahib, following a complaint by a woman. Following the registration of the FIR, Chawla resigned as SGPC



Akal Takht acting jathedar Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj, along with clergymen, pronounced the decree from the platform of the highest Sikh temporal seat in Amritsar on Sunday

member and as senior vice president of the Shiromani Akali Dal.

Chawla, however, had denied the allegations as false and fabricated.

The meeting was attended by the five Sikh head priests — Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj, Akal Takht Jathedar, Giani Kewal Singh, priest at the Golden Temple, Gurbaksh Singh, priest at the Akal Takht, Tek Singh,

Jathedar of Takht Damdama Sahib and Mangal Singh, a member of the Panj Pirara group of Akal Takht.

The Jathedar (head priest) expelled Chawla from the Sikh fold for his alleged violation of Sikh tenets.

He also directed the Sikh community to maintain distance from him and not allow him to take part in any religious activity in any of the Sikh institutions.

## J&K LG Sinha lays stone for Purmandal, Uttervehini revival

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jammu

The Lieutenant Governor, Manoj Sinha, on Sunday laid the foundation stones for projects aimed at the renovation, restoration and revival of the ancient heritage of Purmandal, worth ₹7.15 crore, and for renovation, restoration and related development works at the sacred Uttervehini site, worth ₹6.85 crore.

Addressing the gathering on the occasion, the Lieutenant Governor said the initiative was not merely about repairing bricks and stones, but about reconnecting the nation's glorious past with a radiant future.

Referring to India's cultural ethos, the Lieutenant Governor noted that the preservation of history, sacred knowledge and values rooted in Dharma serves as the lifeline of a nation.



J&K LG Manoj Sinha during the foundation stone laying ceremony of Mata Lalleshwari Cultural & Heritage Centre at Mata Bhaderkali Temple in Jammu on Saturday PTI

"A nation that forgets its heritage loses its foundation. But a nation that respects, preserves and revives its roots ensures that its future generations stand with confidence, resilience, self-belief and a strong sense of identity," the Lieutenant Governor said.

The Lieutenant Governor observed that Purmandal,

blessed by the sacred Devika River, has for centuries been a site visited by saints, sages and spiritual seekers, and that its ancient temples, stone carvings, sacred ponds and historical structures reflect outstanding architectural and artistic achievement, much of which had diminished by time and neglect.

## Opposition sets sights on J&K Govt in Assembly session

MOHIT KANDHARI  
■ Jammu

The working of the nearly two-year-old Omar Abdullah-led National Conference Government will come under sharp scrutiny from Opposition parties when the Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly convenes its autumn session on Monday, in Srinagar.

To counter the Opposition benches, the ruling party legislators attended a brainstorming session with the top brass of the party and chalked out their floor strategy on Sunday.

JKNC vice president and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah also attended the meeting, chaired by party supremo Farooq Abdullah. Alliance partner Congress also joined the deliberations as part of preparations for the forthcoming session.

The ruling party legislators discussed the legislative business expected to come up during the session, along with various issues of public importance, including public welfare, development and governance.

Farooq Abdullah called upon the



Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly

legislators to maintain close coordination and ensure that the concerns and aspirations of the people are effectively raised in the House.

Ahead of the session, Leader of the Opposition, Sunil Sharma, said the Omar Abdullah Government has "failed on all fronts." During a series

of public outreach programmes in the valley, Sharma interacted with the common masses and listed out their grievances to be raised during the Autumn session.

He said they will raise the issue of outsourcing of Government jobs, alleged corruption, delay in panchayat and urban local body elections, the electricity tariff hike, and unfulfilled manifesto commitments. PDP has listed unemployment, job outsourcing, reservation policy, and regularisation of daily wagers as its priorities during the upcoming session.

Jammu and Kashmir Pradesh Congress Committee (JKPCC) president and MLA Tariq Hameed Karra on Sunday said the Congress would continue to raise people's genuine concerns in the Assembly despite being in an alliance with the National Conference (NC).

"We are in alliance with the National Conference, but that does not mean we will not raise public issues. We will take up genuine concerns and ensure they are expedited," Karra said, speaking with reporters in Srinagar, after a meeting of Congress legislators ahead of the upcoming Assembly session.

# Uttarakhand CM expands probe into fake MBBS quota certificates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Dehradun

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami on Saturday ordered the investigation to be expanded to include other reserved-category candidates in connection with an ongoing probe into allegations that students used fraudulent certificates to secure admissions in State medical colleges.

The order comes after allegations surfaced that students used fraudulent permanent residence and freedom fighter dependent certificates during the State-level NEET-UG counselling. According to a statement issued by the chief minister's office (CMO), authorities will now inspect and verify documents submitted across all reserved categories.

If any certificate is found to be fake during the investigation, it will be cancelled, and strict action will be taken against those respon-



Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami

sible, it said. Officials said the initial complaints involved forged freedom fighter dependent certificates, but growing suspicions regarding potential document fraud in other reservation categories prompted the decision to broaden the

scope of the probe.

The CMO confirmed that the certificates of eight candidates have been revoked, resulting in the annulment of their admission processes.

Dhami has also directed investigators to uncover how these fake documents were

issued and identify the perpetrators. He emphasised that any Government official or employee found complicit in the alleged racket will face severe disciplinary and legal consequences. "The crime of securing admission through fake certificates is as serious as the offence of cheating in exams. As soon as the matter came to light, officials were instructed to conduct a transparent investigation and take action. Expanding the scope of the inquiry, certificates from all categories will now be examined. Strict action will be taken against anyone found guilty," Chief Minister Dhami said.

He stressed that to prevent future occurrences, document verification protocols across the state will be made significantly more stringent.

Earlier, Medical Education Minister Subodh Uniyal directed the Dehradun district magistrate to conduct an inquiry and submit a report within a week.

## Over 200 taluks likely to be declared drought-hit in Karnataka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Davanagere (Karnataka)

More than 200 taluks across Karnataka are likely to be included in the drought-affected list as the Government assesses them in phases based on prescribed criteria and ground-truthing, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Sunday. He said 101 taluks were declared drought-affected in the first phase, followed by another 24. An additional 52 taluks are expected to be declared drought-affected in the next three to four days. In the subsequent phase, ground-truthing will be undertaken in around 50 more taluks before a decision is taken based on the assessment, he added.

"Based on the data available now, more than 200 taluks across the state are likely to be included in the drought-affected list," Parameshwara, who holds the Revenue portfolio, told reporters. He said the situation would continue to be reviewed until the end of the monsoon season. Taluks such as Jagalur, which have not yet been included, could also be declared drought-affected in subsequent phases if they meet the prescribed criteria.

"People need not be anxious if their taluk has not yet been included in the list," he said. Parameshwara said a three-day Special Session of the State legislature has been convened to



Karnataka Deputy CM G Parameshwara

discuss the drought situation and the Kasturirangan report on Western Ghats ecologically sensitive areas.

The losses caused by drought, assistance to farmers and the relief sought from the Union Government will be discussed during the session, while the views of the Opposition will also be taken into consideration, he said.

Discussions will also be held on seeking drought relief and a waiver of farmers' loans from the Centre. The State Government intends to take the Opposition into confidence and present Karnataka's demands before the Union Government, he said.

An estimated loss of around ₹18,000 crore has been reported in the 101 taluks declared drought-affected in

the first phase, and the State has sought around ₹3,500 crore from the Union Government as relief, the Deputy CM said. The amount was sought as part of the first memorandum. The Government will submit second and third memoranda incorporating losses in taluks declared drought-affected in subsequent phases, he said.

Last year, Karnataka suffered estimated losses of around ₹39,000 crore and sought ₹18,000 crore in relief from the Centre. However, the state received only about ₹3,400 crore, he said.

In view of the severe distress faced by farmers, the Union Government should consider measures to support farmers across the country, Parameshwara said. Referring to the farm loan waiver announced during the tenure of former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, he said the State Government would also urge the Centre to waive farmers' loans this time. Karnataka is not receiving its due share, and funds under various schemes are not being released adequately by the Union Government, Parameshwara alleged. "Karnataka is yet to receive around ₹17,000 crore under the Jal Jeevan Mission," he said, alleging that the Centre was adopting a "step-motherly attitude" towards the State. He said the State Government would place its demands before the Centre after taking the Opposition into confidence.

## IIT Bombay student death: Crime Branch may summon professor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Mumbai

The Crime Branch, which has taken over the probe into the alleged suicide of a 22-year-old IIT Bombay student, is likely to summon a professor from the premier institute and others for questioning, officials said on Sunday.

The professor has been named as an accused in the case, which will be handled by the Assistant Commissioner of Police (Detection), they said.

Sahil Ravindra Wakode was found hanging from the ceiling fan in his room in Hostel Number 4 on the Powai campus of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay on Friday evening, hours after he was allegedly caught using a mobile phone and ChatGPT during a mid-semester examination, they said. Wakode, a native of Maharashtra's Yavatmal district, was a second-year BTech student in the Energy Science and Engineering department.

The Powai police on Saturday registered a First Information Report (FIR) under Section 108 (abetment of suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention



Students stage a protest following the death of a 22-year-old IIT Bombay student who died by suicide in Mumbai on Saturday

of Atrocities) Act based on a complaint filed by the student's parents.

The family has alleged that Wakode was subjected to institutional harassment and caste-based discrimination before he took the extreme step, which triggered a protest by students on the campus. The protesters claimed that Wakode faced severe pressure and threats of academic suspension.

The case was transferred to the Crime Branch on Saturday night. The Crime Branch is likely to summon the accused professor and others for questioning, an official said.

According to a statement from IIT Bombay, the student had allegedly uploaded the examination question paper

to ChatGPT to seek answers during the exam. However, no disciplinary action was initiated against him, it said.

The instructor and the Head of the Department had discussed the matter with the student and counselled him, assuring him the incident would not adversely affect his academic career, it said.

He subsequently returned to his hostel room and was found dead later in the evening, it said. This is the third reported case of suicide on the IIT Bombay campus in seven months. In February, a second-year student died by suicide in a hostel. In July, at the beginning of the new semester, a 20-year-old second-year BTech student had also ended his life.

## Satish Salian's notice to Aaditya for publicity: Raut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Mumbai

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut said on Sunday that the death of celebrity manager Disha Salian was unfortunate, but her father Satish Salian's bid to hand over a defamation notice to Aaditya Thackeray was an attempt to gain publicity.

Talking to reporters, Raut said the Sena (UBT) is pained over the loss of life of Disha Salian. "It was an unfortunate incident. It is the misfortune of that girl that her father created a scene. That's not pain," he said.

Satish Salian on Saturday visited Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray's resi-



Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut

dence 'Matoshri' here to hand over a ₹500-crore defamation notice to his son and former Maharashtra minister Aaditya Thackeray. Referring to the CBI probe, Raut said the court has given some instructions, and those should be followed.

"It is very cheap the way you came to Matoshri for publicity," Raut said. He claimed the Sena (UBT) is well aware of who is behind all this. This is happening because of "some drunkard with a Nepal connection", he said without elab-

## Jan Suraaj Party announces 5 candidates for Bihar MLC polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Patna

Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor on Sunday announced candidates for five constituencies of the Bihar Legislative Council, where elections are likely to be announced soon. Elections are to be held for a total of eight constituencies — four graduates' and teachers' seats each — terms of which expire in November. Addressing a press conference, Kishor declared the names of five candidates, including Afaq Ahmed, who will seek re-election from Saran teachers' con-



Jan Suraaj Party founder Prashant Kishor

stituency, which he had won six years ago with the support of the former poll strategist, who had not yet to float his party. Kishor said the names of candidates of three other seats will be announced within the next three to four days. Kishor, the MLA of Bankipur Assembly seat, said JSP would seek to bring together various teachers' organisations and form a joint struggle committee to pursue their demands.

He said the party would campaign for three key demands — implementation of the recommendations of the Seventh Pay Commission for teachers, bringing educators from aided

institutions into the regular teachers' category, and setting norms for assigning non-academic duties to teachers. Kishor said these would be treated as demands of Jan Suraaj and claimed that the party would work with teachers to pressurise the Government to fulfill these before the next Lok Sabha elections. Addressing graduate constituency voters, Kishor also promised that if JSP candidates win, 10,000 jobs would be facilitated for unemployed graduates in each graduate constituency, similar to a job-related promise he had made to educated unemployed voters in his Bankipur constituency.

## Protests in Manipur's Kangpokpi over detention of 7 Kuki villagers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Imphal/ Kangpokpi

Violent protests erupted in Manipur's Kangpokpi district over the alleged detention of seven Kuki villagers by security forces, with agitators blocking roads and pelting stones at Government vehicles, officials said on Sunday.

The protests continued from around 10 pm on Saturday till midnight in Motbung and nearby areas, during which agitators allegedly burnt tyres on roads and pelted stones at Government vehicles, they said. The protesters claimed that the seven villagers from Kholen were detained by security forces without being given any reason. Kholen,

located close to the Naga-dominated Chawangking village in the district, had recently come under attack by armed miscreants.

Security forces fired several rounds of tear gas shells to disperse the protesters, who also allegedly dug up portions of National Highway-2 (Imphal-Dimapur) at Motbung using heavy construction equipment to prevent security forces' vehicles from moving, officials said. A few protesters suffered injuries during the agitation and were admitted to a local hospital, they said.

A senior official said the seven village volunteers were subsequently released by the security forces, following which the protest ended.



Security forces

FILE PHOTO

"The situation in the district is under control now," the official said.

The Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), the apex body of the Kuki community, meanwhile, condemned the detention of the seven vil-

lagers by the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF).

In a statement, KIM accused authorities of failing to take adequate action against those responsible for the killing of Kuki women by armed miscreants while

detaining local civilians.

KIM described the detention as a "serious failure of law enforcement" and called for immediate action and accountability. It also alleged that security forces used force against civilians who were peacefully protesting for their rights and security. It also claimed that live rounds were fired and vehicles were vandalised during the incident.

Meanwhile, reacting to the release of detained village volunteers, members of a women's organisation in Kakching district, Langmeidong Apunba Meira Paibi, staged a sit-in at Langmeidong demanding the release of all arrested Meitei village volunteers.

## AIADMK slams TN minister over law and order, dengue outbreak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Madurai (TN)

AIADMK leader RB Udhayakumar accused Minister Aadhav Arjuna of "political arrogance" and "attempting to divert public attention" from Tamil Nadu's deteriorating law and order situation and dengue outbreak.

Addressing a gathering, Udhayakumar claimed the ongoing debate over the Prime Ministerial face of the TVK-Congress alliance was a "calculated distraction".

"The boxing match between TVK and Congress over whether Vijay or Rahul



AIADMK leader RB Udhayakumar

Gandhi is the Prime Ministerial candidate is creating more flutter than the dengue fever panic or the law and order incidents," Udhayakumar said.

"In a single day, 253 people were affected by dengue in Tamil Nadu. Along with three

murders in Madurai, eight people have been murdered across the state in 24 hours," he added, stating, "Perhaps, TVK is deliberately spreading this to divert attention".

Criticising the newly formed TVK-led 'Secular Social Justice Victory Alliance', which includes parties like the Congress, VCK, and MDMK, the former minister said the coalition is facing an impending collapse due to the Prime Ministerial candidate controversy. Udhayakumar strongly condemned Arjuna for recently questioning why a leader from southern Tamil Nadu

## Air chiefs of India, Japan fly in Tejas in bilateral air exercise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jodhpur

IAF Chief Air Chief Marshal AP Singh and his Japanese counterpart Gen Takehiro Morita on Sunday flew in separate Tejas jets, India's homegrown fighter aircraft, as part of a formation sortie during an ongoing bilateral air exercise in Rajasthan's Jodhpur.

While Air Chief Marshal Singh flew solo in a Tejas fighter jet, the Chief of Staff of the Japan Air Self-Defense Force (JASDF) "flew in a Tejas (trainer aircraft) along with an IAF pilot who is commanding a Tejas unit", a senior official

said. The "Tejas formation sortie" was undertaken by the two chiefs during the India-Japan air exercise 'Veer Guardian' and lasted about 20-25 minutes, the official said. Air Chief Marshal Singh, who led the formation sortie, said that the JASDF chief's decision to fly in Tejas is "a very clear example" of his trust in the country's homegrown aircraft. Gen Morita flew in the trainer aircraft, with the IAF pilot as the captain. The formation flew over the airfield and subsequently carried out a peel-off manoeuvre for landing, the senior official cited above said.

'Veer Guardian' is the

second bilateral exercise between the IAF and JASDF, also known as Koku Jieitai.

Exercise Shinyuu Maitri, the first bilateral air exercise involving the two air forces, was held in 2018 in India.

The two air chiefs later addressed the media and shared the significance of such exercises in building interoperability and strengthening defence partnership between India and Japan. India's Tejas and Japan's F-2A fighter aircraft, parked on the runway, formed the backdrop. Gen Morita said, "Air Chief Marshal Singh, it is a privilege to be with you today, and I would like to



Tejas

FILE PHOTO

show my appreciation for your warm welcome and hospitality. I am deeply grateful for the invaluable opportunity to fly in the Tejas. As an

aircraft born from indigenous defence capabilities, Tejas stands as a symbol of India's technological innovation and embodies the

Make in India initiative."

He said that during the sortie, he reflected on the efforts of many people, both in the military and industry, who have contributed to the development of this fighter jet. "Through this experience on board, I gained a first-hand appreciation of the outstanding training environment available to the Indian Air Force and the tremendous value that this exercise provides to the Japan Air Self-Defense Force, Koku Jieitai," Gen Morita said.

"I will remember it not only as a truly invaluable experience, but also as a powerful symbol of the trust,

confidence, and friendship that have been built between our two air services over many years," he added.

Addressing the media, Air Chief Marshal Singh said, "The sortie that you have flown, I think, is a very clear example of how much faith and trust you have in the homegrown Indian aircraft."

The Air Chief Marshal said he was sure that Gen Morita had enjoyed the sortie.

"Yes, we had kept it to a benign sortie since we did not want you to feel uncomfortable on your very first time flying in this heat you are flying," he added.

"I can assure you that the

Indian aircraft industry, the R&D as well as production, is growing at a very fast pace. We've been able to operationalise this aircraft, and a large number of these are on orders. Some of these are stuck because of some global supply chain issues," the IAF chief conveyed to his Japanese counterpart.

But with the next version of Tejas, that is Tejas Mark II, and the next fifth-generation aircraft that India is making — the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft, "Indian aviation, I will say defence aviation industry and R&D is now set to hit much higher heights," he said.



Editor's  
TAKE

## The climate blame game must end

With global warming accelerating, climate justice now demands greater accountability from wealthy nations and faster emissions cuts from allemitters, including India

Prime Minister Narendra Modi told a Delhi climate conference on Saturday that responsibility for emissions has “often been wrongly placed on developing countries”. The principle is sound. India emits about 2.2 tonnes of CO2 per person, less than half the global average; an American emits roughly 14. The six-fold gap PM Modi cited holds for the United States, though less so for Europe or Japan. History strengthens his case. The United States accounts for about a fifth of all CO2 emitted since 1850, some 537 billion tonnes by the end of 2024: two-thirds more than China and three-quarters more than the EU. Per head, the EU’s historical total is three times China’s. The atmosphere’s carbon budget was spent on the rich world’s industrialisation, and late developers are now told to live within the remainder.

Yet justice is not an alibi. India is the third-largest emitter, at about 8 per cent of the global total, and coal still supplies most of its electricity. Per capita is a moral argument; the atmosphere responds to total tonnes. The culprits are also contemporary. China emits nearly a third of global CO2 today. The United States, having formally quit the Paris Agreement again, saw 2025 emissions rise enough to account for about 40 per cent of the global increase, more than the EU, China and India combined. Modi’s claim on delivery needs precision too. India crossed 50 per cent non-fossil power capacity five years ahead of its 2030 pledge, and its emissions grew just 0.7 per cent in 2025, the slowest rise since 2001 outside the pandemic. But the 2.5 to 3 billion tonne carbon-sink goal stood at 2.29 billion in the government’s latest report, and intensity-based targets let absolute emissions keep climbing. “Every commitment met” is premature. The stakes are stark. UNEP’s Limiting Overshoot report, released on September 2, says 1.5C will be crossed within a few years, with 1.8C the best-case peak and about 2.6C by 2100 on current policies.

The way forward has three parts. First, the rich must pay. The \$300 billion a year promised by 2035 fell well short of the \$500 billion developing countries sought and the \$1.3 trillion experts say is needed, and the pledge to triple adaptation finance is non-binding.

At COP31 in November, India should demand delivery schedules, cheaper capital through reformed development banks, and technology transfer. Second, India must convert moral authority into a peak. It should fix a date for peaking coal power, which analysts say is possible before 2030, and expand storage, transmission grids and nuclear capacity to deliver its 2035 pledge of a 47 per cent intensity cut and 60 per cent non-fossil capacity. Third, all the big emitters must cut faster. UNEP’s 1.5C benchmark is a 55 per cent fall from 2019 levels by 2035. Washington’s absence makes that harder still; Beijing’s ambition matters more than ever. PM Modi is right that the poor should not carry the blame. But climate justice cools no degree unless it becomes climate action.

# Kanishka: Four decades later, justice still waits

Forty-one years after Air India Flight 182 was blown out of the sky, killing all 329 people aboard, Canada appears ready to scale back the investigation into one of the deadliest terrorist attacks in its history. For the families who have carried the loss for four decades, the message that there are ‘no fresh leads’ is not closure. It is another wound.



SANJAY LAZAR

Some wounds refuse to close. The bombing of Air India Flight 182, the Kanishka, is one, and this month it was torn open again. At a meeting near Toronto on 12 September, the RCMP told roughly 40 relatives that it has no fresh leads and plans to reduce its Air India team to administrative staff only. I was 17 when that bomb took my entire family. I know exactly what “no leads” costs.

### Two bombs one plot

On 23 June 1985, a suitcase bomb exploded at Tokyo’s Narita airport, killing two baggage handlers. Fifty-four minutes later, a second bomb destroyed Flight 182 over the Atlantic, off the Irish coast. All 329 people aboard died, including 82 children under 13. Until 9/11, it was history’s deadliest aviation bombing. It remains the worst mass murder in Canadian history. Relatives flew to Cork to claim the dead. I spent 25 days in a makeshift morgue there, searching through remains for my own family. Every anniversary since has reopened that room.

### A record of failure

For a decade, nothing moved. In 1995 a \$1 million reward was announced, but fear inside the community was so deep that almost nobody came forward. Charges arrived only in 2000, fifteen years after the bombing. The trial that followed cost nearly \$130 million and ended in 2005 with both accused acquitted. Witnesses recanted, went silent or were threatened. Several testified only as Ms. D or Ms. E, which says much about faith in witness protection. Tara Singh Hayer, who had given police a statement, was shot dead in 1998 despite promises of protection. Nobody has been tried for his murder. Justice John Major’s public inquiry let daylight in. It exposed surveillance tapes erased by CSIS, watchers who trailed Talwinder Singh Parmar’s circle into the woods near Duncan as they tested a device, ignored warnings, and two agencies guarding turf instead of preventing a massacre. It also exposed how the state treated the bereaved. Families of Indian nationality were overlooked, and Canadians of Indian origin were offered far less than others. Justice Major told me this week that Canada treated the bombing as an “Indian problem” rather than a Canadian tragedy. He was right then and the RCMP is proving it



ON 23 JUNE THIS YEAR, THE 41ST ANNIVERSARY, CSIS PUBLICLY ACKNOWLEDGED THAT CANADA-BASED KHALISTANI EXTREMISTS CARRIED OUT THE BOMBING. LESS THAN THREE MONTHS LATER, THE RCMP TELLS US THERE IS NOTHING LEFT TO PURSUE. WHICH AGENCY ARE WE SUPPOSED TO BELIEVE?

Sanjay Lazar is an Air India 182 Kanishka Victim family member, and the Chairman of the Kanishka foundation & GS of the AICCA. He is an aviation analyst, lawyer & best-selling author who writes on aviation, international relations, leadership and law.

again now.

On 23 June this year, the 41st anniversary, CSIS publicly acknowledged that Canada-based Khalistani extremists carried out the bombing. Less than three months later, the RCMP tells us there is nothing left to pursue. Which agency are we supposed to believe? Worse, police suggested that if families could bring them new leads, they might look at them. A national police force asking the bereaved to do its detective work, in the country’s deadliest terrorist attack. The RCMP also said it is talking to New Delhi about returning the wreckage and victims’ personal effects, the language of a file being closed.

This week I spoke with veterans of the original RCMP investigation, with CSIS alumni, with Justice Major and with Bob Rae. None could believe this was under way.

### Where the leads are

Leads exist for anyone willing to look. Investigators drew up a list of persons of interest, and many were never properly questioned. When I asked about them, I was told the investigation is “ongoing.” Inderjit Singh Reyat, the only man ever convicted, has been free since 2016 and has never told what he knows. Others in the plotters’ outer circle have kept silent for four decades. Where is the national appeal for them to speak, endorsed by Prime Minister Mark Carney? Where is immunity for anyone who was merely a bystander? Where is the trial for Hayer’s killers? The reward has not moved since 1995. Reissue it, raise it, and put the government’s full weight behind it. Ripudaman Singh

Malik, acquitted in the bombing, was murdered in 2022, and two men later pleaded guilty. This March, Nancy Grewal, an outspoken critic of violent extremism who had spoken of death threats, was fatally stabbed in Ontario. Speaking out remains dangerous.

### The world does not stop looking

Nazi hunters tracked Klaus Barbie down 38 years after the war and Franz Stangl 22 years after it. The Golden State Killer was caught more than four decades after his crimes. Almost 38 years after Lockerbie, a US court is still preparing to try the accused bomb-maker. As we approach the 25th anniversary of 9/11, imagine the reaction had Washington said it was out of ideas about al-Qaeda.

### What Canada owes us

In his Ottawa office, Prime Minister Stephen Harper promised me and other families that Canada would pursue this case to its conclusion and treat every victim equally. The Canadian Victims Bill of Rights and Justice Major’s recommendations back us. Yet nobody has approached the other families who had standing at the inquiry. Our demands are simple. Keep investigators on the file. If the current team is spent, bring in fresh ones or an independent review. Reissue and enlarge the reward. Speak to every family. We have written to Prime Minister Carney, to Prime Minister Modi, to the foreign ministers, to British Columbia’s Attorney General and to the RCMP Commissioner. Canada cannot walk away from the 331 people it lost, or from families who have waited a lifetime. We will not accept it.

# Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

## Truth Wears Many Names

In a world quick to argue over whose faith, whose path, or whose interpretation of truth is correct, a verse from the Rig Veda offers a strikingly different vision. It declares, “Ekam Sat Viprah Bahudha Vadanti”, Truth is one, though the wise call it by many names.

This single line acknowledges that different seekers, across centuries and cultures, have approached the same ultimate reality through different languages, symbols, and practices, not because truth itself is fragmented, but because human understanding approaches it from many directions at once.

We often mistake a different path for a wrong one, assuming that if someone worships, believes, or lives differently than we do, one of us must be mistaken. This verse suggests otherwise that diversity of expression does not mean division of truth.

Today, encounter one belief or practice different from your own with curiosity rather than judgment, remembering that it too may be reaching toward the same truth you seek.

# The senior swagger, not Gen Z blabber



NAMRATA KOHLI

## 2ND OPINION

Gen Z has become a national obsession. Brands want Gen Z. Luxury wants Gen Z. Media wants Gen Z. Advertisers want Gen Z. Apparently, simply announcing “we are targeting Gen Z” makes even an ageing brand sound young again. Even companies increasingly want workplaces populated by Gen Z. In short, the youth has become synonymous with both being relevant and ‘super cool’. India has rightly celebrated its demographic dividend. But somewhere along the way, “young India” became the only India worth wooing. The 40-plus consumer barely gets a look-in. Cross 60 and you become a “senior citizen” - marketed insurance, medicines, retirement homes and assisted living. What happened to aspiration, ambition, sex appeal and plain old fun? Travel entrepreneur Devendra Parulekar, founder of Saffron Stays, shares how silver economy is their most inter-

esting and fastest growing segment as on date: “Senior citizens are the most interesting customer segment because they are both time rich and money rich.”

Historically, Indian society has always valued age and experience. “Old is gold” wasn’t merely a saying. Elders were repositories of memory, knowledge and judgement. You sought their counsel. Today, in an increasingly materialistic culture, the senior becomes a relic on the mantelpiece - respected ceremonially, perhaps, but considered increasingly archaic and irrelevant. That narrative needs a reality check. That perception does not match reality. Neena Gupta’s career found an extraordinary second wind in her 60s. Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw remains one of India’s influential business voices at 73. Shabana Azmi is commanding screens at 75. But forget celebrities. Sudesh Chawla, a 74-year-old media professional, is learning salsa and taking up modelling assignments. Around us are older Indians travelling solo, starting consultancies, mentoring entrepreneurs and finally learning the music or dance they postponed for decades. Lisa Ray has a wonderful expression for midlife: “This is my prime time.” And she said it, not past our prime, but into “another prime”. And why should 60 mean we stop working? A teacher does not lose her knowledge at 60.

A doctor does not lose his judgement; if anything, decades of experience sharpen it. A lawyer, architect, entrepreneur or artist does not suddenly become less valuable because the calendar has turned. We meticulously plan our lives up to 60 — education, career, marriage, children, savings, retirement. But if we are going to live to 90 or 100, what

is our plan for the four decades that follow? Forty years is not life’s waiting room. It is another adulthood. Perhaps the longevity conversation needs to move beyond simply asking, “How do we live longer?” to a much bigger question: “What are we going to do with all those extra years?”

Longer lives will require a society and an ecosystem designed for them - workplaces willing to rethink retirement, opportunities for reskilling and second careers, financial systems built around longer working and post-working lives, healthcare focused on preserving function and independence, and communities that keep older people connected, purposeful and engaged. If longevity is giving us another adulthood, we need to build a world in which people can thrive. India already has nearly 167 million people aged 60-plus, projected to reach 346 million by 2050, according to the ASLI-JLL report India’s Silver Economy: From Niche to Necessity. Yet we continue to see this generation largely through the lens of care. Today’s 60-year-old could have another 30 or 40 years ahead. Many have money, assets, time, experience - and an appetite for life. Perhaps we need to talk of India having two distinct demographic dividends: the energy of youth and the experience of age. Give the young wings. Let them fly. But remember: shoots may reach for the sky; it is the roots that keep the tree standing. Klub 60 doesn’t need our sympathy. It needs its swagger back.

The writer is an author, podcaster and a Senior Fellow at the Ministry of Culture, Government of India

# LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Democracy under strain in West Bengal

The quality of democracy appears to be facing serious challenges, with recent developments in West Bengal raising troubling questions. The arrest of a Congress candidate in Nandigram over an agitation dating back to 2007, just as the election process begins, naturally invites scrutiny. The reported involvement of the Election Commission in directing the police action makes the timing and circumstances even more contentious. Questions also arise over the fate of others who participated in the same agitation. If reports are correct that assurances were given to participants regarding legal relief, the matter deserves greater transparency. Reports of candidates withdrawing from the contest or expressing concerns about campaigning further add to the perception of an uneven electoral environment. More broadly, concerns about investigative agencies, the functioning of the Election Commission, the criminalisation of politics and the growing influence of wealth in legislatures deserve serious public discussion. Democratic institutions can command public confidence only when they are seen to function impartially and transparently.

AG RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

### India must prepare for energy shock

The reported escalation of Houthi attacks against Saudi Arabia marks a worrying development in an already volatile West Asian situation. Riyadh has reported ballistic-missile and drone attacks targeting several locations, with its air defences intercepting the incoming threats. Any further targeting of civilian or energy infrastructure could trigger Saudi retaliation and increase the possibility of wider regional or US involvement. The situation around the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait is particularly important for India because prolonged disruption could affect crude supplies, shipping, insurance premiums and freight costs. A sustained escalation could also put additional pressure on global oil prices and inflation. India should therefore prepare on several fronts. It should secure additional crude supplies where feasible, replenish strategic petroleum reserves, examine alternative shipping routes and strengthen surveillance and protection of Indian-linked vessels. Diplomatic channels with Riyadh, Tehran, Washington and other stakeholders should remain active to help prevent further escalation. The safety of Indian citizens in the region must also remain a priority. At the same time, the govt should prepare contingency measures to cushion the possible impact of higher fuel, fertiliser and freight costs on the domestic economy.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

### Sanctions may disrupt global energy security

The enactment of the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 represents a significant expansion of Washington’s use of trade measures to influence the energy policies of other countries. The provision allowing tariffs of up to 100 per cent on major buyers of Russian oil could place substantial pressure on countries such as India and China. However, targeting large energy importers raises wider questions about global energy security. For India, securing affordable and uninterrupted energy supplies for its population is a fundamental national interest. Its purchase of Russian oil should therefore be viewed in the context of energy security rather than automatically interpreted as geopolitical alignment. Punitive measures against major oil buyers could have consequences beyond their intended targets. They may disrupt established energy flows, push up international crude prices and add to inflationary pressures worldwide. They could also complicate important strategic relationships. Washington should therefore consider diplomatic engagement alongside economic pressure. Greater stability in global energy markets would serve wider international interests better than measures that risk imposing costs on neutral economies and consumers.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI



Volunteers immerse idols of Lord Ganesha in an artificial pond during the Gauri-Ganapati immersion in Mumbai

PHOTO: PTI

# India needs a Bhu Nyaya Sanhita, not just faster land courts

India’s land disputes suffer from more than judicial delay. The deeper problem is fragmentation: records, maps, title and possession are handled by different institutions and often through disconnected processes. A purpose-built Bhu Nyaya Sanhita could bring them together, making land justice faster, simpler and, crucially, complete



VIVEK KUMAR SINGH

India's land disputes do not merely take too long. They are processed through a system that misreads how land conflicts arise. A land dispute seldom turns on abstract legal right alone. It rests on three connected elements: the record, the map and possession. The record says who claims the right. The map says where that right lies. Possession shows who occupies or uses the land. Justice is complete only when all three converge, yet India's institutions pull them apart. Revenue authorities keep records, survey departments handle maps, registration offices log instruments, and civil courts decide proprietary rights. A citizen may win in one forum and still need a second to correct the record, a third to alter the map and a fourth to obtain possession. The problem is not delay alone. It is fragmentation.

The Code of Civil Procedure, 1908 remains the basic framework for land litigation. It can be amended further, but land disputes are distinctive enough to justify something bolder: a purpose-built Bhu Nyaya Sanhita, or Land Justice Code. Indian law already accepts differentiated procedure: commercial disputes run on stricter timelines, insolvency operates against a statutory clock, and RERA created its own adjudicatory framework. Its objective should be simple: every final decision must bring record, map and possession into convergence.

### Classify before adjudicating

The first departure should be classification at entry. Today, similar controversies surface as suits for declaration, injunction, cancellation, partition, correction of records or recovery of possession, and jurisdiction often turns on how relief is drafted rather than on the real conflict. The Code could instead catalogue land disputes, much as a penal code classifies offences by defined ingredients, without criminalising civil disagreement.

Record disputes would cover fraudulent mutation, contested succession entries, duplicate records, and mismatches between registration data and the Record of Rights. Map and boundary disputes would cover overlapping parcels, shifted boundaries, survey errors, excess or deficient area, and gaps between textual records and cadastral maps. A map left unrevised after inheritance, partition or acquisition could count as an incomplete spatial mutation. Possession disputes would include dis-possession, encroachment, tenancy, permissive and co-sharer possession, and adverse possession. Title and trans- action disputes would take in competing conveyances, wills, family settlements, cancellation of instruments, fraud and impersonation. Public-law disputes over acquisition, ceiling, consolidation, government grants, common lands and public encroachment would form another.

For each category, the Code could specify essential assertions, permissible defences, standard documents, pre-sump-tions, limitation, interim relief, forum, appellate route and post-judgment action. A boundary dispute need not follow the evidentiary path of a fraudulent conveyance. A mutation controversy need not become a title suit. And a serious proprietary dispute should not be settled merely because one party holds a favourable revenue entry.

The law can therefore separate foundational right, current record and judicial determination of title. A right originates in grant, inheritance, partition or transfer; the record reflects recognised later changes; judicial deter-mination is needed when rival claims cannot otherwise be reconciled. Neither an old deed nor a recent mutation is infallible. Courts should apply a best-claim principle, weighing lawful origin, continuity of transactions, parcel identity, consistency of records, possession, notice, good faith and fraud. This would not displace substantive prop-erty law; it would structure how courts weigh compet-ing documentary, record-based and possessory claims.

### One jurisdictional map

Classification would then fix jurisdiction. Undisputed succession, mutation, clerical correction and conse-quential map updates would stay administrative. Contested record, survey, boundary, tenancy, consolida-tion and ceiling matters would go to specialised revenue forums able to commission neutral surveys and grant limited interim protection. Title, cancellation of instru-ments, complex inheritance, partition, fraud, specific per-formance and adverse possession would remain with des-ignated civil land courts.



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

EVERY LAND PROCEEDING COULD BEGIN BY IDENTIFYING THE PARCEL. A STANDARD PARCEL STATEMENT COULD SPECIFY THE LAND, SOURCE OF RIGHT, PRESENT RECORD, MAP, REGISTRATION AND MUTATION HISTORY, POSSESSION AND KNOWN RIVAL CLAIMS. WHERE DIGITAL SYSTEMS PERMIT, AN AUTHENTICATED PARCEL DOSSIER CAN BE DRAWN DIRECTLY FROM REGISTRATION, SURVEY AND REVENUE DATABASES

The writer is an ex-IAS officer and is presently Chairman, RERA Bihar. He served as Principal Secretary, Department of Revenue and Land Reforms, Bihar. This is the last part of a three-part series on land reforms

Mixed cases need a dominant-issue test. If a record dispute cannot be resolved without deciding title, the civil land court decides it. If title is admitted and only its implementation is con-tested, the revenue forum acts. A litigant should not lose years by approaching the wrong forum. Such cases should be trans-ferred, not returned for refileing, with limitation protected and the proceeding continuing from the stage reached.

Appeals need simplifying. A consolidated first appellate mech-anism for civil and revenue land disputes would stop parallel hierarchies reaching inconsistent conclusions on the same parcel. High Court scrutiny would remain for substantial ques-tions of law, jurisdictional error and constitutional review. Civil courts would be reserved for disputes that need them, and tech-nical record and survey matters would stop becoming endless civil trials.

### From principle to procedure

Every proceeding would begin by identifying the parcel. A standard parcel statement would set out the land, source of right, present record, map, registration and mutation history, possession and rival claims. Where digital systems permit, an authenticated parcel dossier could be drawn straight from reg-istration, survey and revenue databases. Defendants would answer the same structured questions rather than offer a general denial. An early case-management hearing would classify the dispute, identify admitted facts, decide whether technical inves-tigation is needed and fix the calendar. Where measurement is disputed, a neutral survey would follow prescribed geospa-tial standards and produce verifiable coordinates and field pro-ceedings. Oral evidence would remain where intention, fraud, consent or conduct matters. But technical facts should be proved technically: boundaries through authenticated maps and measurement, registration history through official records, phys-ical change through geospatial or time-stamped material. The Code could cap adjournments, interlocutory challenges and extensions, subject to narrow recorded exceptions, and set a statutory outer limit for first-instance disposal, with extra time for complex cases. No procedural stage should stay indefinite-ly renewable.

### Make the decree complete

Execution should not begin as though a second case has started. A land decree should specify who must update the Record of Rights, alter the map, cancel an instrument, remove an encroachment and deliver possession, and it should reach every such authority electronically. Each litigated parcel could carry a common digital case identifier and a lis pendens flag across registration, revenue, court and survey systems. A decree that declares ownership but leaves the winner to fight sep-arately for record, map and possession is justice only on paper. The real test is whether a judgment becomes visible at once in the record, on the map and on the ground.

### A federal architecture

Land and land revenue are primarily State subjects, while civil procedure and evidence engage the Concurrent List. A Bhu Nyaya Sanhita must therefore rest on cooperative federalism: a common procedural and evidentiary architecture, with State schedules reflecting local land laws, tenures and institutions. Uniformity need not mean one land law for India, only a coher-ent way of resolving land disputes.

India has spent decades improving land records, surveys and registration. That information cannot deliver full value while adjudication stays fragmented among institutions that do not communicate. The country needs more than faster land suits. It needs a system where the parcel is identified at entry, the dispute is classified correctly, jurisdiction is known in advance, evidence fits the controversy, timelines carry consequences, and the final order travels automatically into the record, the map and possession. A Bhu Nyaya Sanhita would be more than pro-cedural reform. It would finish the unfinished task of making land records, land rights and land justice speak the same lan-guage.

## UPI: From scale to sustainability



ANURADHA PS

If the volume of transactions is around ₹30 lakh crore in a single month, then it isn't just a matter of whether or not a transaction is zero cost. The larger question is who pays to keep the system secure, resilient and sustainable. This is what the latest decision by India on the Unified Payment Interface (UPI) means. The new Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) for the specified person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000 will be 0.4 per cent with a cap of ₹300 from Oct 15. Person-to-person pay-ments and payments made by merchants till a limit of ₹2,000 and under the zero-MDR formula for small mer-chants will continue to be free. The government's current figures indicate that around 96 per cent of the P2M transactions will not be impact-ed. This is not a general consumer levy. MDR is a fee in the merchant-payment system which is shared among the entities involved. The question is: has it managed to keep pace with the unprecedented scale of UPI?

### The economics behind 'free'

UPI is now an integral part of the digital public infrastructure in India. NPCI data revealed transactions worth ₹29.82 lakh crore from 752 banks through UPI in August 2026, meting out 24.51 billion transactions. This is a scale, but it's not a costless scale. The payment system needs investment on a continuous basis. Cybersecurity challenges are new and growing, fraud prevention needs are more complex and sophisticated and banks and payment service providers must have resilient technology to meet the challenges. As transaction volumes increase, the process of resolving the disputes of the customer has to be carried out and interoperability must be maintained and systems upgraded. It seems there's no cost to the user, but there is to the infrastructure. That is why the MDR debate needs to transcend the question of whether or not merchants should be charged. The bigger question is, has India made a sustainable economic and governance model of the digital public infrastructures?

### From zero to differentiated cost

There are strong arguments to maintain the costs of all UPI transactions low. Digital pay-ments are a cost-effective solution that can be promoted to drive adoption, limit reliance on cash and small businesses' access to the formal digital economy. The new framework takes into account that by protecting P2P payments and small-value merchant trans-actions, it will acknowledge this. The gov-ernment's design instead is to distinguish between various kinds of transactions, instead of having a general charge. It's worth noting that distinction is significant. However, as a payment ecosystem starts to make money from specific transactions, transparency is also crucial. What will be the revenue of the system? How will it be applied? What changes can be expected in the infrastructure, fraud prevention and cyber-security?



### When a payment system becomes critical infrastructure

UPI has ceased to be just another payment method. It's a payment channel that's now used by millions of consumers and businesses. This puts people in a new position of responsibility, which has a scope that goes beyond transaction processing. What would be the impact on a large-scale payment system if it went down? When there is fraud, who is responsible? How quickly the significant cyber security incidents are addressed? What if an unauthorized transaction occurs? Where to place the burden of continual upgrading of the infrastructure? With the increasing shift towards digital payments, these are now economic questions of resilience. Governance consequently has to shift from 'transaction governance to ecosystem governance'. This will result in greater clarity of responsibility within the banking system, between banks and payment services providers and other actors, higher operational and cybersecurity requirements, more secure systems in case of failed or fraudulent transactions, and more transparency regarding payment system economics.

### The missing key: accountability

The launch of MDR can contribute to the development of a more sustainable econom-ic model for the UPI eco system. However, the price tag is not enough to achieve sus-tainability. More transparency of financing and strengthening of the ecosystem should be public. The system should be able to show the benefits of the merchant's contribu-tion when they are involved in MDR. These reports might include: the cost of the ecosys-tem, investments in resilience and technology, fraud patterns and enhancements to customer protection. This is not a matter of making all things UPI overly "bureaucrat-ic" and "expensive". It's a matter of understanding that this is a digital public infrastruc-ture that needs institutional responsibility and efficiency. Adoption was the first UPI challenge in India. Scale was the second one. Next is sustain-ability. The measure of success cannot be transaction volumes alone. A processing system with billions of payments needs to be secure when things go wrong, cyber-resistant, and flexible enough to meet the needs of the consumer and have the financial means to make technological advances. This new MDR framework may thus be the first step in a wider discussion on the funding and governance of UPI. The policy dilemma lies in making sure that reducing transaction costs is not at the expense of other long term costs: system failures, fraud, cybersecurity risks, poor grievance redressal, and insuffi-cient infrastructural investment. The world has seen India prove that digital payments can be swift, seamless and so acces-sible at an unprecedented scale. The next demonstration should be that such infrastruc-ture is also sustainable, resilient and accountable. The future of UPI should not be decided on the number of transactions it can process or the cost of individual transactions. More significant question is whether India can keep the same affordability that led to the success of UPI and develop the governance structure for its sustained operation. The true cost of UPI is not just the cost of a transaction. It's what India is ready to pay to maintain the system trusted.

The writer is Professor, Department of Commerce, CHRIST University



NITIN KULKARNI

back in her hand. Ten views. Twenty likes. Decent, but where is his comment? Across the city, a young professional trudges home after weeks of untangling a difficult project. He feels proud until he remembers that his manager ended the final meeting without a word of thanks. In a kitchen, a small boy holds up his drawing. His mother calls it beautiful. He studies her face and asks, "Do you really mean it, or are you just saying it?" Three generations, three ordinary moments, one shared hunger. Somewhere along the way we handed a blinking notification light the authority to decide whether our day was good or bad. Wanting approval is not a flaw. Evolution wired it into us, and it has driven much of what humans have built. The trouble begins when approval stops being a pleasant extra and becomes a condition for feeling okay. Warming your hands at a fire is one thing; needing to inhale its smoke to breathe is

another. When appreciation turns from the icing into the cake, we are dealing with something that deserves a blunter name: validation addiction. Am I Good Enough? Validation is the world's way of telling us we are smart, attractive, capable or right. The addicted need it: "Fewer likes than hoped for, and the weekend is spoiled." "A partner who does not announce the relationship online, and insecur-ity creeps in." "A boss who skips the praise, and impostor syndrome takes over. We have tied our worth so tightly to outside noise that our own voice can no longer be heard above it. Digital life has changed the nature of approval. Once intimate, slow and uncounted, it now arrives as numbers: likes, views, followers, shares. Human warmth has been converted into a public scoreboard, and once worth can be mea-sured, comparison follows automatically. A stranger collects five thousand reactions while we collect fifty. We insist we are too grown-up to care about internet points. Our brains disagree. Every refresh of a feed works like a pull on a slot-machine lever, because the payout is unpre-dictable. Psychologists call this a variable reward schedule, and it is the mechanism that



keeps gamblers at the machine. We never know whether the next pull brings a burst of applause or an empty room, and that uncertainty keeps our anticipation, and our dopamine, running hot. The smartphone in our pocket has become a slot machine that also makes calls. The pleasure of a compliment is not the problem. The sting of its absence is. We tell our-selves we are only checking messages. In truth, we are checking whether we matter. Meanwhile we pay a hidden tax, and the cur-rency is authenticity. We soften our opinions,

people can weigh in before our morning tea has cooled. The answer is not to turn cold, withdraw from people or pretend their opinions mean nothing. Sound criticism sharpens our work, and honest warmth builds lasting bonds. What we need is a firm line between feedback and identity. A crit-ique addresses something we did. It does not deliver a verdict on who we are. That means moving the anchor of self-worth back inside. Before we put the phone down tonight, three uncomfortable questions are

tame our style and polish our joys until they suit what the audience likes to consume. We share what performs, not what is real. The internal question shifts from "What do I actually think?" to "What will they think of me if I say this?" In that shift we hand strangers the wheel of our emotional lives. The bill arrives as anxiety, burnout and a deep loneliness rooted in never feeling like enough. Technology, though, is only the amplifier. India has long lived under the gaze of family, neighbours and rigid hierarchies. Log kya kahenge, what will people say, has always been a powerful currency here. Digital platforms did not create our appetite for approval. They gave an old cultural reflex a global microphone, so that five hundred

worth asking: "Did I live by my own values today, whether or not anyone noticed?" "Did I put honest effort into the things that matter to me?" "When the screen goes dark and the room falls quiet, am I at peace with the person in the mirror? Public approval behaves like the weather. The crowd that crowns you today will scroll past you tomorrow, and the post that draws thousands of likes this week will sink beneath the feed by next. So why build self-worth on something so unstable? Surrendering your peace of mind to an audience that barely notices is a poor bargain. Enjoy the applause when it comes, but never lean on it to stay upright. Real self-worth is measured not by how high we rise when the hall roars, but by how steady we stay when the lights dim. Build self-respect from the inside out, and the world's applause becomes background music. The lion does not lose sleep over what the sheep think. And when the phone is off, no one is watching and no notification is waiting, we should still be able to say, calmly and without anyone's agreement:I am enough. Just enough. For myself.

Dr Nitin Madan Kulkarni is a senior IAS officer who is presently serving as Additional Chief Secretary to Governor of Jharkhand

## Your Trusted Management Advisory

[www.transglobeadvisors.in](http://www.transglobeadvisors.in)

## Order Order

### Court sends Malayalam TV channel MD back to jail



A court in Sultan Bathery on Sunday remanded Anto Augustine, managing director of a Malayalam news television channel, to judicial custody after he completed one day in Excise custody in a case following the seizure of liquor bottles above the permissible limit from his ancestral house here. Augustine, who was taken into Excise custody for one day, was produced before Sultan Bathery Judicial First Class Magistrate Adheena Biju.

He was subsequently shifted to Wayanad District Jail in Mananthavady. Before entering the jail, Augustine told reporters that he would respond to their queries later.

During the 24-hour custody, the Excise team took Augustine to his ancestral house as part of evidence collection in the case. The liquor bottles seized from the house were also examined as part of the investigation.

Augustine, managing director of Reporter Broadcasting Company, was arrested on Thursday after a Special Investigation Team, formed to probe alleged irregularities in a failed football event sponsored by the company, found liquor bottles at his ancestral house. The SIT handed over the seized liquor to the Excise Department, which subsequently registered a case and arrested Augustine, officials said.

He was remanded in judicial custody till September 30. The court on Friday had dismissed his bail petition. Augustine later approached Kerala HC seeking bail. The HC decided to consider his plea on September 22. (PTI)

### UP Police directed to ensure safety of same-sex couple

The Allahabad High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh Police to ensure the protection of an inter-faith same-sex couple in a live-in relationship, saying the lack of marital recognition does not give anyone the liberty to attack the dignity and physical safety of adult citizens. Justice Gautam Chowdhary said the couple has the freedom to peacefully live together without any interference from their family members or any other person.

The court directed that in case of any obstacle to the couple's live-in relationship, the police shall immediately provide security to them after verifying that they are adults and living together voluntarily.

The couple's counsel told the court that there was a threat to the two women's lives from their family members and that they immediately needed police security.

The counsel for the state government, however, argued that same-sex relationships "affect the natural and traditional framework of society" and were not accepted".

The court, after interacting with the couple, observed that they were adults and decided to live together without any pressure, fear or undue influence. Considering the law laid down by the SC, the court said that being in a live-in relationship is a fundamental right of two adult citizens who decide to live together by choice. It added that family members, other relatives or any section of society has no legal right to disrupt or violate their physical liberty. (PTI)



### Seven trial court judges to take oath in Delhi HC, Bench strength rises to 50

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Seven judicial officers from Delhi's district courts will be sworn in as judges of the Delhi High Court on Monday. This will bring the court's current strength to 50 judges, while the approved number is 60. Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya will administer the oath to Nivedita Anil Sharma, Nisha Sahay Saxena, Sanjay Sharma, Bharat Parashar, Aditi Choudhary, Dinesh Bhatt, and Arun Bhardwaj at a ceremony at the High Court at 10 am.

These seven officers have worked for decades in trial courts and held senior administrative roles in Delhi's judicial system. The Centre announced their appointments on Saturday, just two days before the swearing-in. The Supreme Court Collegium, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, had recommended eight names on September 10. The Union government approved seven of the eight recommended names but did not clear Gurvinder Pal Singh, Principal District and Sessions



Judge at the Rohini courts. The President made these appointments after consulting the Chief Justice of India, as required by the Constitution. Nivedita Anil Sharma and Nisha Sahay Saxena will become permanent judges, while Sanjay Sharma, Bharat Parashar, Dr Aditi Choudhary, Dinesh Bhatt, and Arun Bhardwaj will serve as additional judges. Three of the new judges are women, which is significant for a bench that still lacks gender balance. The new judges have direct experience from working in trial courts. Arun Bhardwaj currently serves as the Registrar General of Delhi High Court.



## Make perfect your will: Avoid futile disputes



**SHAMINDRA SINGH KADIAN & DEVENDER SINGH ASWAL**

Make perfect your 'Will', is an old adage. In law, more so, it is all the more essential so as to withstand judicial scrutiny. A Will, or testament, is a legal declaration made by a person how his property and assets shall be distributed after his death. A testator, considering his health and age, makes a Will how his property both moveable and immovable, assets, cash or other valuables shall be bequeathed after his death to obviate futile disputes and litigation among children, spouse and other heirs.

Unlike other documents, the Will speaks from the death of the testator as to the circumstances in which the Will came to be executed. There is an element of solemnity in deciding the question whether the document propounded is proved to be the last Will and testament of the testator. A properly drafted Will makes the intention of the testator clear, more so, where the intended distribution of property is not in accordance with the provisions of the succession law, or there is unequal distribution. The term is very wide term but here we are confined to the basic

ingredients of a Will.

The statutory provision governing a Will, including its execution, is enshrined in Section 63 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925. The testator must declare that he is declaring the Will voluntarily, while in a sound and disposing state of mind, that (s)he fully understands the nature and effect of the Will being made, and that, it is being made without any coercion, fraud or undue influence.

If the testator/testatrix, wishes to modify or revoke or cancel his earlier Will(s), it must be so stated clearly in the last Will being drafted, as multiple Wills are susceptible to creating more disputes. The Will must contain the complete details of the properties and assets to be bequeathed and the complete details of the beneficiaries, their age, address etc., and the exact share of each. It must contain a residuary clause to the effect that all remaining assets, movable/immovable/tangible/intangible, not specifically mentioned in the Will, shall devolve upon a particular beneficiary or that these too shall be shared in the manner indicated by the testator.

The testator must sign the Will or affix his mark of approval and it must be signed by two witnesses. Each witness must sign the Will in the presence of the testator. Under the law, there is no prescribed format, but it must fulfil the ingredients of a Will as indicated in S/63 of the Act.

Though, ex facie, the drafting of a Will appears simple yet, experience bears it out, great many disputes arise in probating the Will due to inherent deficiencies or due to allegation of fraud or coercion or non cooperative attitude of the witnesses who signed the Will or non availability of the witnesses. So much so, disputes have been reaching the Supreme Court by from time to time. In the landmark judgement H. Venkatachala Iyenger v. B.N. Thimmarajamma (1977), the Supreme Court, speaking through Justice Gajendragadkar (later CJI), laid down the propositions that a Will has to be proved like any other document-the usual test of the satisfaction of the prudent mind; examination of at least one attesting witness for the purpose of proving its execution, if there be an attesting witness alive capable of giving evidence and proof of essential facts by the propounder which go into the making of the Will.

But, the cases in which the execution of the Will is surrounded by suspicious circumstances, they stand on a different footing. "A shaky signature, a feeble mind, an unfair and unjustified disposition of

property, the propounder himself taking a leading part in the making of the Will under which he receives a substantial benefit", raise suspicion about the execution of the Will. Such a suspicion cannot be erased merely on the ground that the Will bears the signature of the testator or that he was in sound state of mind.

The presence of suspicious circumstances about execution of the Will excites suspicion and the propounder must remove suspicion to the satisfaction of judicial conscience. Allegations of fraud, undue influence, coercion, etc., in execution of the Will, give rise litigation which the testator precisely wanted to avoid. In Jagdish Chand Sharma v. Narain Singh Saini & Ors (2015), the Supreme Court held that if the evidence of the witnesses produced by the propounder u/s 68 of the Indian Evidence Act, 1872, is found worthless and lacking in credibility, the propounder cannot invoke S/71 of the Indian Evidence Act to supplement failed speculative endeavour. Where the propounder explicitly fails to produce primary evidence, he cannot be allowed to prove by other evidence.

Both the Sections have to be "construed harmoniously" and "not divorced with a mutilative bearing". This view was reiterated in Raj Kumar and Others v. Surinder Pal Sharma (SC2019). Further, the aid of S/71 can only be taken when the attesting witnesses, who have been called, deny or fail to recollect the execution of the

document to prove it by other evidence. It has no application when one attesting witness, who alone has been summoned, has failed to prove the execution of the Will and the other attesting witnesses, though available, has not been called.

In fine, a Will, in order to avoid serious legal challenge, must be drafted with meticulous care and foresight. It must be drafted, preferably by an independent lawyer well versed in case law, must be attested by two independent witnesses and must be signed by the testator in sound and disposing state of mind voluntarily without any coercion or undue influence. The original Will must be safely preserved along with supporting contemporaneous evidence, if any. In case of unequal distribution of the assets in the beneficiaries, the decision must be so stated clearly and conscientiously by the testator in the Will to nip any suspicion.

Registration of Will is not mandatory under the Indian law but it does provide additional evidentiary support at the time of grant of probate by the Court. The testator must select witnesses who later do not deny the attestation or do not turn hostile under undue influence, mindful of their age, so that, at least one of them is available to tender evidence at the time of probation.

The authors are members of the Supreme Court Bar Association. Devender Singh Aswal was ex Addl Secretary, Lok Sabha

## SC now shifting from anthropocentric to ecocentric approach: Justice BV Nagarathna

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

Describing the contribution of the Supreme Court to environmental jurisprudence as "overwhelming and significant", its judge B V Nagarathna on Sunday said the apex court is now pushing for a shift from an anthropocentric to an ecocentric approach on this aspect. "Environmental adjudication is an exercise in foresight, requiring courts to govern the present with an alert consciousness of the future," she said.

She was addressing the valedictory session of a two-day international conference on the topic 'The Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics' organised by the National Green Tribunal (NGT) in the Vigyan Bhavan, where President Droupadi Murmu was the chief guest.

Environmental law must move away from treating nature as property, commodity or resource, Justice Nagarathna said while highlighting that Indian traditions have long placed human beings within, and not above, the natural order.

"The contribution of the Supreme Court to environmental jurisprudence has been overwhelming and significant. In fact, the Supreme Court is now pushing for a shift from an anthropocentric approach to an ecocentric approach in matters of environment," Justice Nagarathna said. An anthropocentric approach regards human beings as the central or most vital element in the universe,



while an ecocentric approach places the natural environment and ecosystems at the centre of moral consideration, rather than just human beings. She said this entails recognising that human interests do not, by virtue of being human, enjoy automatic precedence over the interests of the non-human world. Rather, humans bear obligations towards non-human life that exist independently of their utility to them.

"In recent years, courts across many jurisdictions, including the Supreme Court, have emerged as central actors in giving concrete meaning to the idea of environmental justice.

"This aligns environmental protection with substantive equality, insisting that environmental governance must account not only for aggregated outcomes but for their differentiated social impacts," she said. The apex court judge said that the consequences of environmental decisions are

felt differently across regions, jurisdictions, communities and generations.

"Some bear the brunt of degradation more sharply, while others enjoy the benefits of development more fully. This places before us the question of balancing.

"Environmental governance will frequently require reconciliation between development and conservation, between competing uses of natural resources and between present needs and future interests," Justice Nagarathna said.

She said that such governance is shaped at the intersection of multiple and often competing domains: science, economics, technology, ethics and even politics.

"Legal standards must therefore remain responsive to new information. In today's world, we increasingly face transboundary environmental crises, pollution, climate change, biodiversity loss, and the degradation of

our shared ecosystems," the SC judge said.

She underlined that environmental protection is a matter of global regulation, requiring states to account for the consequences of their actions beyond their own territorial limits.

"The international community's engagement with climate change has acquired institutional urgency through the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change and its annual conferences of the parties. In that sense, environmental protection has become an arena in which national action and international responsibility are inseparable," Justice Nagarathna said.

She said the discussions at the present conference have reinforced precisely the point that rivers, forests, oceans, air and ecosystems do not recognise political boundaries and that climate change, biodiversity loss, pollution, land

degradation and water scarcity are interconnected challenges.

Justice Nagarathna said that effective management of these challenges depends upon cooperation between jurisdictions, sharing of knowledge and resources, and equitable responsibility sharing among nations.

The apex court judge said the "pancha sankalp" or five commitments that "environmental leadership demands of us comprise the steadiness of earth, the adaptability of water, the urgency of fire, the openness of air, and the breadth of space".

Justice Nagarathna cited the concept of the Pancha Mahabhutas, or the five elements, to frame what she described as an essential corrective to modern thinking. "Earth teaches us patience and tolerance. Air teaches us mobility and liberty. Fire teaches us warmth and courage. Sky teaches us equality and broad-mindedness. Water teaches us purity and cleanliness," she said.

"Nature is neither inert matter nor an object external to our existence. It is our teacher, sustainer and kin," the judge said, adding that the environmental crisis, at its deepest level, was a crisis in this relationship.

Humanity, she said, had forgotten that it is constituted by the very world over which it claims dominion.

Drawing on the same imagery, Justice Nagarathna said environmental law could be understood through what she termed "pancha sidhant", or five principles of

sustainable development: the polluter pays principle and absolute liability, the precautionary principle, the public trust doctrine and the intergenerational doctrine.

These, she said, now furnish the vocabulary of environmental governance.

Courts adjudicating environmental disputes were not concerned merely with completed wrongs or injuries already caused, she said, but were equally required to respond to risks unfolding in real time, often amid scientific uncertainty and with the potential for irreversible ecological damage.

NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava said environmental protection must go beyond identifying challenges and focus on building laws, institutions and partnerships capable of responding to emerging environmental threats. He said climate change, biodiversity loss, land degradation, pollution, water scarcity and ecosystem decline were interconnected challenges requiring stronger regional and international cooperation.

"Those with fewer resources often face the greatest risk. Climate action must therefore be inclusive, equitable, and attentive to vulnerable communities and future generations," Justice Shrivastava said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta said environmental challenges can no longer be addressed by a single institution or discipline and require the combined efforts of law, governance, science, economics and society.

## HC issues notice to Gujarat Govt on journalist's plea against arrest

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court has issued a notice to the state government and Adani Enterprises on journalist Ravi Nair's plea challenging his arrest after a sessions court issued a non-bailable warrant against him for failing to personally appear during a hearing in a defamation case.

A single bench of Justice MK Thakker issued the notice to the respondents on Saturday and kept the matter for further hearing on Monday.

Nair was arrested on September 17 after a district court in Gandhinagar issued a non-bailable warrant against him for not remaining personally present during the hearing of his appeal against his conviction in a criminal defamation case.

On February 10 this year, the journalist was sentenced by a Mansa court in Gandhinagar to one year's imprisonment in a criminal defamation suit filed by Adani



Ravi Nair FILE PHOTO

Enterprises on September 3, 2021 over certain tweets and articles attributed to him.

Nair had challenged his conviction in an appellate court in Gandhinagar, which granted him bail on March 9 this year on the condition that he would remain present during the hearing of his appeal. The journalist, however, could not be personally present during the hearing on September 3 due to poor health, as he has to travel from his native state Kerala, his lawyers said.

The appellate court rejected his plea for exemption from personal appearance and issued a non-bailable warrant against him, return-

able on September 17, without any prior notice, the lawyers claimed.

The court directed that the petitioner be taken into custody, and he was accordingly sent to jail.

The HC heard Nair's petition on Saturday evening on a note moved before the Chief Justice, praying for hearing at the earliest on the ground that the matter pertained to Article 21 and personal liberty of an individual.

The journalist, through his lawyers Ronith Joy and Abhik Chimni, submitted that the district court directly issued a non-bailable warrant without first issuing a summons or bailable warrant, and claimed it is against SC's order in a case.

Despite remaining present before court on September 17 and filing an application praying for cancellation of the warrant, the district court rejected the application and passed an order to take the journalist into custody, he told the HC in his plea.

# Regional Culinary Knowledge System

## Hawaijar and the Contemporary Science of Fermentation

Food is rarely simply what is placed on a plate. Behind its final form lies a sequence of decisions about ingredients, season, preservation and preparation. Fermentation of food is one of the oldest and most consequential of these practices. Archaeological evidence places organised food fermentation as far back as the Neolithic period, around 7000 BC, when settled communities were developing new ways of preserving and transforming agricultural produce.

Fermented foods are also being examined for their possible relationship with the gut microbiome and metabolic health. India presents an unusually rich landscape for studying this relationship between food, microorganisms and knowledge. *Dahi, dhokla, dosa, idli, kanji* and other regional preparations represent only a small part of a much larger repertoire of fermentation practices across the country. Fermentation, including pickling and vinegaring, is in fact ubiquitous in the Indian household, a near-universal feature of the everyday meal that nonetheless takes a distinct, regionally specific form, from *gundruk* in the Himalayan belt to nolen gurbased ferments in Bengal and mustard-oil pickles across the north. A 2023 review in *Food Research International* describes Indian fermented foods through their microbial diversity, nutritional characteristics, functional properties and cultural contexts. The history of fermentation in India also predates the scientific terminology through which it is understood today. Ayurvedic literature records preparations such as *asava* and *arishta*. *Charaka Samhita* is among the earliest classical texts to discuss fermented preparations at length, referencing *Sura, Sidhu* and *Sauviraka* as fermented liquids. A 2018 pharmaceutical review of Ayurvedic fermentation practice, published in the *International Journal of Green Pharmacy*, notes that the text describes roughly 84 *Asava* formulations drawn from 9 *Asava Yoni* or base fermenting materials, scattered across its *Chikitsa Sthana* chapters. Fermentation, in other words, belongs to a much longer history in which food, preservation, health and material knowledge intersect.

### A North-eastern Inheritance

In India's Northeast, fermented food preparation and preservation have been transmitted across generations as part of everyday practice. Jeyaram et al. (2009) documented the significance of fermented foods within the region's food traditions, situating them within a broader Himalayan and Northeast Indian fermentation culture. Yet within this vast culinary landscape, some traditions remain remarkably unfamiliar outside their regions of origin. Manipur, in particular, holds extensive knowledge of fermented food preparation, developed originally as a means of preservation and valued for nutritional benefits. Among its best-known fermented foods are *Ngari* (fermented fish), *Soibum* or *Soidon* (fermented bamboo shoot) and *Hawaijar* (fermented soybean). This article turns to one such food, *Hawaijar*, which originates in Manipur.



**MEENAKSHI LEKHI**  
FORMER MINISTER OF  
STATE FOR EXTERNAL  
AFFAIRS, GOVT. OF INDIA



**Dr. SOPHIA LISAM**  
SENIOR RESEARCH  
FELLOW, BHARAT  
KI SOCH

The preparation of *hawaijar* begins with *Glycine max* (soybean) a nutritionally dense legume containing substantial protein together with lipids, carbohydrates, minerals, vitamins and phytochemicals including isoflavones, phenolic compounds and saponins. The beans are soaked and cooked and traditionally wrapped in leaves, fig or banana, before being left to ferment for several days. During fermentation, the soybean undergoes a pronounced physical and biochemical transformation.

At the microbial level, *hawaijar* represents alkaline fermentation. *Bacillus* species, particularly *Bacillus subtilis* and related organisms, play an important role in the process. Their enzymatic activity acts upon proteins and other components of the soybean, producing biochemical changes that account for much of the food's distinctive texture, flavour and composition.

For the traditional food maker, however, the process is encountered through observation rather than microbial taxonomy. The knowledge lies in knowing how the beans should be prepared, how they should be wrapped, where they should be kept and how the sensory characteristics of the ferment change over time. This is an important dimension of Indigenous Knowledge Systems: knowledge can be empirical without being expressed through formal scientific terminology. It can reside instead in repeated practice, sensory judgement, material selection and intergenerational transmission.

### A Plant-Based Protein for Every Table

The nutritional significance of *hawaijar* deserves particular attention. Soybean is naturally protein-rich and provides an important plant-based source of protein and *hawaijar* forms a substantial component of the vegetarian diet, particularly among Manipur's vegetarian population, where its high protein content allows it to function as a genuine alternative to fish or meat. Yet *hawaijar* is not confined to vegetarian cooking alone: it is also prepared alongside meat, making it a genuinely inclusive culinary ingredient.

This versatility finds its fullest expression in *chagempomba*, a dish close to a porridge, in which *hawaijar* is an indispensable ingredient. Made with a mix of vegetables, herbs and rice, sometimes with meat, sometimes without as per one's choices. *Chagempomba* is traced back to periods of war and food scarcity in Manipur's history, when ingredients

were meagre but nutrition still had to be assured. In this dish, *hawaijar* supplied the protein, rice the carbohydrates and the accompanying vegetables and herbs the minerals and vitamins, together forming a complete, sustaining meal from limited means. This gives *hawaijar* a socio-cultural significance separate from its scientifically documented microbial benefits.

At a time when India is addressing nutritional diversity, affordable protein and sustainable food systems, *hawaijar*'s relevance extends well beyond cultural preservation. The scientific interest in *hawaijar* extends beyond its protein content. The 2023 review in *Food Research International* examines the microbiology, nutritional composition, functional properties and safety considerations associated with *hawaijar* and discusses reported antioxidant, fibrinolytic, antidiabetic and ACE-inhibitory activities associated with the food and its microorganisms, identifying potential for further investigation in the functional food and nutraceutical sectors.

### A Wider Family of Soybean Ferments

*Hawaijar* is part of a larger regional ecology of fermented soybean food traditions, including *kinema* in Sikkim, *bekang* in Mizoram, *tungrymbai* in Meghalaya and *axone* in Nagaland. Comparable fermented soybean traditions occur across Asia, including *tempeh* in Indonesia, *natto* in Japan, among several other regional forms.

This diversity is significant because fermentation is never determined by microorganisms alone. It is also shaped by the substrate available, local climate, household techniques, vessels, wrapping materials and cultural preferences. The microbial process is biological but the way a community learns to manage that process is cultural.

### Hawaijar in National Conversation

Bringing *hawaijar* into the national conversation is therefore not simply an exercise in culinary representation. It opens a discussion about plant-based nutrition, microbial biotechnology, food preservation, sustainable food systems and the safeguarding of Indigenous Knowledge.

*Hawaijar*, then, is not an isolated case but an instance of a far larger pattern. Across India's regions, culinary knowledge systems reside quietly within the everyday meal: a fermented rice batter in the south, a jar of pickled greens in the north, and fermented vegetables in the Northeast, each a distinct, regionally evolved culinary practice. Yet the foods that represent Indian cuisine on a national or global stage constitute only a fraction of this accumulated knowledge. Beneath that visible surface lie regional food systems built on highly specialised expertise that remain invisible beyond the communities that sustained them. What is needed now is rigorous documentation and scientific engagement before such knowledge is lost rather than understood.

## Fable with Moral

# Raja Harishchandra and the Ultimate Test of Integrity

(Markandeya Purana)

In the Treta Yuga, king Harishchandra of the Ikshvaku line ruled with a reputation that reached the heavens. He was known above all for an unyielding vow: never to utter a falsehood, never to break a promise once given. Prosperity and peace flourished under his just hand. His queen Shaivya and young son Rohitashva shared a life of quiet dignity.

To test the depth of this integrity, sage Vishwamitra employed his divine powers. In a vivid dream he caused the king to offer him the entire kingdom. When Harishchandra awoke, the memory of the pledge remained clear and binding. Without hesitation or complaint he honoured the dream-promise, abdicated his throne, and departed with his family, reduced at once to absolute poverty.

Separated from wife and child, the former king accepted the lowest of labours, which was service at a cremation ground under a chandala master. Day after day he collected the mandatory fees for the burning of the dead, performing his duty with the same scrupulous honesty he had once brought to kingship.



Tragedy struck when Rohitashva died of a snakebite. Shaivya, herself reduced to servitude, carried the small body to the cremation ground and begged her husband to perform the last rites. Grief nearly undid him, yet Harishchandra refused. The burial tax must be paid; it was his employer's due, and duty admitted no exception, not even for his own son.

At that moment of supreme trial the Gods revealed themselves. Dharma himself had assumed the chandala's form. Vishwamitra's test was complete. The boy was restored to life, the kingdom returned, and Harishchandra, with his queen and people, was raised to the celestial realms.

True morality is the steadfast dedication to truth and dharma even when it costs status, comfort, and the deepest of human attachments.

**Moral of the fable:** Never break your Promise

### Did you know?

One of the world's oldest surviving records of international trade finance is linked to ancient Kerala. Known as the Muziris Papyrus, this remarkable 2nd century CE document was discovered in Egypt and records a massive maritime cargo shipment from the Malabar Coast to Alexandria under Roman trade networks. Far more than a simple inventory, it functioned as a sophisticated commercial contract governing overseas trade. The papyrus describes an astonishing cargo of black pepper, malabathrum, luxury tortoiseshell and ivory valued at nearly 7 million sesterces, an amount enormous enough to purchase a vast estate in the Roman Empire.



The document reveals that nearly 1,900 years ago, maritime trade between Kerala and the Mediterranean world operated through advanced legal agreements, credit systems, insurance mechanisms and large-scale commercial logistics. Long before the rise of modern banking institutions, the Indian Ocean trade network had already developed remarkably sophisticated systems of global commerce.

### Wisdom Word Search

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| U | A | V | U | K | Y | F | Q | F | V | K | J | P |
| B | Q | U | Z | H | A | V | U | K | A | A | L | A |
| A | K | S | B | V | O | I | T | U | I | L | E | N |
| V | C | H | A | L | P | O | K | B | I | A | H | E |
| I | H | A | A | H | G | J | A | L | K | K | W | L |
| N | E | V | J | Y | A | N | L | K | A | O | C | L |
| I | R | U | I | L | H | S | A | G | H | T | F | A |
| L | U | D | H | T | J | I | P | V | A | J | Z | R |
| A | A | H | R | V | H | R | P | A | R | A | D | A |
| M | X | A | Q | R | O | U | A | R | G | A | Y | A |
| X | H | O | D | Q | W | M | U | E | A | K | E | N |
| Z | V | I | T | H | A | Y | K | K | U | K | A | S |

#### WORDS TO FIND

Chal, Cheru, Kala, Kalappa, Nellara, Nilam, Para, U?havukaala, Vithaykkuka, Vithu

**CHAL** - A narrow furrow to direct water flow

**CHERU** - slush for paddy transplantation.

**KALA** - Weeds or unwanted wild growth

**KALAPPA** - Ploughing Tool

**NELLARA** - Rice granary

**NILAM** - Field, agricultural land, or paddy field.

**PARA** - A traditional measuring vessel

**UZHAVUKAALA** - Ploughing Bullock

**VITHAYKKUKA** - The act of sowing seeds

**VITHU** - Seed

Note: These terms come from Gujarati, one of India's 22 Scheduled Languages.

## Marvels of India

### MILLETS



Millets are a remarkable expression of Bharat's agricultural heritage, combining ecological resilience, dietary value and civilisational continuity. Archaeobotanical evidence from Harappan and other early historical sites confirms the cultivation of sorghum, pearl millet, finger millet, foxtail millet and other millets. Textual sources, including the *Yajurveda*, *Arthashastra*, Ayurvedic treatises and later regional literature, record their cultivation, consumption and trade over long periods.

**Strengthening Food Security**

Millets are particularly valuable in rainfed and semi-arid regions. Their short growing cycles, drought and heat tolerance and ability to thrive on relatively poor soils enabled communities to secure food where water-intensive crops were less reliable. Their C4 photosynthesis also enhances water-use efficiency while some varieties require substantially less rainfall than rice, making them a practical buffer against rainfall uncertainty and crop failure.

**Nutrition and Sustainability**

Millets contribute to nutritional security by providing carbohydrates, dietary fibre, protein, iron, calcium and zinc. Their traditional cultivation and consumption also connected food security with local knowledge and sustainable agriculture.

| Agriculture & Food Security                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                       |                                                                  |                                     |                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Option A                              | Option B                                                         | Option C                            | Option D                           |
| <div>1</div>  <p>Ladakh has received the GI tag for this fruit. It grows wild across the cold desert areas, covering both the Leh and Kargil districts. What is its name?</p> | Rasbhari                              | Sea Buckthorn                                                    | Phalsa                              | Apricots                           |
| <div>2</div> <p>Which of these crops is typically cultivated in the valley regions up to 800 m above sea level, requiring heavy rainfall? It has similar agroclimatic zones to coconut and arecanut.</p>                                                           | Kokum                                 | Cashew                                                           | Coffee                              | Tea                                |
| <div>3</div> <p>What primary purpose did the subterranean structures known as 'Khattis' serve amongst the traditional desert communities of India?</p>                                                                                                             | Rainwater harvesting and purification | To preserve food reserves against drought, famine or enemy raids | Cattle sheltering during sandstorms | To protect themselves from bandits |
| <div>4</div> <p>In which part of India are Kachri (wild cucumber), Phog (shrub flowers used in raita) and Matira (indigenous watermelon) naturally found?</p>                                                                                                      | Eastern Ghats                         | Central India                                                    | Himalayas                           | Thar Desert                        |
| Answers: 1 - B, 2 - A, 3 - B, 4 - D                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                       |                                                                  |                                     |                                    |

# nili-katha

## WHEN COMPASSION COMES FIRST

The Wisdom of an Elephant

1

An ancient temple of Goddess Durga stood in the village. People visited every day and worshipped her.



2

One day the villagers noticed that an old pillar near the temple had become badly damaged.

This pillar is very old!

We must install a new pillar!

So the people decided to put up a new pillar.



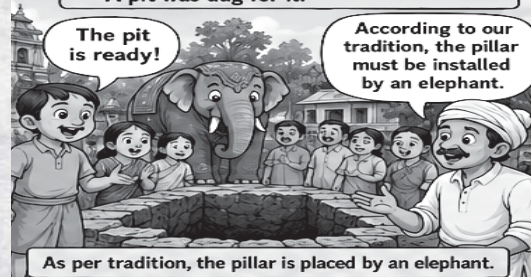
3

On an auspicious day, everyone gathered to install the new pillar. A pit was dug for it.

The pit is ready!

According to our tradition, the pillar must be installed by an elephant.

As per tradition, the pillar is placed by an elephant.



4

The elephant lifted the heavy pillar with its trunk.

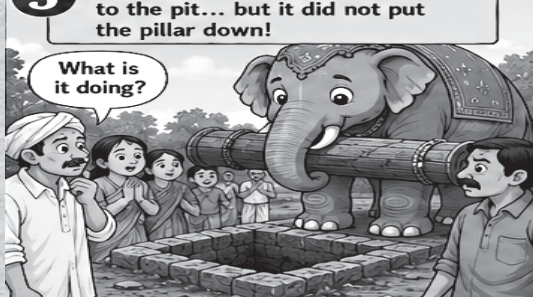
Blessed is the elephant!



5

The elephant brought the pillar to the pit... but it did not put the pillar down!

What is it doing?



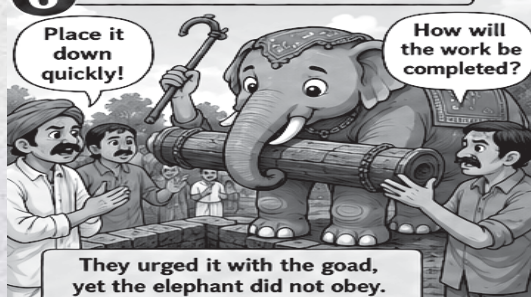
6

The villagers became impatient.

Place it down quickly!

How will the work be completed?

They urged it with the goad, yet the elephant did not obey.



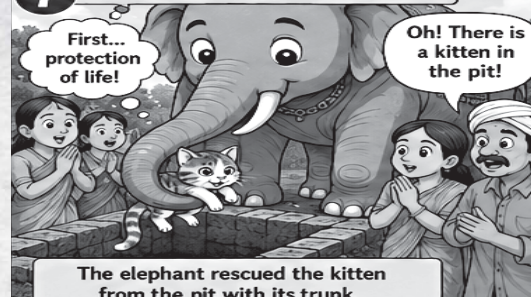
7

Then they discovered the reason!

First... protection of life!

Oh! There is a kitten in the pit!

The elephant rescued the kitten from the pit with its trunk.



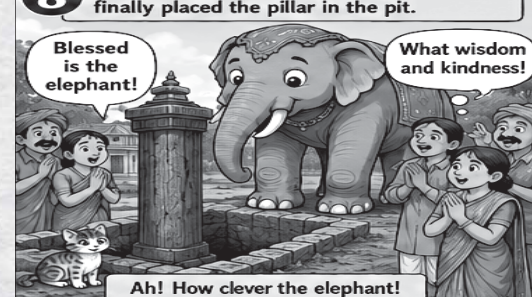
8

After saving the kitten, the elephant finally placed the pillar in the pit.

Blessed is the elephant!

What wisdom and kindness!

Ah! How clever the elephant!



**MORAL OF THE STORY:**

The greatest wisdom is to put kindness and the protection of life above rules.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Imran gets health checkup in jail

Pakistan's jailed former premier Imran Khan underwent a medical checkup amid concerns about his health, a media report said on Saturday. Khan, 73, has been incarcerated since 2023, when he was arrested after conviction in a corruption case. Currently, he is lodged at the high-security Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi. Geo News reported, quoting sources, that a special team from the state-run Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences (PIMS) conducted the former cricketer-turned-politician's medical examination. Khan underwent a comprehensive medical checkup, including examinations for blood pressure, cholesterol and eyes. A PIMS doctor headed the team, while medical staff from the Adiala jail hospital also assisted during examination, the report said. (PTI)

NEPAL

Climate diplomacy section constituted

Nepal's Ministry of Foreign Affairs has set up an environment diplomacy section to institutionalise and strengthen diplomatic efforts on climate change and environmental issues, the ministry said on Sunday. The section has been established for the first time in the ministry in view of the growing impact of climate change on Nepal and the need for effective and adequate responses, according to a statement. The move comes against the backdrop of the devastating floods of August 26 that killed more than 1,400 people in Nepal and left around 6,000 others missing, highlighting the growing threat posed by climate-induced disasters. The new environment diplomacy section will function under the division dealing with the United Nations and specialised agencies and will be headed by an under secretary, the ministry said. (PTI)

Nepal floods: Search continues for 6K missing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kathmandu

Search operations continued in Nepal on Sunday for around 6,000 people who are still unaccounted for the nearly four weeks after the devastating flash floods that killed more than 1,400. Flash floods, originating near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal. The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects. The floods also killed 43



people on the Chinese side, where more than 500 remain missing, according to Chinese media. The search in Nepal has continued across river stretches, debris fields and damaged hydropower projects in Rasuwa and neighbouring districts.

At the Upper Trishuli hydropower project in Rasuwa, rescuers have recovered 17 bodies from a tunnel. The bodies were found trapped in reinforcement mesh and buried in mud. Rescuers used grinders, gas cutters and rotary equipment to retrieve them,

according to the Nepali Army. Earlier this month, a Nepal Army field commander said clearing the material from some of the affected tunnels could take three to four months because of the volume and condition of the debris. The disaster has also left large parts of the affected region struggling with damaged roads and bridges. The government has begun repairing suspension bridges along the Trishuli corridor after the August 26 flood destroyed or damaged crossings connecting communities in Nuwakot and Dhading. Repair work had begun on 12 suspension bridges, with another 33 damaged beyond repair and requiring reconstruction,

according to a report in The Kathmandu Post. The government aims to reopen the 12 bridges by October 6 and has invited tenders for reconstruction of the other 33. The damaged crossings have disrupted access to markets, schools, health facilities and other essential services, forcing residents in some areas to take longer routes or rely on temporary arrangements to cross the river. Identifying the dead has emerged as a major challenge. Of the total bodies recovered, only around 110 have been handed over to families so far after identification, authorities said. Bodies recovered after being swept downstream

have often been severely damaged, decomposed or recovered only in parts, making identification by face, clothing or personal belongings difficult, officials said. Prolonged immersion in water and exposure to mud and debris can destroy identifiable features, while some remains have been fragmented or mixed with other remains. Forensic experts say DNA testing has therefore become crucial, but it is a time-consuming process requiring samples from the remains and biological relatives for comparison. So far, nearly 1,300 bodies have been temporarily buried after their DNA samples were collected, officials said.

JNIM claims deadly Mali army camp attack, releases video of captured soldiers



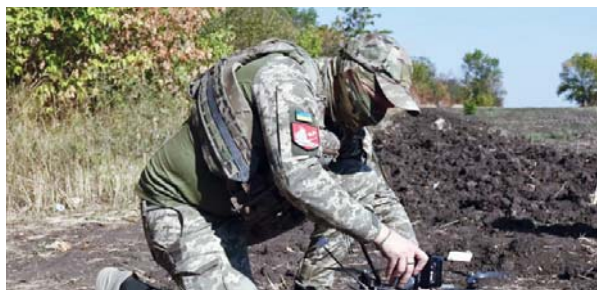
ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bamako

The al-Qaida-linked Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin militant group released videos of dozens of Malian soldiers it said were captured in combat and claimed that more than 100 others were killed in the attack earlier this month on an army camp in central Mali. The Associated Press could not immediately verify the numbers and the spokesperson for the Malian army, Col-Maj Bakary Bocar Maiga, declined to comment. If true, it would make the Sept 10 attack one of the deadliest in the group's history. The attack comes as the junta that has ruled the country since a 2021 coup prepares to celebrate Independence Day on Sept 22. The Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin, or JNIM, said in a statement Friday night that its "fighters were able to neutralise 150 members of the Malian army, including two colonels and one captain, and capture 93 others." The statement was made on its online propaganda channel, Az-Zallaqa.

Ukraine fires over 1,000 drones at Russia, including hundreds launched at Moscow

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

Ukrainian forces fired more than 1,000 drones at Russia overnight, including hundreds that were launched toward Moscow, officials said Sunday as the Kremlin was wrapping up the third and last day of its parliamentary elections. Moscow's mayor described the wave of drones as the "largest ever" attack on the Russian capital and said there had been damage to a Moscow oil refinery and a residential building. Across the wider Moscow region, the attack killed two people and wounded 20, local Gov. Andrei Vorobyov said. The



An Ukrainian soldier preparing to launch drone

dead were a 74-year-old man and a 44-year-old woman, he said. Writing on social media, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that Kyiv had used a range of missiles and drones in the attack – including Ukraine's domestically made Flamingo and

Pelican missiles – to hit oil and logistics facilities. "These are billions of dollars that sustain the war machine," Zelenskyy said, referring to the financial pressure that Kyiv hopes to put on Russia's economy. The voting underway in Russia is the country's first

wartime parliamentary election – balloting that has been virtually devoid of opposition to President Vladimir Putin's policies and is all but certain to cement the Kremlin's dominance. Russia was also holding the vote in the four Ukrainian regions that Moscow illegally annexed after the war began but still doesn't fully control, and in Crimea, the Black Sea peninsula that was illegally annexed by Russia in 2014. Kyiv has denounced the action as illegal. Russia's Ministry of Defence said that its forces shot down 1,100 Ukrainian drones across the country, as well as over the annexed Ukrainian peninsula of

Crimea and the waters of the Black Sea. Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said that 450 drones had been destroyed en route to the Russian capital, and that the attack had damaged the Moscow Oil Refinery and a residential building. He said the "unprecedented attack" on Moscow was an attempt to disrupt the elections. "The enemy failed in this regard," he said. Since Russia's invasion more than four years ago, Ukraine has become a global leader in military drone technology, deploying domestically produced long-range drones alongside missiles for strikes deep inside Russia. Its

drone technology has impressed governments and defence manufacturers around the world. Kyiv is aiming to make the Russian public feel the war's consequences and pressure Russian President Vladimir Putin into negotiating a peace settlement. Putin has so far shown no signs he intends to stop the invasion. Instead, Moscow and Kyiv have been drawn into an escalating duel of long-range aerial strikes as fighting along the roughly 1,250-kilometre front line in eastern and southern Ukraine has slowed, restricted by large numbers of drones and ground robots threatening troop movements.

Bangladesh PM to highlight Rohingya, climate issues in maiden UNGA address

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dhaka

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman is set to deliver his maiden UN General Assembly address in Bangla on September 24, highlighting the Rohingya crisis, climate change and his government's democratic agenda, according to a media report. Rahman will leave Dhaka for New York on September 21 and is scheduled to return on September 25, the state-owned BSS news agency reported on Sunday. His visit will mark his first participation in the UN General Assembly as prime minister and the first UNGA appearance of the incumbent Bangladesh Nationalist

Party (BNP) government, which came to power in February. On the sidelines of the UNGA, Rahman is scheduled to hold bilateral meetings with the Crown Prince of Kuwait and the prime ministers of Croatia, Bhutan, Thailand, Pakistan and Haiti, according to BSS. The talks are expected to cover political and economic relations, trade and investment, development cooperation, the Rohingya crisis and other issues of mutual interest, the report said. At the UNGA, Rahman will also outline Bangladesh's positions on global peace and security, sustainable development, economic cooperation and reform of the multilateral system, Foreign



Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman

Secretary Asad Alam Siam said at a press conference on Sunday. Rahman will seek stronger international support for the repatriation of Rohingyas to Myanmar at a Bangladesh-hosted side event on September 23, as Dhaka pushes to keep the protract-

ed crisis on the global agenda, Siam said. The crisis began in 2017 with the mass displacement of Rohingyas Muslims from Myanmar's Rakhine State amid military crackdowns and violence. Bangladesh faces growing

pressure on its resources and infrastructure as it hosts more than a million Rohingya refugees, while efforts to ensure their safe and sustainable return to Myanmar remain stalled. Climate change will also feature prominently during Rahman's upcoming visit, with the prime minister scheduled to attend a high-level meeting on climate action on September 23 and address a session on sea-level rise the following day, BSS reported. At the climate meetings, Rahman is expected to highlight the concerns of climate-vulnerable countries, particularly on climate finance, adaptation, technology transfer, loss and damage and climate justice.

Macron, Carney to discuss economic, defence ties



French President Emmanuel Macron along with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

French President Emmanuel Macron and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney are set to meet Sunday to deepen economic and security ties on the remote North Atlantic archipelago of Saint-Pierre-et-Miquelon. The meeting comes days after Carney embraced the prospect of Canada becoming the European Union's first associate member, saying closer ties with the continent would ensure no country could control Canada's markets or undermine its sovereignty. US President Donald Trump's tariffs, demands for economic concessions and repeated talk of making Canada the 51st state have pushed Ottawa to reduce its dependence on its neighbour and pursue deeper economic, security and political relationships with Europe. "This is an important moment," Macron said upon arriving Saturday in the French territory off the coast of Newfoundland, Canada.

Saint-Pierre-et-Miquelon is home to about 5,800 people. Talks "will allow us ... to strengthen our bilateral economic ties and defence relationship," Macron said. Macron also said Sunday's talks are part of broader efforts to help France secure oil and gas supplies as the war with Iran disrupts global energy markets and raises fears of higher prices for fuel and other essentials. "Canada is a country with significant resources of critical minerals and rare earths. It is also a major oil and natural gas producer," Macron noted. "What we want to do is conclude agreements to secure more liquefied natural gas that can be shipped to Europe's Atlantic coast." The leaders will discuss deepening the Canada-France partnership in strategic sectors, including aerospace, energy, critical minerals and advanced technologies such as quantum computing, satellites and supercomputing. Carney's office said in a statement.

Trump used to slam China, Here's why he's now rolling out the red carpet for Xi

JOSH BOAK ■ Washington

When President Donald Trump first ran for office, he called out China as a menace to the US economy, saying it had gutted America's factories and eroded the middle class. That tough talk helped Trump get to the White House a decade ago, but since then, he increasingly speaks in glowing terms about Chinese President Xi Jinping, the geopolitical rival Trump will fete on Thursday with a state dinner. "He's a great gentleman; we get along great," Trump said this month. "We have a very good trading relationship and, you know, they're a competitor and all of that, but we have a very good relationship with President Xi."



American President Donald Trump along with Chinese President Xi Jinping

On issue after issue, the Republican president has given Xi a pass. Trump shrugged off reports that China had provided Iran with satellite imagery, saying, "I think he's behaved reasonably well." After accusing Beijing of accessing US voter files back in 2020, Trump indicated he was hesitant to retal-

iate. "I think China is maybe a little bit different today than it was then," Trump's magnanimity comes as China and the United States are in a contest for global leadership, with some of America's traditional allies rethinking their strategies. China has expanded its dominance in manufacturing and pushed into new

technologies such as artificial intelligence and electric vehicles that create risks for the economies of the US, Germany, Italy, France, South Korea and Japan, among others. Unable to change Chinese behavior, Trump has resorted to hospitality. He traveled to Beijing in May, and the two leaders could meet again two more times this year at international summits. Trump has readied a helipad on the White House South Lawn before Xi's arrival and has lamented that his ballroom will not be ready to host the Chinese leader. Trump has insisted that the US is comfortably ahead of China, but his efforts last year to confront China with a mounting set of tariffs back-

fired. China holds a relative monopoly on the rare earths used in electronics and deployed that to help force a trade armistice with Trump. "Trump has dramatically shifted his approach to China because his initial attempt to use super-high tariffs and export restrictions was unsuccessful," said Michael Kovrig, a senior adviser at the International Crisis Group. "Xi and Trump got into a contest of leverage, and Xi came out on top." Meanwhile, Trump has largely undermined the economic and national security alliances that could previously apply pressure on China, said Kovrig, a former Canadian diplomat who was detained by China during Trump's first term.

Trump has mocked French President Emmanuel Macron in speeches. He has run hot and cold on NATO after several of its members did not fully support his choice to start a war with Iran. Trump has launched a potentially brutal trade fight with Canada, a longtime ally he has trolled as becoming the 51st American state. "He's executing Xi's wedge tactics for him, and along the way, helping Xi to tell a story about China as the more stable and responsible power," Kovrig said. "It's led to a wave of Western leaders visiting Beijing and seeking to stabilize and improve their relations with Xi so they can focus more on dealing with problems Trump is causing them."

North Korea launches 2 ballistic missiles toward the sea, dials up pressure on US

HYUNG-JIN KIM ■ Seoul

North Korea launched two short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea on Sunday, South Korea's military said, days after the North threatened to bolster its nuclear deterrent capabilities and respond to what it called US hostilities. The launches were the latest in a series of weapons demonstrations by North Korea even after US President Donald Trump scaled back a joint military exercise with South Korea last month in an apparent effort to revive diplomacy with the North's leader, Kim Jong Un. The two missile

launches – about three hours apart – were conducted from North Korea's eastern coastal Wonsan area. The first missile flew about 450 kilometres while the second one flew more than 600 kilometres, both toward the North's eastern waters, South Korea's military said. The missiles eventually ended up in the sea. South Korea's presidential office urged North Korea to immediately halt ballistic missile launches that are banned by UN Security Council resolutions. The South's military said it maintains readiness to repel any provocations by the North under a solid alliance with the United

States. Japan's Defence Ministry said it detected a suspected North Korean missile earlier Sunday but that the weapon did not land in its territorial waters. Kim's sister and senior official, Kim Yo Jong, earlier shrugged off Trump's overture, saying that shortening the drill wouldn't change its "provocative, aggressive nature." North Korea's military later launched about 10 short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea, apparently following through with a previous threat to respond to the US-South Korean drill. On Friday, Kim's sister slammed another recent US-led multilateral maritime



exercise in the region as a "frantic military move" by the Americans meant to prolong their hegemony in the Asia-Pacific area. The "Pacific Vanguard" exercise brought together the US, South Korea, Japan, Australia, New Zealand and Canada. She claimed that "regular US-led war rehearsals" are the main source of worsening tensions in the Korean Peninsula and the region. "Our will to defend our sovereignty will be expressed in clearer action and there will be never ever change in the course of intensifying the nuclear war deterrence," she said. Earlier

this month, North Korea conducted what it called a joint live-fire drill involving missiles, artillery and drones, a day after the United States, South Korea and Japan wrapped their five-day trilateral military drill that North Korea described as a provocation. North Korea said its drill included firing different types of weapons simultaneously, likely aiming at developing the ability to overwhelm South Korean and US air defences. Kim Jong Un has been focusing on expanding his nuclear arsenal after his earlier high-stakes diplomacy with Trump collapsed in 2019.

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

## Ashiana Housing to invest ₹1,000 crore in FY27: MD Vishal Gupta

Realty firm Ashiana Housing will invest ₹ 1,000 crore this fiscal to buy land parcels for development of housing projects as part of its expansion plan, a top company official said.

Listed entity Ashiana Housing is one of the leading real estate developers in the country. It specialises in building homes for elderly people.

In an interview with PTI, Ashiana Housing MD Vishal Gupta said housing demand continues to be strong despite global uncertainties.

To tap this demand, he said the company is expanding business across major markets including Delhi-NCR, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.

On land acquisition, Gupta said the company is continuously looking for land to develop regular group housing and also senior living projects.

“We will be investing around Rs 1,000 crore this fiscal on land acquisition,” he said, adding that the company has enough cash to fund the investment.

The land acquisition would be outright as well as joint development with landowners.

## Titan open to acquiring smaller watch brands

Leading watchmaker Titan Company, which has been expanding its premium and luxury watch portfolio, is open to acquiring or investing in smaller and emerging brands as part of its growth strategy, a top company official said.

The Tata group firm expects a “robust” festive season this year, driven by healthy consumer demand and an early wedding season coinciding with a delayed Diwali, said Titan Company Chief Marketing Officer Ranjani Krishnaswamy. She also acknowledged that the company is working to keep pace with rising demand. “We are looking at a very robust demand. We are seeing a very healthy start to the festive season. We are very optimistic and, hand on heart, we are struggling to ensure we have the capacity to service demand,” Krishnaswamy told PTI. When asked about acquisition as part of its growth journey, she said Titan is evaluating opportunities that may complement its long-term growth ambitions and help deepen its presence across segments and markets.

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Market investors would track any implications arising from US President Donald Trump signing the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, with crude oil and geopolitical developments remaining the key driving trends for equities this week, analysts said.

Besides, trading activity of foreign investors and trends in global markets would also be tracked, they added.

“Indian equities enter the coming week with crude oil, global bond yields and geopolitical developments likely to remain the main

drivers of sentiment. A new source of uncertainty for Indian markets is emerging on the trade front.

“US President Donald Trump has signed into law legislation giving his administration expanded powers to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from major buyers of Russian oil and gas, with India among the countries potentially exposed given its significant purchases of Russian crude,” Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

US President Donald Trump signed the Sanctioning Russia and Iran

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

# NSE’s shareholders retain significant stake after OFS

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

A majority of the existing shareholders of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) have retained a significant portion of their holdings even after tendering shares in the offer-for-sale (OFS) component of the exchange’s ₹22,569-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The selling shareholders largely comprised institutional investors, who collectively held a 36.82 per cent stake in NSE before the IPO and tendered shares representing a 5.11 per cent stake in the exchange, according to an analysis of data.

Of the 20 institutional shareholders that participated in the OFS, nine were foreign institutional investors, which collectively held a 15.96 per cent stake before the IPO, it added.

The remaining 11 were domestic institutions, comprising 10 public sector entities and ICICI Lombard General Insurance, which

together held a 20.86 per cent stake before the OFS.

Several large institutional shareholders have largely stayed put despite participating in the OFS.

Aranda Investments, which held a 4.54 per cent stake before the OFS, Stock Holding Corporation of India with a 4.44 per cent stake, SBI Capital Markets with 4.33 per cent and ChrysCapital with 3.73 per cent have reduced their holdings by an average of only around 7 per cent.

Among other large foreign investors, Crown Capital

offered around 11 per cent of its pre-OFS holding, while TA Asia Pacific reduced its holding by about 6 per cent.

The pattern indicates that the OFS has allowed existing investors to partially monetise their investments while continuing to hold substantial stakes in NSE.

The IPO, which was fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Friday, is India’s second-largest public issue after Hyundai Motor India’s ₹27,870-crore IPO in 2024. It has also surpassed the ₹21,000-crore public offer

of Life Insurance Corporation of India in 2022. The issue has drawn strong investor interest, with non-institutional investors and qualified institutional buyers driving subscription on the second day of bidding.

The IPO comprises an OFS of up to 12.64 crore equity shares by existing shareholders. The exchange has fixed a price band of ₹1,700-1,785 per share, valuing NSE at up to ₹4.42 lakh crore at the upper end of the price band.

Since the issue is entirely an OFS, the proceeds from the share sale will accrue to existing shareholders and not to NSE. The size of the OFS was earlier planned at 14.9 crore shares, but was subsequently reduced to 12.64 crore shares, bringing down the overall issue size from the initial estimate of around ₹30,000 crore.

The IPO will close on September 21, while NSE shares are expected to make their market debut on September 24.

# FMCG firms to hold prices despite rise in commodity costs; prioritise volume growth

### PIONER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

FMCG companies are likely to hold prices through the festive season despite a rise in commodity prices, including sugar, and the impact of geopolitical disruptions, as they seek to protect consumer demand and maintain volume growth amid improving consumption.

Leading industry executives said companies have already gone for judicious increases of around 2-5 per cent in the June quarter to partly offset higher input costs and are unlikely to raise prices further before the end of the festive season, even as margins remain under pressure.

The sector has been facing renewed cost pressures, with sugar prices touching a new high, alongside a sharp increase in costs of key inputs such as edible oils, coffee, cocoa and crude oil derivatives used in packaging, amid geopolitical disruptions and supply concerns in global markets.

While most companies have absorbed a significant part of the inflation through cost-control initiatives and portfolio

management, they remain focused on protecting volume growth, even as pressure on margins remains elevated, industry executives said.

ITC Chief Executive Officer, Foods Division, and Executive Director Hemant Malik said the company would maintain prices through the festive season despite cost inflation.

“We are attempting to hold prices,” Malik said, noting that companies have been absorbing a large part of the increase in commodity prices through cost management initiatives and portfolio actions.

Referring to the impact of the GST rate reduction on several consumer products

last year, Malik said the move had led to buoyancy in volumes across multiple categories and supported market demand.

However, he indicated that companies may have to revisit pricing decisions later in the financial year if cost pressures persist.

“Maybe in quarter three or quarter four, we will have to look at some corrections on prices,” he said, adding that most FMCG firms have so far implemented only modest price hikes of around 3-5 per cent despite facing much higher cost increases.

Home-grown FMCG major Dabur India, which has also gone for calibrated pricing actions on select products to partly mitigate input costs, is watching the situation.

“We have taken up prices on a few products over the past few months to partly mitigate the inflationary impact due to the geopolitical situation, while keeping the competitive intensity in mind. Going forward, we will be closely watching the situation as it develops,” said Dabur India CFO Ankush Jain.

BUSINESS

13

## Chip majors eye wider ecosystem with Indian talent

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Semicon India 2026 attracted huge participation from global semiconductor players looking to collaborate and expand their presence in India by leveraging skilled local talent and supportive central and state government policies.

Lithographic equipment major ASML, which has a presence only in semiconductor-producing nations, has set up an office in India and expressed optimism that more of its customers are expected to enter India.

ASML Chief Strategic Sourcing and Procurement Officer Allan Wayne said Tata Electronics is the first customer in India to have a 300-millimetre semiconductor fab with production capacity of 50,000 wafers per month.

“If we’re going to be scaling this up, we need to be able to build many fabs here. This is why we are very confident in what we see here now with the policies coming from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his team for the ecosystem and, of course, the great talent that we see in India,” he said.

According to industry experts, no chip in the world gets produced without ASML equipment.

Wayne said ASML enters a region not only to support customers but to leverage talent.

“As you go on into 2032, India’s projection and India’s ambition is to have between 15 per cent and 25 per cent of the wafer fab of India’s local semiconductor demand. That means you’re going to have several fabs by 2032,” Wayne said.

The government has announced the Semicon 2.0 scheme with an incentive of

around ₹1.27 lakh crore or \$13.5 billion to build the semiconductor ecosystem.

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said investment proposals worth USD 12 billion are likely to come under the new scheme for chip production.

semiconductor gear maker Applied Materials committed an investment of \$5 billion, about ₹48,000 crore, over the next 10 years at the event, a day after signing a pact with the Karnataka government to invest ₹3,600 crore in research and development and production of equipment that are used for manufacturing chips. Applied Materials’ competitor Lam Research announced an investment of ₹10,000 crore to set up a silicon component manufacturing facility in India.

Around 56 memorandums of understanding were signed at the event.

Tata Electronics signed 16 agreements with vendors to support its ₹1.18 lakh crore investment to set up a chip manufacturing unit in Dholera, Gujarat and a chip assembly and test unit in Assam.

The company announced the building of a 363-acre park in Dholera to house about 450 vendors that its plant will need.

The agreement brought depth to the semiconductor vendor ecosystem, ranging from partners supplying machines, materials, specialised gases, high-end logistics, etc with companies including Nexperia and BESI from Europe, JSR, Fujifilm, Sumitomo from Japan, Kelington from Malaysia, Ascendas First Space from Singapore, L&T Semiconductors, Inox Air Products, etc.

# Stock market momentum to depend on West Asia crisis, report analysts

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Market investors would track any implications arising from US President Donald Trump signing the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, with crude oil and geopolitical developments remaining the key driving trends for equities this week, analysts said.

Besides, trading activity of foreign investors and trends in global markets would also be tracked, they added.

“Indian equities enter the coming week with crude oil, global bond yields and geopolitical developments likely to remain the main

drivers of sentiment. A new source of uncertainty for Indian markets is emerging on the trade front.

“US President Donald Trump has signed into law legislation giving his administration expanded powers to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from major buyers of Russian oil and gas, with India among the countries potentially exposed given its significant purchases of Russian crude,” Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

US President Donald Trump signed the Sanctioning Russia and Iran

ship and energy sector – as well as on collaborators in Moscow’s defence industry and its so-called shadow fleet.

The Act also authorises

President Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on countries buying Russian oil and gas, including China and India.

The law gives Trump wide

discretion over implementation, including which countries face tariffs, the tariff rates imposed, and whether sanctions provisions are waived.

The law comes into effect within 30 days of signing by the President and requires him to impose duties of up to 100 per cent on goods imported from countries that are the top five purchasers of Russian crude oil or natural gas by total volume during the 12 months preceding enactment.

“Globally, updates on the US-Iran tensions, movement in crude oil prices and Treasury yields will remain

key market drivers,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research at Religare Broking, said.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex dropped 486.8 points, or 0.65 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dipped 51.7 points, or 0.22 per cent.

Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have pulled out ₹ 20,974 crore from Indian equities so far in September amid elevated crude oil prices, higher US interest rates, bond yields and global uncertainties.

“Looking ahead, key economic indicators will dictate market direction globally and domestically. Investors will closely track flash PMI

figures across India, the US, and the Eurozone, along with upcoming US labour market reports. On the domestic front, the listing of the NSE on September 24 stands out as a major landmark event for Indian equities,” Santosh Meena, Head of Research, Swastika Investmart Ltd, said.

The ₹22,569-crore initial public offering of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) was fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Friday, driven by an encouraging response from non-institutional investors and qualified institutional buyers.

# India’s BRICS exports jump 34% in April-August

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

India’s exports to China, South Africa, Brazil and Russia grew 34 per cent to \$19.9 billion in April-August 2026-27, led by a 39 per cent jump in shipments to China, highlighting the growing importance of the BRICS bloc for India’s export growth.

“As India deepens its engagement with the BRICS bloc, strongest momentum is coming from the BRICS members, especially Core BRICS founding partners—China, South Africa, Brazil, and Russia,” an official said.

BRICS, originally comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, with Indonesia joining in 2025. Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan and Vietnam became BRICS partner countries last year.

According to the com-

merce ministry data, exports to the four core BRICS economies grew by 34 per cent, rising from \$14.9 billion in April-August 2025-26 to \$19.9 billion in April-August 2026-27.

The share of the four countries in India’s total exports increased from 9.2 per cent during the first five months of this fiscal from 8.1 per cent in the same period of 2025-26.

Among the core BRICS countries, China emerged as the largest contributor, with Indian exports expanding by 39 per cent to reach USD 9.6

billion in the first five months of 2026-27.

At the same time, South Africa recorded the fastest growth rate, with exports surging 58 per cent during the period. Brazil and Russia also maintained steady double-digit growth of 13 per cent and 11 per cent.

“India is not only strengthening its trade footprint within BRICS but is also becoming more integrated with the bloc’s largest economies. With exports to Core BRICS growing nearly three times faster than

exports to the broader BRICS grouping, these markets are increasingly emerging as a key pillar of India’s export strategy,” the commerce ministry official said.

During April-August 2026-27, India’s exports to Japan surged to \$3.43 billion, registering a 43 per cent growth over the same period last fiscal.

India is steadily expanding its presence in key sectors that align with Japan’s industrial requirements, ranging from energy products and electronics to advanced materials.

The export momentum is being led by mineral fuels, which recorded an increase of \$231.7 million (76 per cent), highlighting growing energy trade between the two countries.

Simultaneously, exports of electronics and aluminium also recorded healthy growth.

Similarly, India’s exports to Italy witnessed a strong surge during the five months of 2026-27, rising to \$3.92

billion from \$3.02 billion in April-August 2025-26, reflecting a growth of about 30 per cent.

On the other hand, outbound shipments to South Korea grew 22 per cent to \$3.21 billion.

The growth story is being driven by India’s increasing role as a supplier of industrial raw materials, energy products, and intermediate goods that feed into South Korea’s advanced manufacturing ecosystem.

The main sectors that helped push exports to South Korea included minerals, fuels, electronics, aluminium, iron and steel and chemicals.

As South Korea strengthens its position as a global hub for automobiles, electronics, semiconductors, and advanced manufacturing, India is increasingly becoming a preferred sourcing partner, driving sustained growth in bilateral trade and reinforcing economic ties between the two nations, the official said.

## Gold to stay range-bound amid dollar, West Asia tensions, report analysts

### PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Gold is likely to remain volatile and range-bound in the coming week as traders track movements in the US dollar and bond yields, developments in the West Asia conflict and the direction of crude oil prices, analysts said.

After a week dominated by monetary policy and geopolitical developments, investors will turn their focus to a fresh batch of economic data, including mid-month manufacturing and services Purchasing Managers’ Index (PMI readings) from major economies.

The data on US housing, durable goods orders and consumer sentiment readings due to be released towards the end of the week will also be closely watched for cues on the outlook for monetary policy and bullion demand, they added.

On the Multi Commodity

Exchange (MCX), gold futures for October delivery rose ₹ 1,597, or 1.04 per cent, last week to close at ₹1.54 lakh per 10 grams. Silver futures gained ₹6,629, or nearly 3 per cent, to end at Rs 2.41 lakh per kilogram.

“MCX gold witnessed a weak opening last week near ₹1.5 lakh per 10 gram but staged a strong recovery towards ₹1.54 lakh per 10 gram as buying interest emerged at lower levels,” Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and

Currency, LKP Securities, said. The recovery followed a period of heightened volatility as markets digested major macroeconomic and geopolitical developments, he said.

“With several key events now behind us, attention will gradually shift towards how markets price the next phase of monetary policy and geopolitical risks,” Trivedi added.

In global markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery ended marginally higher at \$4,424.9 per ounce, while silver gained 3 per cent to \$67.15 in New York.

“Gold futures continued to trade steady as prices consolidated for the third straight week, but some bargain buying was seen at corrective levels in last couple of trading sessions to close the week in positive,” Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said.

# Himanta lays foundation stone for Adani Power’s 3,200 MW Assam project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday laid the foundation stone for Adani Power Limited’s 3,200 MW Ultra-Supercritical Thermal Power Plant (USTPP) at Chapar in Assam’s Dhubri district.

The ₹48,000-crore project is expected to generate up to 20,000 jobs during the construction phase and around 5,000 jobs once operational. The plant is scheduled to be commissioned in phases from December 2030.

The Chapar project is part of Adani Group’s ₹63,000-crore power investment in Assam, which also includes two Pumped Storage Plants (PSPs) with a combined capacity of 2,700 MW through Adani Green Energy Limited. Across power, aviation and cement, the Group’s investments in Assam are expected

to exceed ₹80,000 crore.

The foundation stone-laying ceremony was attended by senior State Government officials, industry leaders, local community representatives and Jeet Adani, Director, Adani Group.

Himanta Biswa Sarma said Assam is fast emerging as the region’s energy hub, with several major energy projects in the pipeline.

“Assam is fast emerging as the region’s energy hub, with several mega energy projects in the pipeline. The 3200 MW Chapar project is a proud outcome of the confidence generated by the Advantage Assam Investor Summit 2.0,” the Chief Minister said.

He said the project, involving an investment of nearly ₹48,000 crore, would constitute one of the largest single investments ever made in Assam. According to him, the project would generate employment, increase economic activity and

contribute to the state’s SGST revenues, while creating opportunities for local industries and enterprises.

Jeet Adani said the project marked an important new chapter for Assam.

“Adani Power will invest ₹48,000 crore in this 3,200 MW thermal power project, bringing reliable and affordable electricity to support homes, businesses and industries. The project will also create jobs and open up opportunities for local contractors, suppliers and businesses. We are proud to invest in Assam and be part of the state’s economic growth,” he said.

The Chapar plant will comprise four 800 MW units and use ultra-supercritical technology, along with high-efficiency systems and modern environmental safeguards. Once commissioned, it is expected to provide power for Assam’s household, commercial and



Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma lays foundation stone of Adani Power project. Adani Group Director Jeet Adani is also seen at the function

industrial requirements.

The ₹63,000-crore power investment in the state comprises around 748,000 crore for the Chapar thermal power plant and approximately ₹15,000 crore for two Pumped Storage Plants through Adani Green Energy. Adani Energy Solutions Limited is also implementing smart metering projects in Assam as part of efforts to modernise the state’s power distribution infrastructure.

Beyond the power sector, the Adani Group has committed investments in aviation and cement in Assam. Terminal 2 at Lokapriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport in Guwahati became operational on February 22, 2026.

The Adani Foundation has also undertaken social development initiatives in the state. It has reached more than 8,000 flood-affected families in Sivasagar and Dhemaji districts with food, medicines, sanitation and hygiene supplies. In and around Guwahati, the Foundation’s work covers 19 villages in Kamrup Rural district across education, healthcare, livelihoods, community infrastructure and climate action.

The 3,200 MW project follows Adani Power’s successful bid through a competitive bidding process in October 2025. The company subsequently received the Letter of Award from Assam Power Distribution Company Limited (APDCL) in November 2025.

Adani Power, part of the Adani portfolio, is the largest private thermal power producer in India, with an installed thermal power capacity of 18,290 MW across 13 power plants in Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh, besides a 40 MW solar power plant in Gujarat.

# India’s semiconductor push targets chips for cars, TVs, power infra: Vaishnaw

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

India wants its semiconductor capabilities to reach into everyday products such as cars, televisions and refrigerators, as well as critical power infrastructure in the coming years, Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has said, outlining the sheer breadth of chip-making prowess the country aims to build going forward.



The Minister’s vision comes as India steps up efforts to establish a larger presence in the global semiconductor value chain, with the Government seeking to move beyond chip assembly and testing, and build capabilities spanning design, fabrication, equipment and materials.

Under the second phase of the semiconductor programme, the Government has committed ₹1.27 lakh crore to expand the domestic ecosystem and attract global investments.

The Government recently said it received about ₹1 lakh crore in investor interest under the second phase of the semiconductor scheme, and this week saw a slew of big-ticket announcements, including Applied Materials’ USD 5-billion India plan through 2035, Lam Research’s proposed ₹10,000-crore investment, Tata Electronics’ 363-

acre vendor park at Dholera and Fujifilm’s ₹800-crore semiconductor materials plant.

In an interview to PTI, Vaishnaw said India should be designing and manufacturing chips for cars, power systems, televisions, refrigerators and other appliances within the next five years.

“There are many chips which go in automobiles, in cars, scooters and motorcycles, that are manufactured in our country. We should be able to have many of those chips designed and manufactured in India,” Vaishnaw said.

The minister said a similar capability should be developed in the power sector, including chips used in transmission lines, transformers

and converters.

“There are many chips which go into power sector, for example, the transmission lines, the transformers and the converters. We should be able to manufacture many of those chips, which are designed and made in India,” he said.

In the consumer electronics space, Vaishnaw said, many of the chips used in televisions, refrigerators and other household appliances should also be designed and manufactured in India.

“...we don’t really see the chip; we see the finished product. When we buy a TV, we don’t see the chip inside it, but it is the chip which is driving the entire thing,” he said, describing the semiconductor as the “brain” and “heart” of a television.

“So once we move in that direction, it will be very good,” he added.

Vaishnaw cited a display-control module plant coming up in Uttar Pradesh as an example of the capabilities India is seeking to build.

The module controls how a television displays the final picture and will be manufactured in the country, he said.

“The display control module is the one which controls how the TV displays the final picture; that is the heart and the brain of the television. So, that is going to be manufactured in India...so many such products are there,” he said.

# Atmanirbharta in arbitration is need of the hour: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

As India continues to endeavor to become self-reliant—or *Atmanirbhar*—across various fields, including manufacturing, services, agriculture, technology, and energy, an equally important area of focus is self-reliance on the legal front. This is particularly crucial for arbitration, which remains one of the preferred routes for resolving commercial disputes.



Indian corporates have traditionally favored destinations like Hong Kong, Singapore, and London to resolve cross-border contractual disputes. However, amid India’s growing economic influence, experts believe it is high time for cities like Delhi or Mumbai to emerge as preferred arbitration hubs, particularly for disputes involving Indian businesses.

Senior Counsel Tushad Cooper believes this issue is becoming increasingly relevant as India’s commercial footprint expands. “The issue is not whether foreign arbitration centers are good. The real question is whether Indian—and eventually global—companies trust our system just as much. India cannot become an economic powerhouse while exporting its disputes,” Cooper noted.

However, experts emphasize that India must make several structural changes to establish itself as a leading

global arbitration seat.

“An aspiration to become a global arbitration hub will not be realized by rhetoric alone. Four structural imperatives demand immediate attention,” said Mani Gupta, Partner at Sarthak Advocates & Solicitors.

“First, consistency of approach across the executive, judiciary, and legislature is non-negotiable. Arbitration reform cannot succeed when ministries, courts, and Parliament operate at cross-purposes—issuing conflicting signals on enforcement policy, statutory interpretation, or pending amendments. India requires one coherent national position, not competing institutional voices.”

“Secondly, the quality of our institutions and arbitrators must be raised deliberately through rigorous, sustained training. Arbitration is a specialized discipline; procedural management, evidentiary

rigor, and award-writing competence cannot be left to chance or assumed to develop organically,” Gupta added.

Additionally, India cannot afford delays at the challenge and enforcement stages. Awards contested for years before enforcement defeat the core rationale for choosing arbitration over litigation.

The country also needs to focus on the integrity and ethics of arbitrators. A single instance of arbitrator misconduct inflicts disproportionate reputational damage on India as a seat. The issues surrounding arbitrator integrity and disclosure have taken center stage amid an ongoing legal dispute between Tata Power Company Limited and Kleros Capital Partners over a \$490.32 million arbitration award.

The case has sparked a broader debate over how much professional information arbitrators should dis-

close when their relationships with parties, lawyers, or third-party funders could raise doubts regarding their independence or impartiality.

On August 26, the Singapore International Commercial Court dismissed three applications filed by Tata Power challenging the award in favor of Kleros.

The court rejected Tata Power’s allegations that two members of the arbitral tribunal exhibited apparent bias due to undisclosed connections with Omni BridgeWay, the third-party funder supporting Kleros’s claim.

Tata Power had challenged the tribunal members over their alleged “undisclosed” professional appointments, arguing that their connections with Kleros’s funder and legal counsel created circumstances requiring full disclosure and examination for potential bias.

# ICAI issues new standard on sustainability assurance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Kochi

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) has issued a new standard on sustainability assurance that will be applicable from April 1, 2027. SSA 5000 is the Standard on Sustainability Assurance, and the General Requirements & Framework for Sustainability Assurance Engagements aligns with global standards.

ICAI President Prasanna Kumar D said the move would help boost confidence among investors and stakeholders. This standard pertains to an entity’s disclosures about sustainability information across different topics, including climate, labour practices and biodiversity.

SSA 5000 has been prepared with certain carve-outs from the International Standard on Sustainability Assurance (ISSA 5000), an ICAI official said on Sunday.

The official said there are



two carve-outs in SSA 5000 are about joint audits and forward-looking statements. Both provisions have been excluded from the standard.

“This marks a significant step in elevating sustainability assurance in India to global standards. It is a principles-based framework and broadens the ambit of sustainability assurance while accommodating the diverse reporting framework we have in the country also,” Prasanna Kumar said at a session here on Saturday.

SSA 5000 will be very important. From April 2027, the standards that already

have the framework for sustainability reporting in India, such as SSA 3000 and SAE 3410, will stand withdrawn, he added. ICAI Vice President Mangesh Kinare, in a release on Sunday, said SSA 5000 broadens the ambit of sustainability assurance while accommodating diverse reporting frameworks with equal rigour and consistency.

As part of efforts to boost reporting and disclosures on sustainability by corporates and other entities, ICAI is also taking various initiatives, including the Sustainability Reporting Maturity Model (SRMM).

# Supertech insolvency: NCLAT raises concern over delay in appointing IRP, slippage on deadline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Appellate Insolvency Tribunal NCLAT has raised concerns over construction major NBCC’s delay in meeting deadlines set for resumption of work at Supertech Ltd’s stalled housing projects.

Besides, a three-member bench has also pulled up the authorities over the delay in appointing an interim resolution professional (IRP) for the realty firm, which is currently going through the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP).

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has directed NCLT and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) to suggest names within a week.

“We have been informed that an application for appointment of the IRP has been dealt with by the NCLT, and IBBI is directed to



suggest the names. Let the said process be completed within a week from today,” the NCLAT said on Friday.

The IRP, once named, is also required to head the Apex Court Committee overseeing the stalled Supertech projects and chair the Project-Wise Court Committee, the appellate tribunal noted.

The NCLAT, in its 5-page interim order, also noted slippages by state-run construction major NBCC in

meeting deadlines set out in its earlier order dated May 6, 2026, for resumption of construction work at Supertech’s projects.

“...the order dated June 6, 2026, certain timelines were given to the NBCC for start of the project, viz. Condition-I being satisfied on December 12, 2024, itself and Conditions - II, III, V and VI were to be complied with on or before July 31, 2026,” it said.

NBCC was also required to

process the award of work as per Condition-IV prior to July 31, 2026, and complete the contract within one month, and then the construction was to commence from October 1, 2026, the NCLAT noted in its order.

A status report filed by the Apex Court Committee on September 10 flagged difficulties faced by NBCC in fulfilling these conditions, but did not offer fresh timelines for compliance, the tribunal observed.

“We have also gone through the Status Report dated September 10, 2026, filed by the Apex Court Committee, which notes the difficulties being faced by the NBCC in completion of Conditions II, III, IV, V and VI,” the appellate tribunal said, adding that it “does not state the prospective dates of the completion of Conditions aforesaid as mentioned in Paragraph 85(1) of the order dated May 6, 2026”.

# AI-powered Smriti to detect dementia

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

There is a breakthrough in the early detection of dementia, a state of mind where the elderly can’t remember and are prone to forgetting. AI tool ‘Smriti’ uses WhatsApp conversations to track cognitive health. This AI-powered tool, is designed to help families detect early signs of cognitive decline in elderly relatives through ordinary WhatsApp conversations. Developed by researcher Aahana Gupta, Smriti functions as a voice companion, engaging users in conversations about their daily lives while analysing patterns in memory, language and recall. Smriti is intended to support—not replace—medical diagnosis.

The tool can also use a familiar caregiver’s cloned voice, which Gupta says can make elderly users more comfortable and encourage more natural conversations.

# NMDC looks to hit 60 MT iron ore production mark this fiscal: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

NMDC is working on strategies to achieve the 60 MT iron ore production mark this fiscal to meet growing demand from domestic steelmakers for the key raw material, its Chairman Amitava Mukherjee said. Aligned with the National Steel Policy 2017, which targets an installed domestic steelmaking capacity of 300

MT by 2030-31, NMDC, India’s largest iron ore producer, aims to scale its output to 100 MT during the period.

“Having crossed the 50 MT milestone in FY2026, NMDC is now aggressively executing a production ramp-up plan to reach 60 MTPA from existing iron ore mines, complemented by NMDC-CMDC Limited (NCL) joint venture assets this fiscal, which would be a rise of around 20 per cent year-on-year,” the top company offi-



cial said in an interaction. Mukherjee shared that the company has already applied for environmental clearances

(ECs) for some deposits with the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change.

On a question related to the 100 MT production goal, Mukherjee said, “We are progressing well. We are on track, and will definitely achieve it”.

Mine-related infrastructure is being built at some places, while at some deposits they are already operational.

For enhancing the capacity of existing mines, bids have been invited from interested parties to develop the

infrastructure, including setting up belt conveying systems and crushers and breakers, among others.

NMDC operates four major highly mechanised iron ore mining complexes in India spread across Chhattisgarh (Bailadila sector) and Karnataka (Donimalai sector).

Under the Ministry of Steel, Hyderabad-based NMDC alone caters to the country’s 20 per cent need of iron ore.

**उत्तराखण्ड सीड्स एण्ड तराई डेवलपमेंट कॉर्पोरेशन लि०**  
पंतनगर, पथरघट्टा पो०-हल्ली-263145, जन्पद : उद्यम सिंह नगर  
वेबसाईट : [www.pantnagarseeds.com](http://www.pantnagarseeds.com) & [www.ukstdc.com](http://www.ukstdc.com) Email: [tdc@quaseedsandtdc.com](mailto:tdc@quaseedsandtdc.com)

**यातायात ई-निविदा सूचना MKT/04/TRP/2026-27**

निगम के पन्तनगर, खटीमा एवं धनौरी (हरिद्वार) स्थित बीज संयंत्रों / गोदामों से स्थानीय एवं देश के विभिन्न स्थानों को बीजों का परिवहन, लादने, उतारने एवं गोदामों में भण्डारण व्यवस्था हेतु ई-निविदा के माध्यम से दो बिड व्यवस्था के अन्तर्गत निविदादाताओं से निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु० 2000.00 + (जी०एस०टी० 18 प्रतिशत कुल धनराशि रु० 2360.00) जमा करने के उपरान्त दिनांक **21.09.2026** से दिनांक **27.09.2026** सांय 5:00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं [www.uktenders.gov.in](http://www.uktenders.gov.in) पर भरी जा सकती है। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र, आवश्यक अर्हताएं एवं अन्य शर्तें निगम की वेबसाईट: [www.pantnagarseeds.com](http://www.pantnagarseeds.com) & [www.ukstdc.com](http://www.ukstdc.com) पर भी उपलब्ध हैं। अधिक जानकारी हेतु निम्न मोबाइल नम्बर पर सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

**1. विपणन अधिकारी मो०-9410561705**  
**2. सहा० विपणन अधिकारी मो०-9415205727**

**प्रबन्ध निदेशक**

BRIEFLY

Suraj finishes 11th in men’s changquan wushu final



India’s Suraj Singh Mayanglambam finished 11th in the men’s changquan wushu final while Aparna Dahiya and Vikrant Baliany lost their round of 16 matches in their respective weight categories at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, here on Sunday. Aparna lost 0-2 to Iran’s Sogand Sinkaichetan in women’s 52kg Sanda while conceding five points each in the two rounds that they clashed in.

With the defeat, Aparna, who had claimed the gold medal in the women’s 52kg category at the Sanda World Cup in May this year, failed to make it to the quarterfinals.

In the men’s 75kg Sanda bout against Iran’s Soheil Mousavi, India’s Baliany suffered a similar 0-2 defeat to crash out before the quarterfinals. While he conceded five points each in the two rounds, Baliany did record one against his opponent on forcible count in the first round. Sanda is the full-contact combat variation of wushu. (PTI)

Rishabh Das finishes sixth in 100m backstroke final



India’s Rishabh Das clocked 54.77 seconds to finish sixth in the men’s 100m backstroke final at the Asian Games here on Sunday. Das, who clocked 26.56 seconds at the 50m mark, finished 2.79 seconds behind China’s Xu Jiayu, who won the gold medal with a time of 51.98 seconds.

Japan’s Hidekazu Takehara took silver in 53.93 seconds, while South Korea’s Lee Juho claimed the bronze medal after finishing in 53.94 seconds.

The Indian swimmer had produced a timing of 54.85 seconds to qualify for the final after finishing fifth overall.

Das finished 0.63 seconds behind second-placed Japanese swimmer Hidekazu Takehara and 2.22 seconds behind the heat leader and Asian record holder Xu Jiayu (52.63s) of China. The other Indian in the fray, Utkarsh Patil, finished 12th with a time of 56.19 seconds and missed out on the top-tier qualification. (PTI)

India thrash Indonesia in Asiad men’s hockey opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

Defending champions India produced a brilliant all-round performance led by striker Dilpreet Singh’s four-goal haul to outplay unfancied Indonesia 13-1 in their opening Pool A match of the Asian Games here on Sunday.

All of Dilpreet’s four strikes (18th, 19th, 37th, 49th) were field goals, while Shilanand Lakra (6th, 35th) and Sukhjeet Singh (38th, 48th) scored a brace each for India.

The other goal-scorers were Abhishek (12th), Rajinder Singh (19th), Mandeep Singh (21st), skipper Harmanpreet Singh (28th), and Jugraj Singh (47th).

Indonesia’s solitary goal



Indian men’s hockey team at Asian Games 2026

FILE PHOTO

was scored by Aulia Al Ardh in the 33rd minute.

India will next play Sri Lanka on Tuesday.

The Indians got off the blocks in the sixth minute through Lakra’s rebound after skipper Harmanpreet’s drag-flick was saved by Indonesia goalkeeper Alam

Fajar.

As expected, India controlled the possession and dominated most of the game.

In the 12th minute, Abhishek doubled the lead from a rebound after the initial shot was saved by the Indonesian custodian.

Asian Games TT: Indian women script 3-2 win against Singapore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Toyota

The Indian women’s team scripted a fine comeback to register a 3-2 win over Singapore in a Group F match, but their men’s counterparts suffered a 0-3 loss to Iran in another Group F match of the table tennis event at the Asian Games here on Sunday.

India were staring at defeat after trailing 1-2 before Sreeja Akula and Yashaswini Ghorpade secured crucial wins to clinch the tie.

Opening the proceedings, Ghorpade defeated Jian Zeng 11-7, 11-3, 8-11, 11-9.

But Sreeja Akula suffered a narrow 8-11, 11-4, 9-11, 11-4, 6-11 loss to Loy Ming in the second match. Diya Chitale too went down 7-11, 4-11, 11-7, 5-11 against Tan Zhao to concede a 1-2 lead to Singapore.

Returning for a must-win match against Zeng Jian, Sreeja shrugged off the earlier loss to register a 6-11 11-3, 11-7, 11-4 win to level the tie at 2-2.

In the decider, Ghorpade beat Loy Ming 5-11, 11-8, 12-10, 4-11, 11-9 to notch up a memorable win for India.

However, it was a disappointing performance from the men’s team as, apart from Harmeet Desai, none of the other paddlers could put up a fight.

Manush Shah went down 3-11, 8-11, 10-12 to Noshad Alamiyani in the opening match, while Manav Thakkar lost 2-11, 6-11, 6-11 to Benyamin Faraji as India



slipped to 0-2.

Harmeet then tried to put up a fight before succumbing to a 10-12, 15-13, 3-11, 12-10, 2-11 loss to Alamian.

Both Indian men’s and women’s teams will next face Pakistan on Monday. Earlier, India’s men’s and women’s teams began their campaigns with identical 3-0 wins over Indonesia in their respective Group F openers. The women’s team began on a winning note as Sreeja, Diya and Yashaswini swept their Indonesian opponents. Sreeja beat Ni Maharani 3-1 in the opening rubber, recovering from an 8-11 second-game loss to win 11-3, 11-4, 11-4.

Diya then defeated Almaira Nebuchadnezzar 3-0 (11-9, 11-8, 11-5) before Yashaswini sealed the tie with a 3-0 (12-10, 11-4, 11-4) win over Citra Rasmi. The men followed with a dominant 3-0 victory, though they were pushed harder in the second rubber.

Indian hockey teams don saffron jerseys in opening Asian Games matches

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

The Indian hockey teams, both men and women, turned up in saffron kits for their respective opening matches of the Asian Games on Sunday despite the pre-event declaration by Hockey India that they would revert to blue uniforms.

The two Indian teams had first played in saffron during last month’s World Cup in Belgium and the Netherlands, which created a massive controversy. The decision triggered internal discord when HI president Dilip Tirkey stated that the change was implemented without the knowledge or approval of the federation’s elected leadership and Executive Board.

It eventually snowballed into a full-blown turf war in the federation with Tirkey at odds with HI secretary Bhola Nath Singh, who is perceived to have driven the change of kit colour. But soon after the World Cup and just before the Asian Games, Tirkey asserted that India will revert to the iconic blue jersey at the continental extravaganza as their primary kit along with white.



“The Indian Olympic Association (IOA) had given us options regarding the team kit colours and Hockey India selected blue as the first choice for the Indian team’s kit. Orange will be the second choice,” Tirkey had said during the send-off ceremony of Asian Games-bound Indian contingent. But both the men’s and women’s teams turned out in saffron jerseys in their opening matches against Indonesia and Uzbekistan respectively in Kakamigahara (Japan), at the Asian Games on Sunday.

A Hockey India source, requesting anonymity, stated that the secondary kits are not even going to be all-blue but a combination of white and blue along with the saffron

attire.

“The two colours for the Indian teams’ playing kits for the Asian Games 2026 were always saffron and the combination of white and sky blue, which was approved by the HI president himself.

“As to why the president then said that India will wear all-blue at the Asian Games is something you need to ask the president himself,” the HI source said. The rationale provided for changing the jersey colour was that playing in blue jerseys on a blue turf caused visibility issues. The Indian hockey teams have largely worn blue jerseys since the country made its Olympic debut in 1928, except for a few isolated instances.

DAILY SUDOKU

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |  |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|--|---|
|   |   |   | 5 | 2 | 4 |   |  |   |
|   |   |   | 9 |   |   | 5 |  |   |
| 8 |   |   |   |   |   | 2 |  | 1 |
| 3 |   |   |   | 6 | 9 | 8 |  |   |
| 2 |   |   |   |   |   |   |  | 4 |
|   | 1 | 6 | 4 |   |   |   |  | 2 |
| 7 |   | 4 |   |   |   |   |  | 8 |
|   |   | 3 |   |   | 5 |   |  |   |
|   |   |   | 7 | 3 | 9 |   |  |   |

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

No SS2249 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com



| SOLUTION (19.9.26) |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|--------------------|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2                  | 7 | 8 | 4 | 5 | 9 | 1 | 6 | 3 |
| 1                  | 3 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 2 | 4 | 9 |
| 4                  | 6 | 9 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 7 | 8 | 5 |
| 9                  | 8 | 3 | 5 | 6 | 2 | 4 | 7 | 1 |
| 5                  | 2 | 7 | 3 | 4 | 1 | 6 | 9 | 8 |
| 6                  | 1 | 4 | 9 | 8 | 7 | 3 | 5 | 2 |
| 7                  | 9 | 1 | 8 | 2 | 6 | 5 | 3 | 4 |
| 8                  | 4 | 2 | 7 | 3 | 5 | 9 | 1 | 6 |
| 3                  | 5 | 6 | 1 | 9 | 4 | 8 | 2 | 7 |

No SS2249 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD  
MONDAY | SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

|    |    |    |    |    |    |    |  |    |    |    |    |    |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|--|----|----|----|----|----|
|    | 1  |    | 2  |    | 3  | 4  |  | 5  | 6  |    | 7  |    |
| 8  |    |    | 9  |    |    |    |  |    |    | 10 |    |    |
|    |    | 11 |    |    |    | 12 |  |    |    |    |    |    |
| 13 |    |    |    |    | 14 |    |  |    | 15 |    | 16 | 17 |
|    |    |    |    | 18 |    |    |  | 19 |    |    |    |    |
| 20 |    |    | 21 |    |    |    |  |    |    |    |    |    |
| 22 |    |    |    |    |    |    |  |    | 23 |    |    |    |
|    |    |    |    |    | 24 |    |  | 25 |    |    |    |    |
| 26 | 27 |    | 28 |    |    |    |  | 29 |    |    | 30 |    |
| 31 |    |    |    |    |    | 32 |  |    |    | 33 |    |    |
|    |    |    |    |    | 34 |    |  |    |    | 35 |    |    |
| 36 |    |    |    |    |    |    |  | 37 |    |    |    |    |
|    |    |    |    | 38 |    |    |  |    |    |    |    |    |

SOLUTION (19.9.26)

| ACROSS       |             |                |                | DOWN                                                   |                                                   |                                                       |                                                          |
|--------------|-------------|----------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1, A-Scot    | 19, Fount   | 2, Sin-gle     | 15, A-R-got    | 1, Bemoan being thirsty around East Central London (5) | 2, Barnum and Bailey were flashy fellows! (7)     | 4, A strong line to get fish out of the river (4)     | 19, High land where the Poles chop wood to the north (7) |
| 6, Ad-O-re   | 22, Pore    | 3, Odd man     | 16, Tyler      | 2, Being human, they have no tails (5)                 | 3, It's out of the picture! (5)                   | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 20, Zola (possibly reminding one of Heskey?) (5)         |
| 9, Dig-nitty | 24, Yen     | 5, Anita       | 18, S-now-y    | 7, A wild binge may be only human (5)                  | 9, Further in the direction of the job centre (3) | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 21, The way to get frozen, perhaps? (5)                  |
| 10, SN-ide   | 25, Sweater | 6, At-tempt    | 19, Fa-natic   | 9, Further in the direction of the job centre (3)      | 12, They squirm like that chap Leslie (7)         | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 22, Mountains of maps? (5)                               |
| 11, T-each   | 26, Na-St-y | 7, Dyes        | 21, Re-pa-st   | 12, They squirm like that chap Leslie (7)              | 14, Game on the snooker table? (3)                | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 23, Board under pressure (7)                             |
| 12, Sties    | 27, Can it  | 8, Recant      | 22, Par-is-h   | 14, Game on the snooker table? (3)                     | 16, The very best ale I'd brew (5)                | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 24, Such shepherds may know a few words of English (6)   |
| 13, Alban-IA | 28, Aidan   | 12, Si-MO-n    | 23, Re-mark    | 16, The very best ale I'd brew (5)                     | 17, His minced steak is sheer poetry! (5)         | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 25, Wander to the back of the queue with a growl (3)     |
| 15, Ant      | 29, Kippers | 13, Am-it-y    | 25, Steps      | 17, His minced steak is sheer poetry! (5)              |                                                   | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 27, Mountains of maps? (5)                               |
| 17, Mean     | 30, A-TT-ic | 26, Niki (rev) | 26, Niki (rev) |                                                        |                                                   | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 28, Being human, they have no tails (5)                  |
| 18, Sp-or-y  | 31, Khaki   | 28, Ark        | 28, Ark        |                                                        |                                                   | 32, Game calling for much more than a stout heart (4) | 30, It's out of the picture! (5)                         |

Wanted India to know about teqball: Quimcy D'Souza after Asiad defeat

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Nagoya

Self-funded and self-coached for four years, Quimcy D'Souza came to the Asian Games with one dream — to make the country know about the sport of teqball. At least a bronze from the two events she competed in the continental multi-sport event would have largely realised her dream, but still, Quimcy feels she has taken the first steps to take the hitherto unknown sport to a higher level.

Despite playing back-to-back matches with a gap of just five minutes, the 24-year-old was almost on the verge of making history, but lost both her women’s singles and mixed double bronze medal matches here on Sunday.

She pushed the Japanese world No. 7 Yuina Sakamoto to the limit in the women’s singles bronze-medal match, going down 0-2 (11-12, 11-12) to miss a podium finish. Just five minutes later, she turned up again at the



same arena along with Mohamed Anas Beg for another shot at a historic medal in the newly introduced sport. They, however, lost the mixed doubles bronze-medal match against Vietnam’s Hoang Minh Tan Nguyen and Gia Nghh Trinh 0-2 (9-12, 6-12).

“It is hard to take it, the results did not go the way I expected it to be. But I know I gave it my all. I wanted India to know what teqball is all about,” Quimcy told PTI in an interview.

“The journey has just begun. Trust me, I’m not giving up on

this. We’ve just started and there’s a way to go. The medal will come very soon. And I think with the right guidance, more girls can play, please believe in this sport,” she said, while trying to hold back the tears of disappointment.

“I started this sport when nobody knew what teqball is in India. I just fell in love with the sport from the first time I took a touch on the table. As a kid, I always dreamt about playing for the country’s badge on my chest. It’s a very good sport. You’ll enjoy playing it.”

Injury has happened earlier too, now let’s work on comeback: Neeraj Chopra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

India’s star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra termed his absence from the Asian Games unfortunate but said it was important to “accept” the setback and focus on making a quick comeback.

The 28-year-old, who won India’s first Olympic gold medal in athletics with his javelin triumph at Tokyo and followed it up with a silver in Paris, missed out on a chance to complete a hat-trick of Asian Games gold medals after suffering a ligament injury while training.

The injury came soon after Chopra produced a season-best throw of 88.05m at the Lausanne Diamond League, bringing his 2026 competitive



season to an early end and ruling him out of the Asian Games and Diamond League Final. “It is definitely difficult. I wouldn’t say it is easy,” he said on Khelo Bharat Podcast of Sports Authority of India (SAI).

“It has become a little normal for me because this has happened quite a few times in my career. There have been times when I was very well prepared

and suddenly suffered an injury. “Even after winning many things, you still feel that if you had been able to use that time without the injury, perhaps even better things could have happened.” Chopra said the latest injury was particularly frustrating because he felt he had finally returned to his best after recovering from an earlier setback.

# Shafali Verma ton powers India into Asian Games final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Nisshin (Japan)

Reigning champions India stormed into the women's cricket T20I final at the Asian Games for a second successive edition on Sunday, confirming at least a silver medal and taking India's medal tally to four at the continental showpiece.

India already have won two silver medals in shooting and an assured bronze in mixed martial arts, while the women's cricket team added another confirmed medal by advancing to the gold-medal match with a crushing 114-run win over Bangladesh.

Shafali Verma peeled off her maiden T20I century, an

unbeaten 100 off just 49 balls, to power India to a formidable 195 for four after opting to bat. The Bangladesh chase then unravelled almost immediately as wickets fell at regular intervals, with the side eventually bowled out for just 81 in 15.4 overs. It was India's second-biggest win by runs against Bangladesh. India will now face Sri Lanka in the gold-medal match on Tuesday, in a repeat of the last edition's final.

The two sides also clashed in the Women's T20 Asia Cup final last Sunday with India winning by 72 runs.

Sri Lanka defeated Pakistan by eight wickets in the first semifinal on Sunday.

Pakistan will now face



Shafali Verma celebrates her century during the second semifinal T20I cricket match between India women and Bangladesh women in ongoing Asian Games 2026, at Aichi Prefectural Korogi Sports Park in Nisshin, Japan

Bangladesh for the bronze in the first match on Tuesday. Nandani Sharma returned 4-0-25-3 and even came close to taking a hat-trick in the 11th over.

## New test coach Fleming targets England's return to top ranking



ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ London

England's new test cricket coach Stephen Fleming has set his sights on taking the team back to number one in the world for the first time in more than a decade.

The former New Zealand captain was appointed in July but has just taken the reins after sitting out the 3-0 victory over Pakistan due to family commitments.

Fleming immediately made his ultimate aim clear: to lift the side from fifth in the ICC test rankings back to the summit for the first time since 2012 and put right the team's dreadful record in the World Test Championship.

"I would love to be in charge of the number one test team in the world. That would be my aspiration," he said. "There have been some really good moments (for this side) but I think there's more to give."

"One of the dark arts of coaching is timing and my honest appraisal is that it's a great time to be the head coach. It's one of the most prestigious jobs in cricket. I was very honoured to be asked. The opportunity to take up this role was one you don't

turn down."

England have never come close to reaching the WTC final in the four editions since it was launched - and lie sixth in the current table - but Fleming is keen to oversee a change of emphasis when it comes to that competition.

"England could do much better than that," Fleming said. "If that's one of the pinnacle trophies in world cricket, why would we not be trying to get it along with every other marquee event that comes our way? "It's aspirational and that's why I'm here. That opportunity is real, but there's a huge amount of work to do."

That work does not entail convincing former captain Ben Stokes to reverse his dramatic decision to retire from international cricket and play a part in next year's Ashes. Stokes has continued playing for Durham and has also signed up for a stint with Adelaide Strikers in the Big Bash League. And speculation that he might make a grand return for one last crack at Australia next summer refuses to go away.

"I went up to Durham and spoke to Ben, which was good. He's really happy and seemed to be really at peace with his decision," Fleming said.

## Smriti Mandhana becomes leading run-scorer in women's T20Is

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Nisshin (Japan)

India opener Smriti Mandhana became the leading run-scorer in women's T20Is, surpassing New Zealand great Suzie Bates' tally of 4,758 runs during India's Asian Games semifinal against Bangladesh, here on Sunday.

The 30-year-old elegant left-hander needed seven runs to break the record as she reached the landmark in the third over, hammering Bangladesh pacer Marufa Akter for back-to-back boundaries off the final two deliveries of the over. Mandhana eventually made a 19-ball 37, smashing



Smriti Mandhana plays a shot during the second semifinal T20I cricket match between India women and Bangladesh women in the ongoing Asian Games 2026, at Aichi Prefectural Korogi Sports Park in Nisshin, Japan

five fours and two sixes, before her quickfire cameo ended on the final ball of powerplay.

Trying to finish the powerplay with another maximum, Mandhana miscued a slog sweep off Akter and was caught by Sobhana Mostary at deep mid-wicket.

By then she had already taken the record outright, moving to the top of the women's T20I run charts with 4,788 runs.

Suzie Bates (4,758) and Indian skipper Harmanpreet Kaur (4,287) and Sri Lankan captain Chamari Athapaththu (4,282)

Mandhana's record also means India now have two

good effect, both the Indian openers were off to a flier and put on 72 runs for the first wicket. Shafali and Mandhana matched each other stroke by stroke while taking the attack to the Bangladeshi bowlers, who had no response to their aggressive approach.

However, the pair was separated right when the powerplay, which they had dominated really well, was about to end.

Nahida Akter had induced a false stroke from Mandhana who looked to slog sleep a delivery, and had her caught behind by Sobhana Mostary.

Mandhana, however, entered the record books on Sunday as she went past New Zealand great Suzie

Bates' tally of 4,758 runs in women's T20Is.

India did not find much from their No. 3 Gunalan Kamalini, who fell soon after for a laborious 10-ball 3 on a wicket where run-making had been rather easier for the batters. Shafali, on the other hand, kept cruising on the other end. She seemed to be effortlessly clearing the boundaries while hitting nine sixes and only three fours, but had to wait until the final over of India's innings to bring up her century. Harmanpreet pierced the gaps with precision to make 40 off 33 balls but it was her 94-run stand off only 55 balls with Shafali which took the game away from Bangladesh.

## Sooryavanshi is different kind of talent, future for India: Jayasuriya

SUMAN RAY  
■ Gurgaon

Former Sri Lankan captain Sanath Jayasuriya on Sunday rated teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi a "different kind of talent" but advised against rushing him into India's playing 11.

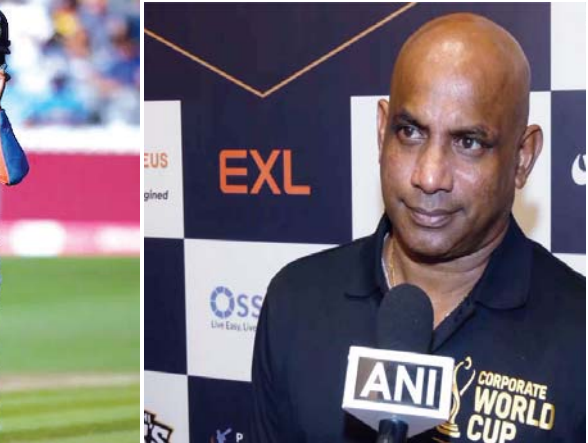
Sooryavanshi was in India's squad for the recent three-match T20I series against Afghanistan but the management stuck to the regular opening combination of Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma.

"He's a different kind of talent. I think he's the future for India. He has a lot of time. So, give him the opportunity to do well and he will do well," Jayasuriya told PTI on the sidelines of the launch of



the Corporate World Cup here.

The star performer of the 1996 World Cup for Sri Lanka said Sooryavanshi has the talent to grab the opportunities.



"Opportunities will come. I can't tell which position he will play, it depends. But when the opportunity comes, he will grab them. So, let's wait and see. "I can't comment on the

selection and the batting line-ups. I think he is highly talented," said the prolific all-rounder of yesteryears.

In that context, Jayasuriya said Abhishek and Samson need to keep performing.

## India T20I a major opportunity to boost cricket's profile in Japan: JCA COO Curr

HIMANK NEGI  
■ New Delhi

Japan Cricket Association COO Alan Curr on Sunday hoped that the historic maiden T20I against India will boost the sport's profile in his country, helping it to take a firm step towards achieving global recognition.

Reigning T20I world champions India will face Japan at the Sano International Cricket Ground on Tuesday, and the match will be live on FanCode, the official broadcaster of the contest. "The boys are excited. An opportunity like this doesn't come around very often for us," Curr responded to a query during a joint media interaction.

Curr remained optimistic that the India fixture can become a starting point for Japan to host more established cricket nations in the future. "We're trying to take all of this as part of the steps we're taking to try and do that," Curr said, referring to Japan's future ambitions.

"In terms of the mainstream in Japan, it's certainly piquing interest. It's easy to say that the reigning world champions are coming to

Japan to play against our team. But we've still got a long way to go," he said.

The immediate challenge was that Japan has never



hosted a cricket match of this scale. The JCA had to transform the Sano ground over the last few days, adding temporary seating, VIP areas, ticket gates besides enhancing the security arrangements.

The ground normally has permanent seating for around 500 spectators.

The association has also brought in a security consultant from England who has worked at World Cups, The Hundred and events involving India. "We are taking all of this very seriously, and I think it's really important for us to show that we have the capacity to handle something like this," Curr said.

The weather, however, remains a concern, with a typhoon potentially threatening the preparations.

"Right now, success will be getting a game on. I'm not going to lie, there is a gigantic typhoon just to the south of Japan right now, so that's the concern," Curr said.

But India's visit has already sparked massive interest in the country, and for Curr, it's a success in itself.

"I think a lot of the success has almost already happened. The fact that India has agreed to come, the fact that I'm sitting here talking to you guys, the fact that there's already a lot of Japanese media coming tomorrow to find out more about this game and about the sport - I think success is already here," he said. India's visit is also the result of a longer-term effort by the JCA to upgrade its facilities and attract leading cricket

nations to Sano.

The association relaid its turf square this year using the same clay that was used for the Asian Games facility in Nagoya. Curr said the aim was to create a venue capable of hosting top international teams and provide them with a training option when they are in Japan.

"We were quite keen to try and host the Asian Games here, but unfortunately that wasn't possible. So, finding reasons to attract full members to come here became important," he said.

"Once we had the pitch laid in March this year, we started preparing a proposal to send out to all the full members."

Those efforts eventually led to discussions with the BCCI, which Curr said moved quickly after the proposal was circulated.

Japan's registered player base has grown to 8,800 from around 3,000 when Curr joined the JCA in 2014. The Japan Cup, the country's regional T20 competition, has expanded to more than 80 teams, while the Japan Cricket League (JCL) now has four divisions with over 30 teams. Curr said the JCA's focus on junior cricket and making top-level cricket more accessible were central to the sport's growth.

## Yashasvi Jaiswal should get enough chances as backup opener before 2027 WC: Irfan Pathan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan feels Yashasvi Jaiswal should be given enough opportunities in the upcoming ODI series against the West Indies to establish himself as the team's backup opener ahead of next year's ODI World Cup.

India will face the West Indies in a three-match ODI series from September 27 to October 3, with the home season beginning in Thiruvananthapuram.

Pathan said the series presents India with an opportu-



nity to test its bench strength, with several regular players unavailable due to their participation in the Asian Games.

"This is not the main team

against the West Indies for the ODIs, and I feel that's the right way to go. Bumrah is not there, Shreyas, Axar, and Washington Sundar are all playing at the Asian Games.

## India maul Uzbekistan 19-0 in Asiad women's hockey, Deepika Sehrawat scores eight goals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Kakamilgahara (Japan)

Young striker Deepika Sehrawat slammed in a record-shattering eight goals as the Indian women's hockey team hammered lowly Uzbekistan 19-0 in its opening Pool B match to make a flying start at the Asian Games, here on Sunday.

It was expected to be a one-sided affair and it turned out exactly that way as Uzbekistan defence had no answer to India's relentless attacks.

The gulf between the two sides was



evident throughout and it rained goals from India with the 22-year-old Deepika leading the way by striking in the 8th,

You are going to get only a few matches before the World Cup next year, and in those games, you want to test your bench strength as well," Pathan told jioHotstar.

"With the Asian Games and the West Indies series happening simultaneously, it's a blessing in disguise, where a lot of young boys will definitely get a chance," he added. The 41-year-old from Vadodara particularly wants Jaiswal to make the most of his opportunities, saying the opener should have sufficient international exposure before the World Cup in South Africa.

22nd, 25th, 33rd, 36th, 38th, 41st, 54th minute. This was the best performance by an Indian woman player in a single Asian Games match. The rising drag-flick specialist has been in good form since coming back from injuries earlier this year.

Mid-fielder Ishika Chaudhary (11th, 42nd, 54th), Lalremsiam (7th), Baljeet Kaur (12th), Neha (18th), Navneet Kaur (23rd, 45th), Lalhantluangi (43rd, 51st), and Sakshi Rana (43rd) were the other goal-getters in the lop-sided contest.

India will play Indonesia in their next match on Monday.